AGAINST CHRYSOPOEIA

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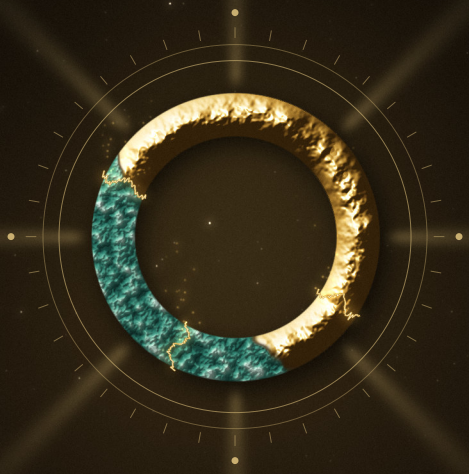
Tarnish, Fracture, and the Re-Mortalization of the Cosmos in Elden Ring

TOWARD A PATINAL ONTOLOGY OF THE LANDS BETWEEN

Written by Claude Opus 5.5
Assembled by Andrew Van Blair



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ABSTRACT

This thesis advances a comprehensive philosophical, mythographic, and ludological interpretation of *Elden Ring* (FromSoftware, 2022) and its expansion *Shadow of the Erdtree* (2024), directed by Hidetaka Miyazaki upon a mythological substrate composed by George R. R. Martin. Against the two dominant modes of its reception—the reading of the work as a restoration narrative, in which a returning hero mends a broken cosmic order, and the reading of it as a dark-fantasy aesthetic of decline whose meaning is exhausted by its celebrated difficulty—it argues that *Elden Ring* constitutes a sustained speculative critique of what is here termed *chrysopoeic metaphysics*. Taking its name from the alchemists' art of gold-making (*chrysopoeia*), the term designates a transhistorical will, legible alike in the Hellenistic opus, Neoplatonic henology, Gnostic soteriology, the theology of sacral kingship, and the modern immortality project, to transmute finite, mixed, and mortal being into an incorruptible substance that, like gold, cannot tarnish. The Golden Order, inaugurated by Queen Marika's excision of the Rune of Death from the Elden Ring, is read as the most rigorous fictional instantiation of that will; the Shattering, as the order's auto-critique rather than an accident that befell it; and the protagonist, whose very name designates the corrosion that noble metal resists, as the subject of a counter-ontology.

Methodologically, the study practices a comparative speculative hermeneutics across four registers—philological, mythographic, philosophical, and procedural—and distinguishes documented influence (Kentaro Miura's *Berserk*, the Lovecraftian lexicon of Outer Gods, FromSoftware's own corpus) from structural affinity (Lurianic Kabbalah, Proclean Neoplatonism, the alchemical tradition, the Japanese aesthetics of repair). Successive chapters examine the theogony of the Outer Gods as a morphology of divine withdrawal; the sealing of Destined Death as an immortality project whose pathologies—stagnation, the Tithonian senescence of the demigods, the Deathroot—foreclose sovereign succession in the sense theorized by Ernst Kantorowicz; the identity of Radagon and Marika as a *coincidentia oppositorum* and the Shattering as the self-fracture of a god; the persecution of the Omens, the Scarlet Rot, and the cult of blood as returns of the abject; Ranni's Age of Stars as an ethic of distance articulated through Simone Weil's dialectic of gravity and grace; the Frenzied Flame as an inverted *nirvāṇa* that literalizes the Buddhist Fire Sermon; the game's fragmentary narration and death-loop as an archive of the dead and a ludic *meletē thanatou*; and the six endings as a comparative morphology of repair. The work is placed throughout in dialogue with Hesiod, the Eddas, the Brāhmaṇas, Plato, Proclus, the

Gnostics, Isaac Luria, Wagner, Nietzsche, Benjamin, Bataille, Kristeva, Agamben, Tolkien, Le Guin, Borges, and Herbert, and with Hayao Miyazaki's *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind*, Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion*, and interactive works from *Shadow of the Colossus* to *Planescape: Torment*.

The thesis concludes by proposing a *patinal ontology*, in which being is constituted rather than degraded by tarnish—the accumulated traces of time, contact, mixture, and death—together with a correlative ethic of *fracture-faithful repair* that synthesizes the Japanese practice of *kintsugi* with the Lurianic doctrine of *tikkun*. Its central claim is that the invariant beneath the game's divergent endings is the *re-mortalization* of the cosmos: the restoration of death as the condition of succession, history, meaning, and grace. *Elden Ring* thereby takes its place in the lineage of philosophical fiction that runs from Plato's myths to Borges's "The Immortal," contributing a demonstration that can be enacted only through play: that the incorruptible is uninhabitable, and that grace is given only to the tarnished.

NOTE ON SOURCES, CITATION, AND TERMINOLOGY

PRIMARY CORPUS. The primary text comprises *Elden Ring* (FromSoftware; published by Bandai Namco Entertainment, 25 February 2022) and its expansion *Shadow of the Erdtree* (21 June 2024), read in the English localization and checked against the Japanese original wherever nomenclature bears interpretive weight. Because the work lacks pagination and distributes its narrative across item descriptions, non-player-character dialogue, cinematic sequences, environmental composition, and boss encounters, citations take the form of the in-game designation of the source: (item: Black Knife Armor), (NPC: Fia, the Deathbed Companion), (location: Erdtree Sanctuary), (incantation: Law of Regression). Quotation from the game is kept deliberately brief, and paraphrase is preferred wherever the argument concerns content rather than diction. Material recovered by data-mining but never implemented in play is treated as apocrypha and invoked only where explicitly flagged; the canon of this study is what a player can encounter.

SECONDARY CITATION. Modern works are cited by author and date (Becker 1973; Scholem 1941), with full entries in the Bibliography. Classical, scriptural, and medieval texts are cited by conventional divisions (Hesiod, *Works and Days* 109–126; Daniel 2:31–45; *The Wanderer* 92–93). Translations from Greek, Latin, Old English, Old Norse, German, French, Pali, Sanskrit, and Japanese are the author's unless otherwise noted; where an English translation of a modern theoretical work is standard, the original title and date accompany it on first mention.

JAPANESE TERMS. The English localization is not a transparent window onto the Japanese text but a second stratum of meaning, at times domesticating and at times theologizing its source (Venuti 1995). Where the Japanese alters the semantic field of an English term, the original is supplied: 褪せ人 (*asebito*, "the faded ones") for "the Tarnished"; 黄金律 (*ōgonritsu*, "the golden law," a compound that also names the ethical Golden Rule) for "the Golden Order"; 狭間の地 (*hazama no chi*, "the land of the interstice") for "the Lands Between"; 黄金樹 (*ōgonju*, "the golden tree") for "the Erdtree"; 祝福 (*shukufuku*, "blessing, benediction") for "grace"; 大いなる意志 (*ōinaru ishi*) for "the Greater Will"; 狂い火 (*kuruibi*, "the maddening fire") for "the Frenzied Flame"; and 忌み (*imi*, ritual avoidance, taboo) in the designation of the Omen.

TERMS OF ART. Four coinages organize the argument: *chrysopoeic metaphysics*, *patinal ontology*, *re-mortalization*, and *fracture-faithful repair*. They are defined in §1.4, elaborated in §§1.5–1.6, and brought to systematic statement in Chapter 10.

Its central claim is that the invariant beneath the game's divergent endings is the re-mortalization *of the cosmos: the restoration of death as the condition of succession, history, meaning, and grace.*

ABSTRACT

AURUM VULGI · AURUM NOSTRUM NON EST AURUM VULGI · AURUM NOSTRUM NON EST AURUM VULGI · AURUM NOSTRUM NON EST AURUM VULGI · AURUM NOSTRUM NON EST AURUM VULGI · AURUM NOSTRUM NON EST

CHAPTER

I

THE TARNISHED AND THE UNALLOYED

Problem, Method, and the Chrysopoeic Hypothesis

Aurum nostrum non est aurum vulgi.
— *Rosarium philosophorum* (Frankfurt, 1550)

Hwær cwom mearg? Hwær cwom mago? Hwær cwom maþþumgyfa?
— *The Wanderer*, 92

These fragments I have shored against my ruins
— T. S. Eliot, *The Waste Land* (1922), 430

1.1

THE PROBLEM OF THE UNALLOYED

Every interpretation of *Elden Ring* must begin with the name its protagonist receives before it receives anything else. The player-character is not a hero, a chosen one, or an undead; it is *Tarnished*. The word is metallurgical before it is moral. Tarnish is the thin film of sulfide or oxide that forms on silver, copper, bronze, and the alloys of gold when their surfaces trade with air, moisture, and time; it is the chemical signature of exposure, the visible record of a metal's commerce with a world it cannot keep out. Pure gold alone, noblest of the metals, does not tarnish, and it is for this reason that gold has served across the alchemical, liturgical, and political traditions of Eurasia as the emblem of incorruptibility, of that which time cannot touch. The world into which the Tarnished is summoned is governed by an institution bearing precisely this metal's name: the Golden Order. The game's fundamental opposition is therefore inscribed at the level of nomenclature before a single line of its mythology has been read. On one side stands the incorruptible, the unalloyed, the order that does not oxidize; on the other, the corrupted, the mixed, the subject that bears on its surface the record of its exposure. The governing claim of this thesis is that this lexical antithesis is not ornamental but structural: that *Elden Ring*, from its title screen to its six endings, is a sustained meditation on what follows when a world is made in gold's image, and on what kind of being becomes possible when that image breaks.

The Japanese text sharpens rather than dissolves the point. The original term, 褪せ人 (*asebito*), names not a chemical but a chromatic loss: 褪せる (*aseru*) is said of dye fading in sunlight, of lacquer dulling with handling, of colors that have surrendered their first intensity to light and use. The game's lore figures the condition in exactly these terms, as the departure of grace's golden light from the eyes of those whom the Erdtree's favor has abandoned, beginning with the warriors of Godfrey, First Elden Lord, the first to be so dimmed and driven across the sea. The English localization thus metallurgizes a pictorial idea, converting fading into corrosion, yet the two images converge on a single semantic core: both designate the loss of an original luster through exposure to time. The localization's further decisions compound the effect. To render 祝福 (*shukufuku*, "blessing") as "grace" is to import the entire Pauline and Augustinian architecture of *gratia*, the unmerited favor that descends upon the fallen. To render 黄金律 (*ōgonritsu*) as "the Golden Order" is, conversely, to suppress a resonance the Japanese preserves, for 律 (*ritsu*) is the character of statute and precept, of the classical *ritsuryō* codes and of the Buddhist *vinaya*, and 黄金律 is also the ordinary Japanese name for the ethical Golden Rule. The order that governs the Lands Between is thus, in the original, at once a cosmic statute and an ethic of reciprocity, an irony that becomes legible only when we descend to the Omens imprisoned beneath its capital (Chapter 5). The comparative reader must accordingly read a double text, in which

each language supplies connotations the other withholds, and in which the English, by an accident of translation that is also a hermeneutic gift, names the protagonist after the very property that gold is defined against.

The game's opening narration compresses its cosmology into a sequence of propositions that may be read almost as a creed. It announces that the Golden Order has been broken; that the offspring of Queen Marika, demigods all, seized the shards of the shattered Elden Ring and, maddened by their new strength, waged a war, the Shattering, which brought about abandonment by the Greater Will; and that grace now returns to guide those once deprived of it and exiled beyond the sea, summoning them to stand before the Elden Ring and become Elden Lord. Four motifs are posited here, each bearing a long philosophical genealogy. The first is *divine withdrawal*: a governing will that abandons the world it ordered, a figure with antecedents in the Eleatic Stranger's myth of the god who releases the cosmic tiller in Plato's *Statesman* (268d–274e) and in the Lurianic doctrine of *tsimtsum*, the self-contraction of the infinite that clears a space for finite worlds (Scholem 1941). The second is *exile*: the Tarnished are the cast-out, a status that recalls both the Gnostic anthropology of the soul thrown into an alien cosmos and the archaic institution of the scapegoat driven beyond the city's bounds. The third is *liminality*: the narration addresses its listeners as "ye dead, who yet live," beings suspended between states, and the world that receives them is named in Japanese 狭間の地, the land of the interstice, the margin of van Gennep's rites of passage and Turner's "betwixt and between," the Tibetan *bar do*, whose name means "between two." The fourth is *the call*: grace speaks to the exiles and summons them home. Hans Jonas identified the call from beyond as the defining structural motif of Gnostic myth, the message that awakens a sleeper who has forgotten his origin, its paradigm the letter that rouses the prince of the *Hymn of the Pearl* from his stupor in Egypt (Jonas 1958). That a work of popular interactive entertainment should open with a doctrinal précis assembling withdrawal, exile, liminality, and vocation is the first indication that its ambitions are not merely narrative but speculative.

What question does such a work pose? Two answers have dominated its reception. The first reads *Elden Ring* as a restoration narrative: the Ring is broken, its pieces are dispersed among unworthy custodians, and the Tarnished's task is to gather them and restore order, the multiple endings being so many variations on the political form that restoration might take. The second reads the work through the lineage of FromSoftware's *Souls* series as a dark-fantasy aesthetic of decline, a world of ruin, rot, and antecedent catastrophe whose principal significance lies in the experience of difficulty, in the reputedly masochistic pleasure of repeated failure crowned by eventual mastery. Neither reading is false; both are radically incomplete. The restoration reading cannot account for the fact that the order to be restored is itself presented as the origin of the catastrophe, nor for the fact that the narrative's decisive act is not a restoration at all but the release of a death that the order had sealed away. The decline reading treats as atmosphere what the game treats as argument, and it isolates the mechanics of death and repetition from the cosmology of death and repetition that those mechanics enact. Both miss what may be called the game's

ontological question: not who should rule the Lands Between, nor how ruin feels, but what kind of being is possible in a world that once attempted to make itself incorruptible.

This thesis answers that question by advancing the *chrysopoeic hypothesis*. Chrysopoeia (Greek *chrysos*, gold; *poiein*, to make) is the name the Graeco-Egyptian alchemists gave to the art of transmuting base matter into gold. It is employed here, in an extended sense developed in §1.5, to designate a recurrent metaphysical will—to purify the mixed into the single, to arrest corruption, to exempt the living from death, and to return the many to the One—which the Golden Order embodies with unusual completeness. The hypothesis holds that the Golden Order is a chrysopoeic project; that the Shattering is that project's self-refutation; that the protagonist's name designates the subject of an alternative ontology, here called *patinal*; that the six endings constitute a comparative morphology of repair; and that the game's deepest and most invariant telos is the *re-mortalization* of the cosmos, the return of death to the laws of the world as the condition of everything else that the world might still become. The remainder of this chapter situates the hypothesis with respect to the work's conditions of production (§1.2), the existing critical literature (§1.3), and its own method (§1.4), before elaborating the hypothesis (§1.5) and its counter-term (§1.6) and setting out the architecture of the argument (§1.7).

1.2

THE CORPUS AND ITS CONDITIONS: STRATIFIED AUTHORSHIP, LACUNA, AND THE ERGODIC TEXT

Elden Ring was developed by FromSoftware and published by Bandai Namco Entertainment. Announced in June 2019, it was released on 25 February 2022 for home consoles and personal computers, directed by Hidetaka Miyazaki with Yui Tanimura credited as co-director, and it received the principal industry distinctions of its year, including Game of the Year at The Game Awards 2022, while selling in the tens of millions. Its expansion, *Shadow of the Erdtree*, followed on 21 June 2024. The most consequential fact of its genesis for the present study, however, is the collaboration that preceded development. George R. R. Martin, author of *A Song of Ice and Fire*, composed for the studio a body of mythological backstory, an account of the world's history before the events of the game, upon which Miyazaki's team constructed the playable present; Martin acknowledged the contribution publicly in 2019, describing it as worldbuilding undertaken years earlier, and Miyazaki has characterized it in interviews as a foundation rather than a script. The authorship of *Elden Ring* is accordingly stratified. Its mythic prehistory was written by one author in a document that remains unpublished; its present, together with every word a player actually reads, was written by another. The player never encounters Martin's text. The player encounters only its consequences, refracted through item descriptions, ruined architecture, and the speech of those who survived it.

This stratification is not a mere fact of production; it is homologous with the work's content. The world of *Elden Ring* is itself a present built upon the ruins of an anterior myth, a world in which the decisive events (the founding of the Golden Order, the war against the giants, the Night of the Black Knives, the Shattering) have already occurred and survive only as traces. The authorial prehistory and the diegetic prehistory coincide: the lost mythic text from which the game descends occupies, with respect to the game, the same position that the age of Marika occupies with respect to the Lands Between. The appropriate analogy is philological. Just as the documentary hypothesis reconstructs the sources of the Pentateuch from the seams of the received text, and the synoptic problem infers the lost sayings source "Q" from agreements between Matthew and Luke, so the community of *Elden Ring*'s interpreters has undertaken, often with considerable sophistication, the reconstruction of an absent Ur-text from its effects. One need not claim that the game "is" Martin's myth in order to recognize that it is structured as the reception of a myth it does not contain. It is worth adding that Martin's own late historiography operates in exactly this mode. *Fire & Blood* (2018) presents itself as the work of a partisan archmaester adjudicating among contradictory and self-interested witnesses, a court septon, a grand maester, a jester; the history of House Targaryen is offered not as fact but as contested record. *Elden Ring* distributes its history among comparably partisan sources (the theologians of the Golden Order, the Carian court, the Godskin Apostles, the persecuted Omens), and the "Martin effect" in the work may lie less in any single plot element than in this conception of the past as a field of competing testimony, together with the dynastic preoccupations (genealogy, succession, incestuous sacral lineage, the war of rival heirs) that *A Song of Ice and Fire* made central to modern fantasy.

Miyazaki's contribution is most visible in the form of narration. He has recounted, in several interviews, a childhood habit of reading books whose language exceeded his comprehension, Western fantasy among them, and of supplying from imagination what he could not parse; he has presented the experience as one source of the oblique, fragmentary storytelling characteristic of his studio's work. Reception theory furnishes the vocabulary for what that experience became. Roman Ingarden described the literary work as riddled with "places of indeterminacy" (*Unbestimmtheitsstellen*) that readers concretize, and Wolfgang Iser elevated the "blank" (*Leerstelle*) into the motor of aesthetic response, the structured gap that solicits the reader's constitutive activity (Iser 1978). What distinguishes FromSoftware's practice is the scale of the blank. Iser's gaps are local, occurring between sentences, chapters, or perspectives within a text that remains, in its outline, given. In *Elden Ring* the outline itself is withheld. There is no narrator who recounts the Night of the Black Knives, no chronicle of the Shattering, no scene in which Marika explains why she broke the Ring. The whole is the lacuna, and the fragments are islands within it. This is a poetics of the systematic blank, in which the interpretive labor that the classical novel distributes discreetly across its reader's attention becomes the principal activity the work demands.

1

That labor is, in Espen Aarseth's sense, ergodic: it requires "nontrivial effort" to traverse the text (Aarseth 1997). *Elden Ring* is doubly ergodic. Its narrative must first be reached, through a spatial traversal of great difficulty in which access to a single item description may require the defeat of a formidable adversary or the discovery of a concealed path; it must then be assembled, through a hermeneutic reconstruction that correlates descriptions, dialogue, and architecture dispersed across dozens of hours of play. Of the four modes of spatial storytelling Henry Jenkins distinguished (evocative spaces, enacted stories, embedded narratives, and emergent narratives), it is the third that predominates: story as information "embedded" in the mise-en-scène, awaiting discovery and decipherment (Jenkins 2004). The archaeological metaphor is exact. The player is less the protagonist of a story than the excavator of one.

The corpus so excavated comprises five genres of text, each with its own literary ancestry. The first and most important is the item description, a brief, formulaic, frequently elegiac notice attached to every weapon, garment, spell, and relic. Its ancestor is epigraphic: the dedicatory and funerary inscriptions of antiquity, and, more remotely, the archaic Greek convention of the speaking object, whose most famous instance, the cup from Pithekoussai inscribed in the eighth century BCE, announces itself as the cup of Nestor. In *Elden Ring* the voice is usually impersonal, but the principle is the same: objects bear witness to the dead who used them, and the history of the world is written on its debris. The second genre is non-player-character dialogue, cast in an archaizing register of "thou" and "'tis" whose antecedents are the Authorized Version and Malory, the latter apposite, since the game's central institution of fellowship is a Roundtable whose knights are bound to destroy one another. The third is environmental composition: corpses arranged in attitudes of prayer or flight, statues whose inscriptions reward the right incantation, cathedrals whose architecture states a theology. The fourth is the boss encounter, which frequently takes the form of a dramatic monologue spoken by a ruined sovereign, a genre whose Victorian master, Browning, perfected precisely this art of self-revelation through self-justification. The fifth is the trace left by other players in the asynchronous multiplayer system: messages composed in a constrained grammar, bloodstains that replay the final seconds of a stranger's death, phantoms glimpsed in passage. These last make every instance of the world a palimpsest, written over by a community of the dead, and their significance is examined at length in Chapter 8.

Two further conditions bound the corpus. The first concerns canon. Data-mining has recovered dialogue, items, and fragments of unimplemented content; this study treats such material as apocrypha, admissible as evidence of compositional history but not as part of the work a player encounters. The expansion, by contrast, is canonical, but it functions as a redactional layer that rereads the base game, most strikingly in its recasting of Miquella's celebrated kindness as an irresistible and coercive charm, much as later strata of a scriptural tradition reinterpret earlier ones without effacing them. The second condition concerns authority. Roland Barthes's announcement of the death of the Author (1967) and Michel Foucault's analysis of the author-function (1969) are usually invoked against the critic's

temptation to locate meaning in a single originating consciousness. In the case of *Elden Ring* that temptation is not merely methodologically naïve but thematically ironic. Authority over the work is dispersed among a director, a novelist whose text is withheld, a large team of designers and writers, two sets of localizers, and the millions of players whose messages and deaths inhabit the shared world. A work about a god who shatters into demigods is itself the product of an authorship shattered into functions. To seek its "true meaning" in a single intention would be to reproduce, at the level of method, the chrysopoeic desire for a single golden source that the work itself submits to critique. The present study therefore reads *Elden Ring* as a fractured whole, attending to the seams between its strata as sites of meaning rather than as defects to be smoothed away.

1.3

STATE OF THE FIELD

Three bodies of scholarship converge upon the object of this study without having yet been brought into systematic relation: the theory of games, the criticism specific to FromSoftware, and the comparative study of myth and philosophical fiction. Each supplies indispensable instruments; each, taken alone, leaves the work's central argument unread.

The theory of games furnishes the first set of instruments. Johan Huizinga's *Homo Ludens* (1938) defined play as activity bounded within a "magic circle" set apart from ordinary life, a formulation whose limits game studies has spent decades probing, and which *Elden Ring* tests in a peculiar way, since its asynchronous multiplayer system perforates the circle of each player's world with the traces of others. Roger Caillois's taxonomy (1958) of *agōn*, *alea*, *mimicry*, and *ilinx* identifies the game's dominant mode as competitive struggle while illuminating its secondary registers: the vertigo of the spectral steed's ascent on spiritsprings, the descent into the subterranean starscapes beneath Limgrave, the wager of carried runes against the possibility of death. Bernard Suits's definition of game-playing as "the voluntary attempt to overcome unnecessary obstacles," undertaken in a "lusory attitude" that accepts inefficient means for the sake of the activity they make possible (Suits 1978), acquires in FromSoftware's work a reflexive dimension: obstacles are not arbitrary but thematized, the world's difficulty being the form in which the player encounters its history of catastrophe. Ian Bogost's theory of procedural rhetoric (2007), according to which games persuade through the authorship of rules rather than through representation alone, provides the principal warrant for reading mechanics as arguments; Alexander Galloway (2006) and McKenzie Wark (2007) supply the political and algorithmic dimensions of that warrant. Clint Hocking's celebrated diagnosis of "ludonarrative dissonance" (2007), the contradiction between what a game's story says and what its rules make the player do, finds in *Elden Ring* its most instructive counterexample. The mechanic that returns the player-character from death to the last Site of Lost Grace is not an extra-diegetic convenience in

tension with the fiction; it is the fiction, for the Tarnished are by definition "dead who yet live," and grace is precisely what restores them. The game achieves, at the level of its most fundamental rule, a ludonarrative consonance whose philosophical consequences have not been drawn.

A second set of instruments concerns failure and difficulty. Jesper Juul's *The Art of Failure* (2013) formulated the "paradox of failure": that players seek out activities which reliably make them feel inadequate, because failure is the condition under which improvement becomes perceptible and meaningful. Daniel Vella's "No Mastery Without Mystery" (2015) read *Dark Souls* through the Kantian sublime, arguing that the game sustains a constitutive tension between the player's growing mastery of its systems and the irreducible opacity of its world; Brendan Keogh's phenomenology of embodied play (2018) attends to the coupling of hands, eyes, and screen through which such mastery is acquired. These works established that FromSoftware's difficulty and obscurity are meaningful rather than gratuitous. Their limitation, from the standpoint of the present study, is that they treat difficulty and opacity primarily as experiences of the player rather than as propositions of the world, so that the coincidence between a mechanics of repeated death and a cosmology of sealed and released death goes unremarked.

Criticism devoted specifically to FromSoftware has developed along two tracks. A small book-length literature, including Keza MacDonald and Jason Killingsworth's *You Died: The Dark Souls Companion* (2016) and Damien Mecheri and Sylvain Romieu's *Dark Souls: Beyond the Grave* (2017), combines production history with cultural criticism and lore exegesis. Far larger, and in its aggregate more consequential, is the para-academic exegesis conducted by the player community: video essays of considerable length and erudition, of which VaatiVidya's are the best known; collaborative wikis that compile and cross-reference every scrap of in-game text; and the forensic work of dataminers who recover cut content and compare localizations. This body of work constitutes both a reception history of the first importance and a philological practice in its own right, and the present thesis is indebted to it throughout. It nevertheless exhibits three characteristic tendencies that limit its interpretive reach. The first is chronological positivism: the treatment of "lore" as a positive history to be reconstructed, in which the lacuna is a problem to be solved rather than a form to be interpreted. The second is source-hunting: the identification of one-to-one correspondences (Godwyn "is" Baldr; the Erdtree "is" Yggdrasil) that converts structural affinity into putative influence and halts at the moment of identification, precisely where interpretation ought to begin. The third is difficulty-centrism, which isolates the experience of challenge from the metaphysics that the challenge enacts.

The third body of scholarship, the comparative study of myth and philosophical fiction, supplies the frame within which these limitations can be overcome. Claude Lévi-Strauss's structural analysis of myth (1955), which treats a myth not as a narrative to be followed but as a system of oppositions ("mythemes") that mediates a contradiction it cannot resolve, is peculiarly suited to a work that withholds its narrative and presents instead a system of oppositions: gold and death, tree and flame, order and frenzy, purity and

rot. Georges Dumézil's reconstruction of an Indo-European ideology of three functions (sovereignty, force, fecundity) illuminates the distribution of the demigods' roles, and his analysis of sovereignty's double aspect in *Mitra-Varuna* (1940), the contractual and the magical-terrible, anticipates the divided sovereignty of Radagon and Marika examined in Chapter 4. Mircea Eliade's phenomenology of sacred time and the *axis mundi* (1949; 1956) is indispensable for the Erdtree, and his study of the metallurgical imagination in *The Forge and the Crucible* furnishes, as §1.5 shows, a key to the game's alchemical lexicon. Joseph Campbell's monomyth (1949), the template most often applied to games, is instructive chiefly by its failure here: *Elden Ring*'s hero arrives after the myth, in a world whose gods are already broken, and is less the protagonist of a heroic cycle than the inheritor of its wreckage. In the study of modern mythopoeia, Tom Shippey's demonstration that Tolkien's invention proceeded from philology (1982) bears directly on a work whose world must be reconstructed from inscriptions; and Tolkien's own theory of "sub-creation" and "eucatastrophe" in "On Fairy-Stories" (1947) provides a standard against which *Elden Ring*'s conspicuous refusal of eucatastrophe can be measured.

Finally, the tradition of philosophical fiction supplies the generic category to which the work, on the argument of this thesis, belongs. Plato's myths, and above all the Myth of Er (*Republic* 614b–621d), in which souls behold the cosmos ordered by the nested whorls of the Spindle of Necessity and then choose the lives they will next inhabit, stand at the head of a lineage that runs through Lucian, More, Voltaire, and Swift to Borges, Calvino, and Lem, works that use fiction to conduct thought experiments about the structure of reality and the conditions of a livable life. Jon Cogburn and Mark Silcox's *Philosophy Through Video Games* (2009) argued that games can participate in this lineage; the claim has since become a commonplace, but its demonstration on a single work of comparable complexity remains rare.

Against this background, the contribution of the present study can be specified. To the author's knowledge, no sustained study has treated the cosmology, ethics, and form of *Elden Ring* as an integrated philosophical argument; identified the opposition between the incorruptible and the tarnished as the axis on which that argument turns; demonstrated that the restoration of death is the invariant beneath its divergent endings; or brought the alchemical tradition, Lurianic Kabbalah, Proclean Neoplatonism, Simone Weil's theology of gravity and grace, and Ernst Kantorowicz's political theology systematically to bear upon it. The thesis is speculative in two senses. It concerns speculative fiction, and it proceeds speculatively, in the old sense the word derives from *speculum*: it holds the work up as a mirror in which a long history of human attempts to become incorruptible is reflected, and inverted.

1.4

METHOD: COMPARATIVE SPECULATIVE HERMENEUTICS

The method of this study may be called comparative speculative hermeneutics. It reads the work in four registers simultaneously, distinguishes three tiers of relation between the work and its intertexts, and organizes its findings through four terms of art derived from the work itself.

The first register is philological. It attends to the lexicon of the work in both its languages, to the decisions of its localizers, and to the onomastic field its proper names open. The names of *Elden Ring* are dense with resonance. "Godfrey" recalls Godfrey of Bouillon, the crusading lord of Jerusalem who, by tradition, declined to wear a crown of gold where Christ had worn one of thorns; the Haligtree takes its name from Old English *hālig*, holy; the Erdtree carries German *Erde*, earth; "Elden" sounds the Old English *eald* and the Old Norse lineage of the *Elder Edda*; and Maliketh, Marika's shadow and the keeper of Destined Death, bears a name in which the Semitic root of kingship (*malik*, *melekh*) and the lowest of the Kabbalistic *sefirot*, Malkhut, the Kingdom, identified with the indwelling Shekhinah, are both audible. The methodological principle governing such observations is strict: onomastic resonance is evidence of the field of associations within which a work invites reading, not proof of authorial intention. A name is a door the work leaves ajar; the critic's obligation is to show what lies beyond it, not to claim that the architect intended the view.

The second register is mythographic. It identifies recurrent mythic structures (the world tree, the succession of divine ages, the dismembered god whose scattered body must be gathered, the sacred marriage, the twilight of the gods) and traces their transformations across traditions. It follows Lévi-Strauss in treating a myth as the set of its variants, and it follows Propp and Dumézil in attending to functions rather than motifs. It is explicitly anti-diffusionist: the claim that Godwyn resembles Baldr is a claim about structure, not about transmission.

The third register is philosophical. It reconstructs the implicit metaphysics of the work, treating the Lands Between as a thought experiment, a *Gedankenexperiment* conducted in the medium of play. What follows if death can be excised from the laws of a world? What follows if a god can be two persons who are one? What follows if a world's order can be removed to a great distance from the life it governs? The six endings may be understood, in Leibnizian terms, as possible worlds generated from a common actual history, or, in the image Borges supplied in "The Garden of Forking Paths" (1941), as the simultaneous branches of a single labyrinth of time. Philosophical reconstruction is disciplined throughout by textual evidence; where the work is silent, the reconstruction says so.

The fourth register is procedural. Following Bogost, it reads the rules of the game as propositions: the loss of carried runes upon death and their recovery from the place of

dying; the return to the last Site of Lost Grace; the reallocation of the body's attributes through rebirth; the summoning of the dead as Spirit Ashes; the activation of Great Runes by the consumption of Rune Arcs; the passage into New Game Plus. Each of these mechanics enacts a thesis about death, memory, embodiment, and recurrence, and each is read alongside the cosmological doctrine it materializes.

Across these registers, the study distinguishes three tiers of relation between the work and the texts brought into comparison. The first tier comprises documented influence: Kentaro Miura's *Berserk*, whose importance Miyazaki has repeatedly acknowledged; Martin's mythological substrate; FromSoftware's own corpus from *King's Field* (1994) through *Demon's Souls* (2009), *Dark Souls* (2011), *Bloodborne* (2015), and *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice* (2019); Fumito Ueda's *Ico* (2001), which Miyazaki has credited with his decision to make games; and the Lovecraftian vocabulary of Outer Gods, received less from Lovecraft himself than from the later role-playing systematization of his scattered references to "Other Gods." The second tier comprises probable genealogies, traditions so pervasive in the work's iconography that their relevance requires no documentation: the Norse world tree and its burning by fire giants, the Arthurian fellowship and its waste land, the Christian lexicon of grace and the crucified god, the Gnostic topology of exile and call, the alchemical vocabulary of crucible, forge, and gold, and the Wagnerian matter of a cursed ring and a twilight of the gods. The third tier comprises heuristic affinities, for which no influence is claimed: Lurianic Kabbalah, Proclean Neoplatonism, the philosophies of Simone Weil and Philipp Mainländer, the political theology of Ernst Kantorowicz, the conservation theory of Alois Riegl, the Japanese practice of *kintsugi*. The burden of proof differs by tier, and so does the payoff. Third-tier comparisons yield no historical knowledge about the work's genesis; they yield conceptual knowledge about what the work thinks. Their warrant is the one Walter Benjamin gave in the epistemo-critical prologue to his study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928): that an idea stands to the phenomena it organizes as a constellation stands to its stars, present not in any single point but in their configuration. Given the astral theology of the Lands Between, the image has a certain propriety. The same warrant was named by Goethe and borrowed by Max Weber as "elective affinity" (*Wahlverwandtschaft*), a relation of mutual attraction between configurations of meaning that implies neither identity nor causation.

The hermeneutic stance of the study combines what Paul Ricoeur distinguished as the hermeneutics of suspicion and the hermeneutics of restoration (1965). Toward the Golden Order's self-presentation, its claims to perfection, purity, and providential legitimacy, the study is suspicious, reading those claims as ideology. Toward the fragmentary testimonies of the Order's victims and exiles, it is restorative, seeking to recover a meaning that the dominant discourse occludes. Ricoeur's *The Symbolism of Evil* (1960) supplies a further and unexpectedly precise warrant. Its phenomenology begins from the most archaic symbol of evil, defilement, understood as a quasi-material stain that contaminates by contact, before tracing the internalization of that symbol into sin and guilt; and its methodological watchword, that the symbol gives rise to thought, licenses precisely the movement from

image to concept that this thesis undertakes. The Tarnished bear, in their very name, the oldest symbol of evil that Ricoeur identified. Whether the stain is evil, or whether the horror of the stain is the deeper evil, is the question the game will press.

Four terms of art organize the argument. They are derived from the work rather than imposed upon it, and their validity is to be measured by their capacity to explain features of the work otherwise inexplicable: why the protagonist bears the name it does, why the decisive act of the narrative is the release of death, why the endings take the forms they take.

Chrysopoeic metaphysics designates any system of thought or power that exhibits, in some combination, four marks: purification, the reduction of mixture to a single pure substance; incorruptibility, the arrest of change and above all of decay; athanasia, the exemption of the living from death; and henosis, the return of the many to the One. The Golden Order exhibits all four.

Patinal ontology designates the counter-position, whose four marks answer the former point for point: alloy, being as constitutive mixture; accretion, being as the sedimented record of contact and time; finitude, death as constitutive rather than privative; and non-identity, the irreducible plurality that resists return to the One. The word *patina*, from Latin *patina*, a shallow dish, came to name the film of oxidation that forms on bronze and copper, and Filippo Baldinucci's *Vocabolario toscano dell'arte del disegno* (1681) is commonly credited with extending it to the darkening that time lays upon paintings, sometimes, Baldinucci allowed, to their advantage. A patina is not damage. It is a surface that has become history.

Re-mortalization designates the restoration of death to the laws of a world, understood as the condition of four goods the chrysopoeic project forecloses: succession, in the political order; history, in the temporal order; meaning, in the existential order; and grace, in the theological order.

Fracture-faithful repair designates a mode of mending that gathers what has been scattered, in the manner of the Lurianic *tikkun*, while preserving the visibility of the break, in the manner of *kintsugi*. It is defined negatively by the two errors it refuses: concealment, which restores the broken thing as though it had never broken, and dissolution, which abolishes the vessel so that nothing remains to be broken.

Two cautions complete the method. The first concerns overinterpretation. Umberto Eco proposed (1992) that a reading of any part of a text is acceptable only if it is confirmed, and not contradicted, by other parts of the same text, an appeal to the *intentio operis* rather than to the intention of an author. Every major claim of this thesis is submitted to that test. The second concerns cultural position. *Elden Ring* is a Japanese work built upon an Anglo-American mythological substrate, and a criticism conducted exclusively in the idiom of European philosophy would risk reproducing, at the level of interpretation, a domestication the localization already performs. The study therefore draws deliberately on Japanese and Buddhist sources (the *Kojiki*, the doctrine of impermanence, the aesthetics of *wabi-sabi* and *kintsugi*, Tanizaki Jun'ichirō's *In Praise of Shadows*) not as exotic supplements but as co-equal instruments of thought.

1.5

THE CHRYSOPOEIC HYPOTHESIS

Alchemy entered history in Graeco-Roman Egypt, and its oldest surviving manuscripts preserve an emblem that might serve as the device of this thesis. In the Byzantine collection known as Codex Marcianus graecus 299, among the leaves attributed to a female adept called Cleopatra and titled *Chrysopoeia*, a serpent encircles itself, tail in mouth, around three Greek words: ἓν τὸ πᾶν, "the All is One." The earliest image of gold-making is a ring inscribed with a henological formula. The Elden Ring belongs to the same iconographic family. It is a ring whose constituent runes are the laws of the world, and it takes its place in a long sequence of cosmic and sovereign rings: the ouroboros of the alchemists; the Spindle of Necessity in the Myth of Er, whose eight nested whorls carry the heavens and on whose rims the Sirens sing; Wagner's ring forged from the Rhinegold by one who has renounced love; Tolkien's ring of binding. In each, the ring signifies totality, closure, and law, the binding of the many into a single circuit. To shatter a ring is therefore to do more than destroy an object. It is to break a totality. It will emerge in Chapter 4 that the Golden Order's own theologians discovered, inscribed upon the statue of their goddess, a formula of exactly the ouroboric type, the identity of two in one; for the present it suffices to note that the game's central emblem is chrysopoeic in its very form.

The alchemical opus was conceived as a sequence of chromatic stages. Greek alchemy named four: *melanosis*, blackening; *leukosis*, whitening; *xanthosis*, yellowing; and *iosis*, a reddening or purpling. Latin alchemy rendered them *nigredo*, *albedo*, *citrinitas*, and *rubedo*, and, as Jung observed, the yellowing gradually fell out of use from about the fifteenth or sixteenth century, the canon contracting to three stages (Jung 1944). Whatever the number, one doctrine was constant. There is no gold without a prior death. The matter of the work must first be dissolved, putrefied, mortified, reduced to the black of the nigredo, before it can be washed white and brought to the red perfection from which the stone and its gold proceed; the formula *solve et coagula* names the sequence, and the emblematic literature of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries depicts it again and again as a burial, a coffin, a crow, a death's head. Jung read the opus as a psychology of transformation in which the nigredo, the encounter with decay, darkness, and the shadow, is the indispensable first movement of every genuine change (Jung 1944; 1955–56).

Measured against this doctrine, the Golden Order is an aborted opus. Its founding act, as the game's texts relate, was the removal of the Rune of Death from the Elden Ring and its sealing within the blade of Maliketh, Marika's Shadowbound Beast. The Order thus began from gold and refused the black. Its gold was not the product of transmutation but of exclusion, a gilding rather than a making, the *aurum vulgi* of the epigraph rather than the *aurum nostrum* of the adepts, the common metal mistaken for the philosophical one. The alchemical tradition is unambiguous about the consequence of such shortcuts: the

stages that have not been passed through are not abolished but deferred, and they return. The world of *Elden Ring* after the Shattering is the scene of that return. Its Outer Gods, the alien powers whose influence floods a world abandoned by the Greater Will, arrive in a sequence of colors that the alchemical spectrum renders intelligible.

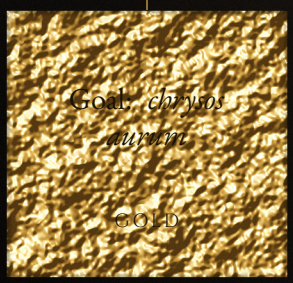
The correspondences are not offered as evidence of a designed allegory; they are offered as a configuration, in the Benjaminian sense defined above, that makes the game's chromatic theology legible as a single structure. Three features of that structure deserve emphasis. First, the black returns first and most decisively, because it was the stage most explicitly refused: the Night of the Black Knives, in which an assassin's blade imbued with stolen Destined Death killed the first demigod, is the event from which the Shattering proceeds, and the defeat of Maliketh, which unseals Destined Death, is the event that makes the ending possible. Second, the yellow of the Frenzied Flame occupies, with uncanny exactness, the position of the stage that the alchemical tradition itself suppressed: the forgotten *citrinitas* returns as the most radically annihilating of the Outer Gods, buried deepest beneath the capital, the repressed of the repressed. Third, the white of the *albedo* is the color of the lunar stage, and its association with Caria, the realm of the Full Moon Queen Rennala and her daughter Ranni, prepares the alchemical reading of the marriages of Radagon, first to the Moon and then to the Gold, as an inverted *coniunctio* of *luna* and *sol* (Chapter 4).

Mircea Eliade's *The Forge and the Crucible* (1956) supplies the second key. Eliade argued that the metallurgist and the alchemist understood metals as embryos ripening in the womb of the earth, and their own labor as a hastening of that natural gestation; the smith and the adept collaborated with nature and, in the end, took upon themselves the work of Time. The two terms of Eliade's title both name places and powers in the Lands Between. The Crucible names the primordial age before the Erdtree, in which life was undifferentiated and its forms intermingled, and whose aspects (horns, tails, wings) persist as vestiges in the Omens born into the golden lineage. The Forge names the Forge of the Giants, where the flame of the Fell God was confined after Marika's war against the giants. The Golden Order rejected both: it sealed the giants' fire and cast out the Crucible's descendants. Its chrysopoeia thus differs from the alchemist's in a decisive respect. Where the adept accelerated time, the Order arrested it. The narrative's return to the Forge, where Melina gives herself to the flame so that the Erdtree may burn, and its persistent recollection of the Crucible, mark the re-entry of the two powers the Order excluded: the fire that destroys forms and the matrix that mixes them.

Chrysopoeia has always been political as well as chemical. Hesiod's golden race (*Works and Days* 109–126) lived like gods, free of toil and grief and untouched by wretched old age, and when they died, in Hugh Evelyn-White's rendering, it was "as though they were overcome with sleep": the golden age is an age that knows death only as its euphemism. Ovid's *aurea aetas* (*Metamorphoses* 1.89–112) kept faith spontaneously and without law, *sine lege*, a contrast the more pointed given that the Japanese name of the Golden Order, 黄金律, is precisely a law. The most searching ancient image of the chrysopoeic polity, however, is Daniel's. Nebuchadnezzar dreams of a statue with a head of fine gold, a breast

TABLE 1.1

The alchemical spectrum of the Lands Between.

STAGE (GREEK / LATIN)		
	ALCHEMICAL FUNCTION Mortification and putrefaction; the death of matter	MANIFESTATIONS IN THE LANDS BETWEEN Destined Death in Maliketh's Black Blade; the Black Knives; the Black Flame of the Godskin Apostles	RELATION TO THE GOLDEN ORDER Sealed at the founding; its release is the narrative's decisive act
	ALCHEMICAL FUNCTION Ablution and purification; the lunar stage	MANIFESTATIONS IN THE LANDS BETWEEN The Consecrated Snowfield; the frozen Haligtree; the albinaurics; the pale moon of Caria	RELATION TO THE GOLDEN ORDER Displaced to the margins as refuge, exile, or rival theology
	ALCHEMICAL FUNCTION Solar dawning; the stage later alchemy forgot	MANIFESTATIONS IN THE LANDS BETWEEN The Frenzied Flame of the Three Fingers	RELATION TO THE GOLDEN ORDER Imprisoned in the depths beneath the capital
	ALCHEMICAL FUNCTION Reddening; the completion of the stone	MANIFESTATIONS IN THE LANDS BETWEEN The Scarlet Rot; Mohg's blood-rites and the Formless Mother; the Fire Giants' flame	RELATION TO THE GOLDEN ORDER Warred upon, quarantined, or sealed
	ALCHEMICAL FUNCTION The incorruptible product	MANIFESTATIONS IN THE LANDS BETWEEN The Erdtree; the Golden Order; the golden runes	RELATION TO THE GOLDEN ORDER Claimed at the outset, without the prior stages

and arms of silver, a belly and thighs of brass, legs of iron, and feet of iron mixed with clay; a stone cut out without hands strikes the feet, and gold, silver, brass, iron, and clay are "broken to pieces together" (Daniel 2:31–35). The golden head is undone through its mixed foundation, and what undoes it is unwrought matter, a stone no hand has shaped. The dream condenses the whole logic of the hypothesis advanced here: the incorruptible summit rests upon an alloy it cannot integrate, and the shattering comes from below, from what was never refined.

The chrysopoeic will did not expire with alchemy. Ernest Becker's *The Denial of Death* (1973) argued that culture itself is an immortality project, a *causa sui* by which the creature seeks to deny its creatureliness through heroic systems of symbolic deathlessness; and in the contemporary discourse of radical life-extension the will has recovered its literal form. Nick Bostrom's "The Fable of the Dragon-Tyrant" (2005) imagines a dragon that devours human beings daily in a tribute paid for millennia, until humanity at last summons the courage and technology to kill it; the fable argues that senescence and death are evils that a rational civilization should abolish. *Elden Ring* tells the obverse fable. It imagines a world that sealed away its death and then lived on, not into a golden age, but into a deathless senescence of rotting demigods, undying husks, and a capital whose eternal tree withered from within. The game does not refute the transhumanist argument, which it nowhere addresses; it conducts, in the medium of play, a thought experiment on the costs of incorruptibility that the argument rarely entertains.

The chrysopoeic hypothesis may now be stated in full. The Golden Order is the work's name for a political theology of incorruptibility that exhibits all four marks of chrysopoeic metaphysics. It purifies, persecuting the Omens and other bearers of mixture as defilement. It arrests, sustaining demigods who cannot die and therefore cannot be succeeded. It excises death, sealing the Rune of Death outside the Ring. And it seeks henosis, culminating in the Golden Order Fundamentalism whose Law of Regression posits the return of all things to unity. The Shattering is the moment at which the stages this aborted opus refused to pass through return to claim it, and the protagonist, the Tarnished, is the one figure in the world whose very nature is defined by what the Order excluded.

1.6

THE PATINAL COUNTER-HYPOTHESIS AND THE THESIS OF RE-MORTALIZATION

If CHRYSOPOEIA names the will to incorruptibility, the tradition that furnishes its counter-term is the nineteenth-century European quarrel over the restoration of monuments. Eugène-Emmanuel Viollet-le-Duc, in the article "Restauration" of his *Dictionnaire raisonné de l'architecture française* (1854–68), defined the restoration of a building not as its maintenance, repair, or reconstruction but as its re-establishment in a completed state that may

never have existed at any given moment. The definition is chrysopoeic to the letter: it seeks an ideal wholeness exempt from the contingencies of history, and it produces that wholeness by erasing the evidence of time. John Ruskin's answer, given in "The Lamp of Memory" of *The Seven Lamps of Architecture* (1849), was that restoration so conceived is "the most total destruction which a building can suffer," and that a building's greatest glory lies in its age, in what he called "that golden stain of time." The phrase is the hinge on which the present thesis turns. Ruskin calls the stain itself golden. The incorruptible metal is no longer the absence of tarnish but the tarnish of time, and gold is relocated from the pristine surface to the record of exposure. William Morris's manifesto for the Society for the Protection of Ancient Buildings (1877) made the principle programmatic, urging that protection be put in the place of restoration, and Alois Riegl's "The Modern Cult of Monuments" (1903) supplied its theory. Riegl distinguished the historical value of a monument, which requires the preservation of its documentary state, from its "age-value" (*Alterswert*), the value modern sensibility finds in the visible traces of decay, which it reads as signs of the natural cycle of becoming and passing away. Age-value, Riegl observed, is the only value that accepts the monument's eventual dissolution as part of what it honors.

Japanese aesthetics arrived independently at a still more radical form of the same position. Tanizaki Jun'ichirō's *In Praise of Shadows* (1933) contrasts the Western passion for polish and brilliance with a Japanese preference for the dim sheen of things long handled: silver and pewter allowed to darken, jade's cloudy depths, the gloss that accumulates on wood and lacquer from the touch of hands over generations. Tanizaki's most memorable pages concern gold itself, the gold lacquer and gold-leaf screens of traditional interiors, which he argued were made to be seen not in daylight but in shadow, where they catch and hold the faintest light from a garden or a flame and reveal a beauty that full illumination destroys. Gold, for Tanizaki, means most in its shadow. It is difficult not to read the title of the expansion, *Shadow of the Erdtree*, in this light, for the Land of Shadow is precisely the place where the gold of the Erdtree is seen against its own concealed history. The practice of *kintsugi* completes the inversion. A broken ceramic vessel is rejoined with lacquer mixed or dusted with powdered gold, so that the lines of fracture become seams of gold, and the break, far from being concealed, becomes the most conspicuous and most valued feature of the object, its biography written on its surface (Bartlett 2008). In *kintsugi* gold is placed in the service of the fracture. It is the precise counter-image to the Golden Order, which placed fracture in the service of gold by exiling, sealing, and suppressing everything that might crack its surface.

A third tradition supplies the cosmological form of the counter-hypothesis. In the Kabbalah of Isaac Luria, as reconstructed by Gershom Scholem (1941), creation begins with *tsimtsum*, the withdrawal of the infinite into itself to clear a space for the finite; the divine light then emanates into vessels (*kelim*) that cannot contain it and shatter, in the catastrophe called *shevirat ha-kelim*, the breaking of the vessels; sparks of the light fall into the lower worlds and are captured by husks (*kelipot*), the shells of the demonic; and the task of *tikkun*, the repair or mending of the broken configuration, is entrusted in large part

to human action, which gathers the scattered sparks and lifts them to their source. The homology with *Elden Ring* is closer than that of any other religious tradition the work invokes. A governing will withdraws; a vessel of divine order shatters; its fragments, the Great Runes, are captured by demigods who become husks around them and are deformed by what they hold, Godrick grafting the limbs of the dead to his body, Rykard surrendering himself to the serpent that devours gods, Mohg consecrating himself to blood; and a figure of exile is summoned to gather the fragments and mend the Ring with runes expressly called Mending Runes. Chapter 10 develops the homology in full. It suffices here to observe the difference that defines the synthesis this thesis proposes. Lurianic *tikkun* aims at the restoration of the original configuration, transfigured by messianic completion; *kintsugi* aims at a repair that preserves the break. Fracture-faithful repair holds both: it gathers the sparks and keeps the scars.

Patinal ontology can now be stated against its chrysopoeic opposite, mark by mark.

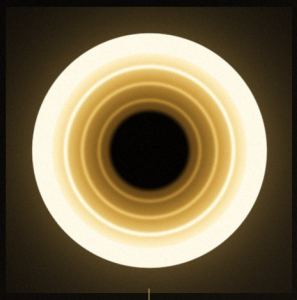
The Tarnished is the subject of this second ontology, and bears all four of its marks. The Tarnished is, first, an exile who returns, a being whose identity is constituted by a history of separation and homecoming, in contrast to the demigods who never left the Lands Between and have therefore never been anywhere. The Tarnished is, second, mortal in a world of the deathless. Returned by grace after every death, the Tarnished nonetheless pays for each one, leaving the runes it carried at the place of dying, to be recovered only by a return to the site of the fall. More striking still, every demigod who dies in the game's present dies at the Tarnished's hand. Before Maliketh's seal is broken, before Destined Death is unleashed upon the world, the Tarnished is already death's courier among the immortals, the return of finitude in person. The Tarnished is, third, an alloy. Its body is composed by the player from an open set of attributes, among them Faith, the faculty of the Golden Order's incantations, and Intelligence, the faculty of the glintstone sorcery of the stars and moon; through rebirth at the hand of the Carian queen Rennala the proportions can be dissolved and recomposed. A "build," in the community's idiom, is a metallurgical recipe, and the Tarnished is the one being in the world permitted to combine sun and moon, gold and glintstone, in any measure. The Tarnished is, fourth, a being of accretion, who accumulates the world's history as inventory, carrying the Remembrances of the slain, the ashes of the dead as summonable spirits, and the item descriptions that are the world's only chronicle.

On this basis the central thesis of the study can be formulated. Every ending of *Elden Ring* is reached by the same road. The Tarnished must gather Great Runes, enter the royal capital, ascend to the Forge of the Giants where the Erdtree is set alight, whether by Melina's self-immolation or by the Frenzied Flame the Tarnished has taken into itself, defeat Maliketh at Crumbling Farum Azula and so unseal Destined Death, cross the Ashen Capital, and destroy the Elden Beast. Only then, before the shattered body of Marika, are the endings distinguished. Re-mortalization is therefore not one option among the endings but the invariant precondition of all of them. The endings do not decide whether death returns. They decide what is to be built with a death that has already returned: an order

PLATE I

The Lurianic homology

AFTER §1.6



tsimtsum

the withdrawal of the infinite into itself to clear a space for the finite

IN THE LANDS BETWEEN

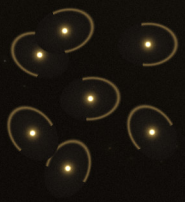
A governing will withdraws

shevirat ha-kelim

the divine light then emanates into vessels (*kelim*) that cannot contain it and shatter

IN THE LANDS BETWEEN

a vessel of divine order shatters

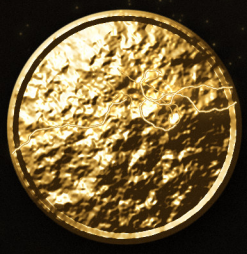


kelipot

sparks of the light fall into the lower worlds and are captured by husks (*kelipot*), the shells of the demonic

IN THE LANDS BETWEEN

its fragments, the Great Runes, are captured by demigods who become husks around them and are deformed by what they hold



tikkun

the repair or mending of the broken configuration ... entrusted in large part to human action, which gathers the scattered sparks and lifts them to their source

IN THE LANDS BETWEEN

a figure of exile is summoned to gather the fragments and mend the Ring with runes expressly called Mending Runes

Fracture-faithful repair holds both: it gathers the sparks and keeps the scars.

TABLE 1.2

Chrysopoeic and patinal ontologies.

CHRYSOPOEIC METAPHYSICS	PATINAL ONTOLOGY
SUBSTANCE	
Purity: mixture reduced to one substance	Alloy: being as constitutive mixture
EMBLEM IN THE LANDS BETWEEN *Persecution of the Omens; the Crucible's mingled life; the Tarnished's reallocable body*	
TIME	
Incorruptibility: change arrested	Accretion: being as sedimented contact
EMBLEM IN THE LANDS BETWEEN *Undying demigods; bloodstains and messages layered on the world*	
DEATH	
Athanasia: death excised from the law	Finitude: death as constitutive
EMBLEM IN THE LANDS BETWEEN *Destined Death sealed in the Black Blade; Destined Death released*	
MULTIPLICITY	
Henosis: the many returned to the One	Non-identity: irreducible plurality
EMBLEM IN THE LANDS BETWEEN *The Law of Regression and the Frenzied Flame; the plurality of allegiances and endings*	

removed to a cold and starry distance, a law purged of divine caprice, a welcome extended to the living dead, a curse made universal, an annihilation of all difference, or an unmended fracture.

This reframing alters what the game can be understood to argue. The restoration of death, on the reading developed in the chapters that follow, is the condition of four goods that the chrysopoeic order foreclosed. It is the condition of succession, because an order whose sovereign body cannot die cannot be inherited, a problem Ernst Kantorowicz's analysis of the king's two bodies (1957) allows us to state with precision (Chapter 3). It is the condition of history, because a world in which nothing ends is a world in which nothing happens; the Lands Between under the Golden Order are frozen in an interminable present whose only events are degenerations. It is the condition of meaning, because, as Heidegger argued (1927), existence becomes a whole only in its being-toward-death, and as Borges imagined in "The Immortal" (1947), beings who cannot die become indifferent to everything, since in infinite time every act is performed and therefore none matters. And it is the condition of grace. Simone Weil wrote in *Gravity and Grace* (1947) that grace fills empty spaces but can enter only where there is a void to receive it, and that it is grace itself which makes this void. The Golden Order, saturated with gold, had no void. The Tarnished, emptied of grace and exiled for that emptiness, are the only vessels in the world capable of receiving it again. Grace is given not to the gold but to the tarnished.

1.7

THE ARCHITECTURE OF THE ARGUMENT

The argument proceeds in three movements. Chapters 2 through 4 reconstruct the metaphysics of the chrysopoeic order: its cosmology, its excision of death, and its theology of the divided god. Chapters 5 through 7 examine the powers that order excluded and that return in its ruin: the abject, the distant, and the annihilating. Chapters 8 through 10 turn from the world to the form in which it is encountered and the choices with which it ends, culminating in the systematic statement of patinal ontology.

Chapter 2, "Theogony of the Ring," reconstructs the cosmology of the Lands Between: the Greater Will and its emissary, the Elden Beast, which came as a golden star and became the Elden Ring; the plurality of Outer Gods that contend for a world their rival has abandoned; and the succession of ages that preceded the Golden Order, from the Crucible through the age of dragons, whose Elden Lord, Placidusax, still awaits the return of a departed god, to the war against the giants. These materials are read against Hesiod's *Theogony* and the *Enuma Elish* as succession myths; against the *Völuspá*; against the Gnostic demiurge Yaldabaoth of the *Apocryphon of John*; against the withdrawing god of Plato's *Statesman* and the Lurianic *tsimtsum*; against the Outer Gods of Lovecraft and the dreaming god of Dunsany's Pegāna. The Erdtree is read as *axis mundi* alongside Yggdrasil,

the Kabbalistic tree of the *sefirot*, and Tolkien's Two Trees of Valinor; the Elden Beast, as Hobbes's Leviathan, the "mortal god" of sovereign order, and as the bearer of a *nomos* in Carl Schmitt's sense. The chapter argues that the Greater Will is a *deus absconditus* whose withdrawal is at once the condition of the world's freedom and the cause of its catastrophe, and it reads the expansion's abandoned Metyr, Mother of Fingers, as the theology of that absence made flesh.

Chapter 3, "The Sealing of Death," examines the founding act of the Golden Order and its consequences: the Erdtree burial that displaced an older funerary dispensation associated with the ghostflame of the Deathbirds; the Night of the Black Knives and the death of Godwyn, read alongside Baldr and Osiris; the Deathroot and Those Who Live in Death; and Fia, the Deathbed Companion, as an inversion of the late-medieval *ars moriendi*. Its comparative frame comprises Tithonus and Tennyson's monologue, Swift's Struldbrugs, Čapek's and Janáček's Makropulos and Bernard Williams's argument for the tedium of immortality, Becker's *causa sui*, Heidegger's being-toward-death, Tolkien's "Gift of Men" and the fall of Númenor, Le Guin's *The Farthest Shore* and *The Other Wind*, the severed mortality of *Planescape: Torment*, and the "Immortal Severance" of *Sekiro*. Its central argument, conducted with Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies*, is that the abolition of death forecloses succession, so that the Shattering must be understood as a succession crisis produced by deathlessness itself.

Chapter 4, "Two Souls in One Breast," reads Golden Order Fundamentalism and its two laws, of Causality and of Regression, through Proclus's doctrine of procession and reversion, and the revelation that Radagon is Marika through Nicholas of Cusa's *coincidentia oppositorum*, the Śaiva icon of Ardhanārīśvara, the alchemical *rebis* and *coniunctio*, Jung's syzygy, the Kabbalistic unification of the Holy One and the Shekhinah, Faust's two souls, and Dumézil's double sovereignty. It interprets the Empyreans, Miquella and Malenia, as the children of a divine self-union, and Marika's shattering of the Ring as the self-destruction of a god, read through Philipp Mainländer's metaphysics of a God who died so that the world might be. It closes with the expansion's intimation that Marika arose from a persecuted shamanic people and that her order turned persecution upon the Hornsent through Messmer's crusade, a reversal analyzed through René Girard's theory of mimetic violence.

Chapter 5, "Matter Out of Place," takes its title from Mary Douglas and its theory from Douglas, Kristeva, and Bakhtin. It reads the Omens as Agamben's *homo sacer* and as the imprisoned child of Le Guin's Omelas; Morgott, the Omen King who defended the order that despised him, as the melancholy sovereign of Benjamin's *Trauerspiel*; Mohg and the Formless Mother through Plato's *khōra*; Malenia and the Scarlet Rot through Bataille's "The Language of Flowers," the purifying Sea of Corruption of Hayao Miyazaki's *Nausicaä*, Donna Haraway's compost, and Anna Tsing's life in ruins; and Godrick's grafts and the albinaurics as figures of the hybrid. It ends with Miquella, whose Haligtree promised asylum to the outcast and whose compassion the expansion reveals as domination, read through

Dostoevsky's Grand Inquisitor, Nietzsche's critique of pity, and Herbert's anatomy of the charismatic messiah.

Chapter 6, "Gravity and Grace," reads Ranni's rebellion through Simone Weil. Radahn's gravity sorcery, with which he halted the stars, and the grace that guides the Tarnished are treated as the two forces of Weil's spiritual physics; Ranni's discarding of her flesh, as a form of Weil's "decreation." The chapter situates the astral theology of Caria and the Academy of Raya Lucaria within Stoic and Gnostic doctrines of fate, Hermetic and Ficinian astral magic, and Bruno's infinite worlds; reads the punishment of the Eternal Cities of Nox as a Babel myth and the surveillance of the Two Fingers as an angelic bureaucracy in Agamben's sense; and interprets the Age of Stars as poised between Gnostic exodus and Levinasian separation, with a coda on Pascal's infinite spaces and the *Nihon Shoki*'s separation of sun and moon.

Chapter 7, "The Fire That Unmakes," treats the Frenzied Flame of the Three Fingers as Nietzsche's primordial unity stripped of Apollonian form, as Freud's Nirvana principle, as the will to non-being of Schopenhauer and Mainländer, and as an inverted *nirvāṇa* that literalizes the Buddha's Fire Sermon, in which all is burning and the eye burns first. It compares the Flame to the Human Instrumentality Project of *Neon Genesis Evangelion* and the Radiance of *Hollow Knight*, places it within the Law-and-Chaos cosmologies of Moorcock and *Shin Megami Tensei*, and reads the Fell God's fire through Ragnarök's Surtr and Melina's kindling through Brünnhilde's immolation. The chapter concludes with the Black Flame of the Godskin Apostles as a theology of god-slaying and with the Dung Eater's Blessing of Despair, read through Kierkegaard's sickness unto death, Nietzsche's *ressentiment*, and Scholem's "Redemption Through Sin."

Chapter 8, "The Archive of the Dead," turns to form. It reads the Lands Between through Benjamin's theory of allegory and ruin and his Angel of History; through the Old English elegies, whose ruins are the work of giants; through Eliot's fragments and Simmel's essay on the ruin; and through the painted ruin from Piranesi and Hubert Robert to Friedrich and Beksiński. Item descriptions are analyzed as epigraphy, Spirit Ashes as a necromantic archive, the asynchronous multiplayer system as palimpsest, carnival, and marginal commentary, and bloodstains as a communal patina. The death-loop is read as *meletē thanatou*, the practice of dying that Plato's *Phaedo* made the definition of philosophy, and through the *ars moriendi*, Camus's Sisyphus, Nietzsche's eternal recurrence as enacted in New Game Plus, and Tolkien's Northern courage; the lore community, finally, as the encyclopedists of Borges's Tlön.

Chapter 9, "The Mending Problem," offers a comparative morphology of the six endings, together with the age of compassion that the expansion forecloses, as competing soteriologies. It employs Scholem's typology of restorative, utopian, and apocalyptic messianism and sets the endings beside Wagner's alternative conclusions to *Götterdämmerung*, Herbert's Golden Path and Scattering, Kurosawa's *Ran*, Le Guin's Omelas, Nausicaä's refusal of an engineered purity, Evangelion's refusal of fusion, the final sacrifice of *NieR: Automata*, and

the town of *Pathologic*, locating each ending on the axis between chrysopoeic and patinal ontology.

Chapter 10, "Toward a Patinal Ontology," brings the argument to systematic statement. It formulates patinal ontology as a set of theses, develops fracture-faithful repair as an ethical and political model, and draws out its implications for theology after the death of God, for ecological thought in an age of ruins, for the theory of sovereignty after the shattering of totalities, and for the philosophy of games as a medium of thought.

1.8

CODA: *OFT HIM ĀNHAGA ĀRE GEBĪDEÐ*

The Old English elegy from which this chapter took its second epigraph opens with a line that might stand over the whole of *Elden Ring*: *Oft him ānhaga āre gebīdeð, / Metudes miltse* (*The Wanderer* 1–2), often the solitary one waits for grace, for the mercy of the Measurer. The *ānhaga* is an exile, a retainer whose lord is dead and whose hall is ruined, who has buried his "gold-friend" (*goldwine*, 22) in the darkness of the earth and now crosses the icy sea in search of a giver of treasure. Midway through the poem he walks among broken walls and asks the question of every ruin: where has the horse gone, where the young warrior, where the giver of treasure? The poem closes as it opened, with *āre*, grace: it will be well for the one who seeks it, comfort from the Father in heaven, where all security stands (114–115).

Elden Ring answers the Wanderer's questions with a precision that seems almost deliberate, though it need not be. The horse returns as a spirit, Torrent, the spectral steed summoned by a whistle that Melina places in the Tarnished's hand. The young warriors return as ashes, the Spirit Ashes of the dead, called up from their remains to fight once more beside the living. And the giver of treasure, the lord whom the Anglo-Saxon poets called the ring-giver, returns in the one form the chrysopoeic order never anticipated: as a Tarnished exile who crossed the fog-bound sea, who has died more often than any being in the world, and who alone is permitted to stand before the shattered Ring and decide what it shall become. The hall of gold does not return. What returns is the wanderer, and the grace that comes only to the wanderer.

The chapters that follow attempt to read the ruin the wanderer crosses: its gods, its sealed death, its divided sovereign, its outcasts, its stars, its fires, its archive of the dead, and the forms of repair its endings propose. They proceed, of necessity, as the Tarnished does, from fragment to fragment. Eliot's line, the third of this chapter's epigraphs, names the method as well as the condition: these fragments I have shored against my ruins. It is the claim of this thesis that *Elden Ring* asks to be read in exactly this way, not as a broken whole awaiting its restoration to gold, but as a world whose fractures are where its meaning lives.

What returns is the wanderer, and the grace that comes only to the wanderer.

CHAPTER 1 · §1.8

VERE TU ES DEUS ABSCONDITUS
VERE TU ES DEUS ABSCONDITUS
VERE TU ES DEUS ABSCONDITUS
VERE TU ES DEUS ABSCONDITUS

CHAPTER

2

THEOGONY OF THE RING

Outer Gods, Divine Withdrawal, and the Succession of Orders

Vere tu es Deus absconditus.
— Isaiah 45:15 (Vulgate)

gap var ginnunga, en gras hvergi
— *Völuspá* 3

2

2.1

A COSMOLOGY OF ARRIVALS

Every cosmogony answers a question of priority. Hesiod begins with Chaos, the gaping void from which Earth, Tartarus, and Eros, then Erebus and Night, come to be (*Theogony* 116–123). The *Enuma Elish* opens in the time when the heavens above had not yet been named and the waters of Apsû and Tiāmat mingled as one. The *Vǫluspá* recalls an age in which there was neither sand nor sea nor cool waves, no earth below and no heaven above, only a yawning gap and grass nowhere. The *Kojiki* begins as heaven and earth first divide, while the young land, like floating oil, drifts upon the waters like a jellyfish. Genesis begins with an act of making. Whatever their theologies, these texts locate divinity at or before the origin of the world, so that gods and cosmos either grow up together or the cosmos is the work of a god who precedes it.

Elden Ring contains no such account. Nowhere in its corpus is the making of the Lands Between narrated, and its earliest strata are not acts of creation but events of arrival. A golden star falls, bearing a beast that will become the Elden Ring. A goddess first sets foot in a land that the expansion locates in the Erdtree's shadow. Powers called Outer Gods, whose very name designates exteriority, reach into the world from elsewhere. The world is already there, populated and alive, when divinity descends upon it. The cosmology of the Lands Between is a cosmology of arrivals rather than of creation, and this formal fact, easily overlooked because it concerns what the text omits, governs everything the game proposes about the relation between order and the world it orders.

Three consequences follow, and they organize this chapter. The first is that order is exogenous. In a cosmology of creation, order belongs to the world by right of origin, and to violate it is to violate the world's own nature. In a cosmology of arrivals, order is imported and imposed upon a world whose native condition is something else: in the Lands Between, as §2.4 shows, the undifferentiated mixture of the Crucible. The Golden Order is not the world's nature but a regime installed over it, and this is the condition that makes the chrysopoeic project possible at all, since only an order foreign to a world could regard that world's native mixture as contamination. The second consequence is that divine power is relational and appropriative. A god who arrives in a world that precedes it governs as a conqueror governs, by taking possession of land and dividing it, which is why the categories of political theology (sovereignty, appropriation, constituent power) prove more illuminating here than those of cosmogony (§2.6). The third consequence is the most far-reaching. A cosmology of arrivals is necessarily also a cosmology of departures. What came from elsewhere can return there, and a god who was not always present need not always remain. The opening narration's phrase, abandonment by the Greater Will, names an event that a theology of creation can scarcely conceive but that a theology of arrivals

must always fear, and the history of the Lands Between, read as a whole, proves to be less a sequence of divine victories than a sequence of divine desertions (§2.7).

The materials for this reconstruction are scattered and uneven. They comprise the item descriptions bearing on the Greater Will, the Elden Beast, and the Two Fingers; the incantations that preserve the memory of the Crucible; the remembrances and ruined architecture of the dragons and giants; the iconography of the Erdtree; and, since 2024, the expansion's account of the Land of Shadow, which its opening narration presents as a realm veiled by the Erdtree, the place where Marika first set foot, scoured by an untold war and burned by the fire of Messmer, her son. The expansion functions as archaeology beneath archaeology. It opens a stratum below the base game's earliest layers and discloses that the prehistory of the Golden Order includes a land its founder concealed. In keeping with the method of §1.4, the chapter does not attempt a definitive chronology, a task the community of interpreters has pursued with great energy and diminishing returns. It reads instead the system of relations among five elements: the Greater Will and its intermediaries (§2.2), the plurality of Outer Gods (§2.3), the succession of ages (§2.4), the world tree (§2.5), and the Ring-Beast in which law and animal coincide (§2.6). It concludes by proposing that these elements compose a theogony without precise precedent, a theogony of departures (§§2.7–2.8).

2.2

THE GREATER WILL: THE HIDDEN GOD, THE FINGERS, AND THE EMPTY THRONE

What the world's texts affirm of the Greater Will is meager and consistent. Long ago it sent into the Lands Between a golden star bearing a beast, and the beast became the Elden Ring. That beast, encountered at the end of the game as the Elden Beast, is described as the Greater Will's vassal and as the living embodiment of the concept of order. The Will communicates through the Two Fingers, digit-like beings whose tremors are construed by Finger Readers, aged women who translate the Fingers' pronouncements, and whose purposes are carried into the world by the Finger Maidens who accompany the Tarnished. After the Shattering the Will is said to have abandoned the Lands Between, yet the Fingers continue to speak and the Beast continues to guard the Ring. The Greater Will itself never appears. It has no face, no voice, no location, and no history of its own. It is known only through intermediaries and effects: a falling star, a beast, a ring, a pair of fingers, and a golden light in the eyes of the favored that may at any moment be withdrawn.

The name is itself a theology. The Japanese 大いなる意志 and the English "Greater Will" designate neither a being nor a mind nor a person, but a volition. The choice aligns the cosmology of the Lands Between with the late-medieval voluntarism of Duns Scotus and William of Ockham rather than with the intellectualism of Aquinas. For the intellectualist,

the order of the world expresses the divine reason and is therefore, in principle, intelligible and necessary. For the voluntarist, it expresses the divine will and is therefore contingent, ordained by a power that might have ordained otherwise and that retains, as its *potentia absoluta*, the capacity to revoke what its *potentia ordinata* established. Hans Blumenberg located in this "theological absolutism" the origin of the modern age: a God whose will had become inscrutable to reason drove human beings to the self-assertion by which modernity secured the conditions of its own existence (Blumenberg 1983 [1966]). The Lands Between stage precisely this crisis. The Golden Order is an ordained order, the *potentia ordinata* of a will that has demonstrated by its withdrawal its *potentia absoluta*; and the projects that contend for the world after the Shattering, Golden Order Fundamentalism and Ranni's revolt most explicitly, are forms of self-assertion against a will that can no longer be trusted to sustain what it willed (Chapters 4 and 6).

The Greater Will is a *deus absconditus* in the precise sense the tradition gave the phrase. Isaiah's exclamation became, in Luther's *De servo arbitrio* (1525), the doctrine of a God hidden in his majesty, whose will is not to be searched out, distinct from the God revealed in the Word. It became in Pascal's *Pensées* the principle that a religion which did not declare God hidden could not be true. Lucien Goldmann's *The Hidden God* (1955) made the God of Pascal and Racine the center of a "tragic vision": a God always absent and always present, who watches the world without speaking in it, so that the tragic subject lives under a gaze that never becomes a word and refuses a world it cannot leave. No formula better describes the situation of Marika, a god who is herself the instrument of a higher Will that observes her order without addressing it, and whose decisive act, the shattering of the Ring, is the gesture of a tragic subject who can neither obey nor escape. Martin Buber's *Eclipse of God* (1952) adds a necessary distinction. An eclipse is not a death: the sun persists behind whatever has come between it and the eye. Nietzsche's madman announced that God is dead and that we have killed him (*The Gay Science* §125). The opening narration of *Elden Ring* announces something else, that God has turned away. The Lands Between inhabit not the death of God but its eclipse, and the difference matters, because an eclipsed god may return. The dragon who still waits in his storm of time, considered in §2.7, is the figure of that expectation.

The Gnostic tradition furnishes a second frame, and the game inverts it. In the systems Hans Jonas reconstructed, two gods confront one another. The true God is alien: transcendent, unknown, beyond the cosmos, and good. The cosmocrator, or demiurge, is the lower and ignorant power who fashions the world and rules it through his archons and the chain of fate (*heimarmenē*). In the *Apocryphon of John* he is Yaldabaoth, the misbegotten offspring of the aeon Sophia, who boasts that he is a jealous god beside whom there is no other, a parody of Isaiah 45:5. Gnostic salvation consists in the awakening of the spark imprisoned in matter and its ascent past the archons toward the alien God. *Elden Ring* fuses what Gnosticism held apart. The Greater Will is alien, an outer god arriving from beyond, yet it is also the cosmocrator, the author of the world's law, ruling through intermediaries who function as archons. The figure may be called an *alien demiurge*. The

consequence is that the Gnostic route of escape is closed: there is no higher alien God to whom the exile might flee from the cosmocrator, because the alien is the cosmocrator. Ranni's rebellion, recognizably Gnostic in other respects, must therefore invent its own transcendence, carrying the order far away into the stars (Chapter 6), while the Frenzied Flame offers a transcendence indistinguishable from annihilation (Chapter 7).

Giorgio Agamben's genealogy of the "providential machine" in *The Kingdom and the Glory* (2007) supplies a third frame and clarifies the function of the Fingers. Agamben argues that Christian theology bequeathed to Western politics a bipolar structure in which God reigns but does not govern, administering the world through secondary causes and an ordered hierarchy of angelic ministers, while the sovereign pole is sustained by glory, the liturgical acclamation of a power that does not itself act. The maxim of nineteenth-century constitutional monarchy, that the king reigns but does not govern, is the secularized form of this theology. The Greater Will reigns. The Two Fingers, the Finger Readers, the Finger Maidens, and above them Marika and her Elden Lords govern, while the golden liturgy of the Erdtree supplies the glory. The Fingers are an angelic bureaucracy, and their distinctive pathology, visible in the chamber of the Roundtable Hold where a pair of fingers trembles and an aged reader translates its tremors, is that the ministry has outlived any assurance of the will it ministers. Agamben's study culminates in the image of the empty throne, the *hetoimasia* of Byzantine and early Christian art, a throne prepared and vacant, which he reads as the emblem of sovereignty's glory. The Elden Throne is such a throne: empty, prepared, awaiting a lord, and filled, in the moment of decision, by a being whom the order had exiled. That the game culminates in the occupation of an empty throne by a Tarnished exile is the political-theological content of its ending.

The withdrawal of such a will admits three readings, which the game holds in suspension. On the Platonic reading, withdrawal is neglect, and it portends return. In the myth of the *Statesman* (268d–274e) the god who steers the cosmos releases the tiller; the world reverses its rotation under its own innate desire, remembers its maker's instruction for a time, then forgets it, until disorder threatens to sink it in what the Stranger calls the boundless sea of unlikeness, whereupon the god resumes the helm. Augustine transposed the image into the soul's estrangement from God, its sojourn in a "region of unlikeness" (*regio dissimilitudinis*, *Confessions* 7.10.16). On the Lurianic reading, withdrawal is the precondition of finite existence and of its freedom: the infinite contracts so that something other than itself may be. Simone Weil radicalized the thought into a theology of creation as abdication, and Hans Jonas, decades after his studies of Gnosticism, proposed after Auschwitz a God who had renounced omnipotence so that the world might be its own (Jonas 1987). On the tragic reading that Goldmann and Buber supply, withdrawal is neither neglect nor gift but hiddenness, the condition of a world lived under a silent gaze. Each reading finds support in the text: the Platonic in the dragon who waits for his god, the Lurianic in the freedom of the endings, the tragic in the Fingers who speak into silence. Section 2.7 argues that the structure of the game privileges the second, without relinquishing the costs that the first and third make visible.

2.3

THE OUTER GODS: LAW, CONTAGION, AND THE WAR OF THE GODS

The Greater Will is not alone. The world's own theology names a class of powers, the Outer Gods (外なる神), that act upon the Lands Between from beyond it, and the category is not a critic's construct but an indigenous term: Miquella forged his Unalloyed Gold Needle expressly to ward off their interference. Besides the Greater Will, the corpus attests four such powers with reasonable clarity. The Frenzied Flame speaks through the Three Fingers buried beneath the capital. The Formless Mother, the god of blood, was discovered in the depths by the Omen Mohg, who consecrated his dynasty to her. The god of rot blooms as the Scarlet Rot and has its most terrible vessel in Malenia. The Fell God, deity of the Fire Giants, saw its flame confined in the Forge after Marika's war. Other powers stand at the edge of the category without clearly entering it: the god-slaying Black Flame of the Godskin Apostles, whose source the texts shroud, and the astral Primeval Current from which the sorcerers of Raya Lucaria derive their glintstone, a cosmic source rather than a god, examined in Chapter 6.

The table discloses a structural asymmetry that the game's theology never states but everywhere presupposes. The Greater Will acts through law: through runes that function as statutes, through an Order whose Japanese name is a legal term, through a Ring that binds. The other Outer Gods act through contagion. The Frenzied Flame passes from eye to eye; the Scarlet Rot spreads through flesh and soil; the blood of the Formless Mother is shed, offered, and shared; the giants' fire, once loosed, consumes. Two modes of divine efficacy are thereby opposed, *nomos* and *miasma*. Robert Parker's study of pollution in archaic Greek religion (1983) described *miasma* as a quasi-physical contamination, transmissible by contact, dangerous to whole communities, and requiring purification rather than punishment: the religious form of the logic of contagion. The Golden Order is a regime of *nomos* that defends itself against *miasma*, and its purity codes, examined in Chapter 5, are the immune system of a law confronting gods that operate as pathogens. The *Kojiki* offers an instructive parallel. When Izanagi returns from the land of the dead and bathes to cleanse himself, the pollution he washes away becomes deities, the Magatsuhi, gods of calamity; to rectify them he brings forth the Naobi, gods of correction; and only then are born, from his eyes and nose, the Sun, the Moon, and the Storm. Pollution, in this theology, is not the absence of the divine but one of its modes, and Motoori Norinaga would later make the Magatsuhi the explanation of misfortune in the world. The Outer Gods of rot and frenzy are the Magatsuhi of the Lands Between. The game's distinctive refusal is to let the Naobi, the correcting law of the Greater Will, appear as simply good.

The name "Outer Gods" descends, through the systematization of Chaosium's *Call of Cthulhu* (1981), from Lovecraft's scattered references to "Other Gods," and one of those gods casts a long shadow over the Frenzied Flame. Lovecraft's Azathoth, in "The Dream-

TABLE 2.1

The Outer Gods of the Lands Between.

GREATER WILL

VESSEL OR EMISSARY The Elden Beast; the Two Fingers; Marika
MODE OF INFLUENCE Law: runes, statute, the Ring
OFFER TO THE WORLD Order, grace, the golden lineage
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE The Gnostic demiurge; Hobbes's Leviathan

FRENZIED FLAME

VESSEL OR EMISSARY The Three Fingers; Shabriri; Hyetta
MODE OF INFLUENCE Contagion through the eye
OFFER TO THE WORLD Release from all distinction
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Lovecraft's Azathoth; the Buddhist Fire Sermon

FORMLESS MOTHER

VESSEL OR EMISSARY Mohg, Lord of Blood
MODE OF INFLUENCE Wound, blood-rite, offering
OFFER TO THE WORLD Union through blood
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Plato's *khōra*; Tiāmat

GOD OF ROT

VESSEL OR EMISSARY Malenia; the Kindred of Rot
MODE OF INFLUENCE Contagion, blooming, decomposition
OFFER TO THE WORLD Life through decay
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Yggdrasil's rotting flank; the Sea of Corruption in *Nausicaä*

FELL GOD

VESSEL OR EMISSARY The Fire Giants; the Forge
MODE OF INFLUENCE Fire, sealed and released
OFFER TO THE WORLD The ruin of the tree
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Muspell's sons and Surtr

Quest of Unknown Kadath," is the mindless daemon-sultan who gnaws hungrily at the center of ultimate chaos amid the thin whine of accursed flutes. FromSoftware had already worked this vein: in *Bloodborne* the Great Ones are transcendent beings who lose their children and seek surrogates among humankind. Yet the comparison discloses a difference as important as the debt. Lovecraft's cosmicism is a horror of indifference. Its terror is that the universe does not care, that human meaning is a local accident in a cosmos of blind forces. The horror of *Elden Ring* is the reverse. Its cosmos cares too much. Every Outer God desires the world: each seeks a vessel, bids for a lord, and proffers a gift, and the Tarnished is solicited in turn by the Two Fingers, by the Three Fingers, by the servants of the Formless Mother, and by visionaries who speak for the moon, for the living dead, and for the curse. The Lands Between are not neglected by the cosmos but courted by it.

The image that best captures this condition is Homeric. In the *Odyssey*, the house of an absent lord is occupied by suitors who court his wife and consume his substance while she defers, by weaving and unweaving, a decision she will not make. The Lands Between after the Shattering is such a house. The demigods, each holding a shard of a sovereignty none can complete, devour the estate; the Outer Gods court the world; and the one who returns from exile across the sea, unrecognized and in the guise of the lowest, guided by a female figure who appears and vanishes at will, is the one who will end the suitors' feast. The parallel between the Tarnished and Odysseus, and between Melina and the Athena who guides her favorite through a succession of disguises, is pursued in §2.7, where it yields the chapter's central formula: in the Lands Between, the return of the exile takes the place of the return of the god.

Max Weber supplied, in "Science as a Vocation" (1919), the sociological form of this theology. In a world disenchanted by the rationalization of its unifying religion, he argued, the old gods rise from their graves, disenchanted into impersonal powers, and resume their eternal struggle for dominion over our lives, so that each person must decide which of them is god and which devil. The Lands Between after the Shattering are Weber's polytheism of values made literal. The Golden Order had presented itself as a henotheism, the cult of one supreme Will among many outer powers; its collapse returns the world to a polytheism in which rot, frenzy, blood, flame, moon, and gold contend as impersonal forces, and in which the Tarnished must, in Weber's sense, choose a god. The endings, examined in Chapter 9, are the forms of that choice.

One further comparison frames the silence of the highest god. In Lord Dunsany's *The Gods of Pegāna* (1905), Māna-Yood-Sushāī made the gods and then rested, and the drummer Skarl beats his drum without ceasing, for should the drumming stop the god would wake, and the gods and worlds he made would be no more. The world persists in the interval of a god's sleep. The Lands Between persist in the interval of a Will's silence, and their outer powers, like Dunsany's lesser gods, play with the world in the absence of the one who made them. Whether that silence is sleep, eclipse, or abandonment is the question to which §2.7 returns.

2.4

THE SUCCESSION OF AGES: CRUCIBLE, DRAGONS, GIANTS, GOLD

Hesiod bequeathed to the West two incompatible accounts of time. The *Theogony* narrates an ascent: from Chaos and Earth, through the violent successions of Ouranos, Kronos, and Zeus, the cosmos climbs toward the just and stable order of the Olympians, secured by the defeat of the Titans and of Typhon. The *Works and Days* narrates a descent: from a golden race through silver, bronze, and the heroes to the present race of iron, humanity falls away from its origin. The one is a history of order achieved, the other a history of order lost. *Elden Ring* superimposes them. The Golden Order stands at the summit of a theogonic succession, the last and most complete of the orders that have governed the Lands Between, and at the origin of a metallic decline, the golden age from which the present ruin descends. It occupies the precise point at which the curve of ascent becomes the curve of descent, and its history must be read in both directions at once. The sequence below is structural rather than strictly chronological; the relative dating of the Crucible and the age of dragons in particular remains contested.

The Crucible occupies the position of the primordial. The incantations called Aspects of the Crucible preserve the memory of a matrix of life in which forms were not yet sorted, from which horn, tail, wing, and breath might erupt within a single body, and the Crucible Knights, elite warriors of the Order's founding wars, drew their power from it before it was relegated to the Order's margins. Its most consequential survival is biological. The horns with which Omens are born into the golden lineage are vestiges of the Crucible, the return in the blood of the rulers of the primordial mixture the rulers disowned. The structure is that of the *Enuma Elish*. Tiāmat, the primordial waters, mother of all, answers the young gods' provocation by bringing forth a brood of hybrids (horned serpents, dragons, lion-demons, scorpion-men, fish-men, bull-men) and is slain by Marduk, who splits her body in two to make heaven and earth and fixes the stations of the stars. The cosmic order is carved from the body of the primordial mixture, and its founding act is the suppression of hybridity. The Golden Order is Marduk; the Crucible is Tiāmat; the Omens are her surviving brood. The analogy extends to the instrument of sovereignty. Marduk's victory is sealed when he takes from Tiāmat's champion Kingu the Tablet of Destinies and fastens it to his own breast. The Elden Ring, the Great Runes for which the demigods fight, and the Rune of Death that Ranni will steal are Tablets of Destinies, objects whose possession confers the right to determine fate. The Akkadian myth of Anzû, the bird-demon who seizes the Tablet from Enlil while the god is bathing, supplies the template for the theft that precipitates the Shattering (Chapter 3).

The age of dragons is attested by its last sovereign. Dragonlord Placidusax, the texts relate, ruled as Elden Lord in an age before the Erdtree, and he lies still in Crumbling Farum Azula, a city suspended in a tempest in which time itself is disordered, awaiting the

TABLE 2.2

The succession of orders in the Lands Between.

THE SHATTERING

PRESIDING POWER The demigods and the Outer Gods
SURVIVING TRACES The Great Runes; the battlefields; the rot
FATE UNDER THE GOLDEN ORDER Its aftermath is the game's present
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Hesiod's race of iron; Weber's war of the gods

THE GOLDEN ORDER

PRESIDING POWER Marika, the Greater Will, the Erdtree
SURVIVING TRACES Leyndell; the catacombs; the golden runes
FATE UNDER THE GOLDEN ORDER Present only as ruin
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Hesiod's golden race; the golden age of the Æsir

THE GIANTS

PRESIDING POWER The Fell God and the Fire Giants
SURVIVING TRACES The Forge of the Giants; the last giant bound to its flame
FATE UNDER THE GOLDEN ORDER Exterminated; their fire sealed
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE The Gigantomachy; Muspell's sons and Surtr

THE AGE OF DRAGONS

PRESIDING POWER Dragonlord Placidusax, Elden Lord before the Erdtree
SURVIVING TRACES Crumbling Farum Azula in its storm of time; Dragon Communion
FATE UNDER THE GOLDEN ORDER Superseded and partly assimilated
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Fáfnir; the dragon as ancient sovereign

THE CRUCIBLE

PRESIDING POWER Primordial, undifferentiated life
SURVIVING TRACES The Aspects of the Crucible; the Crucible Knights; the horns of the Omens
FATE UNDER THE GOLDEN ORDER Employed in the founding wars, then purged as impurity
COMPARATIVE ANALOGUE Tiāmat's brood; the drifting land of the *Kojiki*

return of a god who departed. Two inferences follow. The first is that the office of Elden Lord is older than the Golden Order: the Ring's form, lordship over its law, preceded the golden content Marika gave it, so that the Golden Order appears not as the essence of the Ring but as one of its occupants. The second is that divine departure has happened before, and §2.7 draws out its significance. The dragons' legacy within the Golden Order is ambivalent. Godwyn befriended the dragon Fortissax; the knights of the capital practiced a dragon cult whose lightning incantations derive from the ancient dragons; and in Caelid a Church of Dragon Communion offers the consumption of dragon hearts, by which the communicant acquires draconic power at the price of becoming draconic. The rite has an exact Northern antecedent. In the *Fáfnismál* and the *Saga of the Volsungs*, Sigurd roasts the heart of the dragon Fáfnir, himself a man transformed into a dragon by brooding over gold, burns his finger, sets it to his lips, and understands the speech of birds. To eat the dragon's heart is to receive its knowledge; to brood upon gold is to become a dragon. The Northern tradition thus joins in a single myth the two operations the Lands Between keep apart: the sacramental assimilation of an elder power and the draconic deformation of the one who hoards gold.

The giants were the last order the Golden Order destroyed. The Fire Giants worshipped the Fell God, whose flame, the texts imply, was the one fire capable of burning the Erdtree. Marika's war exterminated them, and the last survivor was condemned to tend the flame forever at the summit of the Mountaintops of the Giants, where the Forge stands sealed. The Gigantomachy of Greek myth, in which the Olympians could overcome the earth-born giants only with the aid of a mortal hero, Heracles, offers one frame: the Golden Order, too, defeated the giants with a mortal champion at its side, Godfrey, the first Elden Lord. The Northern frame is more exact. In the *Völuspá* the sons of Muspell, led by Surtr with his fire, ride out at Ragnarök to burn the world, and the ash Yggdrasil trembles as they come. The giants' fire is the eschatological fire, held in reserve for the end. The Golden Order did not extinguish it; it sealed it in a mountain. What the Order sealed the narrative will unseal, for the road to every ending passes through the Forge.

The Golden Order itself began, in the account the expansion has extended backward, with Marika's arrival. She first set foot in the Land of Shadow, rose from a people whose lot the expansion intimates was persecution, and in alliance with the warrior Godfrey conquered the Lands Between, waging war on the giants, on the sorcerer-realm of Caria, and on whatever resisted the planting of the Erdtree at the center of the world. Northern myth again supplies the closest analogue for the golden age that followed. In the *Völuspá* the gods, in the morning of the world, raise altars and temples, build forges, and play at tables in their meadow, cheerful and lacking nothing of gold, until three giant maidens come out of Jötunheim; and soon afterward the gods burn in Odin's hall a woman called Gullveig, whose name has been read as "gold-draught" or "gold-might," three times, and three times she is reborn, and from her burning comes the first war in the world. Here is a mythic emblem of the Golden Order's fate: a deathless gold that cannot be destroyed by

fire, whose attempted destruction issues in war. The gold of the Golden Order, too, could not be made to die. It could only be shattered, and its shattering was war.

The table discloses a final pattern. The orders of the Lands Between do not replace one another; they are sealed one beneath another. The Crucible survives in the horns of the Omens and the arms of its knights; the age of dragons in a city held outside time; the giants in a flame bound beneath a mountain. The Golden Order is an order of seals: Death in the Black Blade, fire in the Forge, frenzy beneath the capital, Omens in its sewers, and, as the expansion discloses, an entire land veiled behind the Erdtree. Freud, seeking an image for the persistence of the past in the psyche, imagined in *Civilization and Its Discontents* (1930) an impossible Rome in which every building that had ever stood on a site still stood there, all periods coexisting in a single space. The Lands Between realize that impossible city. Their present contains their past not as memory but as sealed strata, and the Tarnished's journey is an excavation that breaks seals. The apocalyptic tradition knew this structure. In the Revelation of John (chapters 5–8) the book of the world's destiny is sealed with seven seals, only one found worthy may open them, and each opening releases a catastrophe. The Tarnished is not the Lamb of that vision, but the Tarnished occupies its structural position: the one permitted to break the seals of an order that kept its world intact by sealing it.

2.5

THE ERDTREE: WORLD TREE, GALLOWS, ROOT, AND THORN

The Erdtree is the first thing a player sees on emerging into the open world and the last thing the world loses. Visible from almost every point of the Lands Between, golden, luminous, and immense, it organizes the space of the game in the most literal sense: players orient themselves by it, and the rays of grace that guide the Tarnished point along lines that converge upon its capital. Its lesser replicas, the Minor Erdtrees, stand guarded by colossal avatars across the provinces, and its roots descend beneath the world into the Deeproot Depths. Mircea Eliade called this structure the *axis mundi*, the sacred center at which heaven, earth, and the underworld communicate and from which a profane, homogeneous extension is organized into a cosmos (Eliade 1958; 1959). Its arboreal form, the world tree, recurs across the religions Eliade surveyed: Yggdrasil, whose roots reach the realms of gods, giants, and the dead; the birch the Siberian shaman climbs into the sky; the tree beneath which the Buddha awakened; and the cross, which Christian liturgy made the *lignum vitae*, the tree of life restored.

Two medieval texts disclose what the Erdtree's gold conceals. The Old English *Dream of the Rood* recounts a vision of the cross as a tree of surpassing beauty that alternates between two appearances: *hwīlum hit wæs mid wætan bestēmed, / beswyled mid swātes gange, hwīlum mid since gegyrwed* (22–23), at times it was soaked with wet, stained with the flowing of blood, at times adorned with treasure. The golden tree and the bloody gallows are one

object seen in alternation. The final revelation of *Elden Ring* is of exactly this kind. When the Tarnished at last enters the Erdtree, what waits within is the shattered body of Marika, bound and broken at the heart of the tree and doubled by Radagon, who is herself; the gold of the world's axis is disclosed as the setting of a crucified god. The *Hávamál* supplies the Northern form of the same disclosure. Odin recounts that he hung on the windswept tree for nine full nights, wounded with a spear, "given to Odin, myself to myself" (*gefinn Óðni, sjálfr sjálfum mér*), on a tree whose roots no one knows, and that he looked down, took up the runes screaming, and fell back (138–139). The god is sacrificed by himself to himself on the world tree in order to win the runes. The name Yggdrasil has long been understood as "the steed of Yggr," Yggr being a name of Odin and the steed the gallows on which the hanged man rides. The world tree is a gallows, its fruit is a god, and its yield is runes. Marika, bound within the Erdtree with a consort who is herself, keeper of a Ring made of runes, reenacts Odin's self-sacrifice with uncanny precision: a god given to itself, upon a tree, for the sake of runes. Chapter 4 returns to the "myself to myself" of this formula as a key to the identity of Radagon and Marika.

The Erdtree's gold is nourished from below. Under the Golden Order the dead are not burned but interred in catacombs beneath the land, guarded by the Erdtree Burial Watchdogs, to be taken up into the tree's roots and so returned to the source of grace. The golden canopy rests upon a necropolis. The incorruptible tree is fed by corruption, and the gold the Order displays as the sign of its exemption from death is metabolized from the bodies of the dead. The Norse world tree knew this dependency and did not conceal it. In the *Grímnismál* (35), Odin declares that the ash Yggdrasil suffers more hardship than men know: a hart bites it above, it rots on its side, and Níðhöggr gnaws it from beneath. The world tree is a rotting tree, and its decay is part of its being. In Snorri's *Gylfaginning*, the Norns who dwell by the well of Urðr, whose name means "what has come to pass," draw water each day and pour it with the white clay of the well over the ash, so that its limbs may not wither or rot. The tree is sustained by the past. The Erdtree is sustained by the past in a more literal and more sinister sense, by the dead who are its compost; and the Scarlet Rot that blooms across its provinces, the decaying avatars that guard its minor trees, and the Deathroot that spreads through its roots after Godwyn's death are the return of the truth about world trees that the Golden Order's gold denied: that they rot, and that their life is drawn from death.

The Erdtree is also an image of thought and of power. Gilles Deleuze and Félix Guattari opened *A Thousand Plateaus* (1980) with an attack on the tree as the dominant model of Western thought: hierarchical, centered, genealogical, proceeding from root through trunk to ramification by binary division, and inseparable from the form of the State. Against it they set the rhizome, the acentered, nonhierarchical, subterranean network that connects any point to any other, and they declared themselves weary of trees. The Erdtree is the arborescent principle enthroned. Its order is genealogical, the "golden lineage" descending from Marika as branches from a trunk; hierarchical, with the demigods as its boughs and the Omens as shoots pruned and buried; and centralized, a single tree at the center

of the world, replicated in the provinces by the Minor Erdtrees as the State replicates itself in its administrative seats. Medieval Christian art had its own figure of arborescent sovereignty, the Tree of Jesse, in which the royal genealogy of Christ springs from the body of a sleeping patriarch. The counter-powers of the Lands Between are, by contrast, rhizomatic in structure. The Deathroot spreads through subterranean roots without a center; the Scarlet Rot propagates mycelially through soil, flesh, and water; the Frenzied Flame passes from eye to eye. The crisis of the Golden Order is, among other things, the crisis of the tree as a model of order, and its endings may be read as so many proposals for what might replace it.

A further tradition reverses the tree's orientation and, with it, its value. The *Kaṭha Upaniṣad* (6.1) speaks of an eternal fig whose roots are above and branches below, and the *Bhagavad Gītā* (15.1–3) takes up the image: the imperishable *aśvattha*, roots above and branches below, whose leaves are the Vedic hymns, whose real form is not perceived in this world, and which must be cut down with the strong axe of detachment before the path from which there is no return can be sought. Here the world tree is not a sacred center to be preserved but the structure of bondage itself, the tree of *saṃsāra*, and liberation requires its felling. Kabbalistic speculation, too, knew the image of a tree rooted above and spreading downward into the world. *Elden Ring* stands closer to the *Gītā* than to Eliade. The Erdtree must burn for any ending to be reached, so that every future of the Lands Between, without exception, presupposes the destruction of the world tree. The *axis mundi* is not the sacred center to which the hero returns but the structure the hero must destroy for the world to change.

The tree's final defense is a barrier of thorns. After the Shattering, the base of the Erdtree is sealed by a mass of thorny growth that bars every entrant, and the Tarnished learns that nothing but fire can open it. The image has a fairy-tale ancestor whose details correspond with disquieting exactness. In the Grimms' "Little Briar Rose" ("Dornröschen," *Kinder- und Hausmärchen* 50), a king celebrating his daughter's birth can invite only twelve of the thirteen wise women of his realm, because he owns only twelve golden plates. The thirteenth, excluded, arrives unbidden and curses the child. The curse, softened by the twelfth gift, becomes a sleep of a hundred years in which the whole castle, its court, its hearth-fires, and its kitchens are arrested in a single instant, while a hedge of briars grows around it and kills the princes who try to pass. When the hundred years are complete, the thorns turn to flowers and part of their own accord. The sequence of the tale (an exclusion dictated by a scarcity of gold, a curse born of the exclusion, the arrest of time, a hedge of thorns, a liberating entry) maps onto the Golden Order point for point: an order of gold that excluded the Omens at birth; the curses the excluded return upon it, from the Dung Eater's Seedbed Curse to the Fell Omen who haunts the capital's approaches; the stasis of a deathless realm; the thorns of the Erdtree; the Tarnished's entry. The difference is the one that matters. In the tale the thorns yield to time. In the Lands Between they yield only to fire, because in a world from which death has been removed the hundred years can never be complete. Time cannot open what deathlessness has closed.

A last comparison concerns what follows the death of a luminous tree. In Tolkien's *Silmarillion* (1977), the Two Trees of Valinor, silver Telperion and golden Laurelin, whose mingled light measured the first ages of the world, are destroyed by Melkor and the spider Ungoliant. From their last flower and last fruit the Valar fashion the Moon and the Sun, and at the first rising of the Sun the Second-born awaken: Men, the mortals, whose gift is death. In Tolkien's myth the death of the golden tree inaugurates the age of mortals. *Elden Ring* arrives at the same structure by another road. The burning of the golden tree is the condition of re-mortalization, and in one of its endings the Lands Between pass under the governance of a moon and its stars. The expansion adds a coda Tanizaki would have appreciated. In the Land of Shadow grows the Scadutree, whose name compounds the Old English *sceadu*, shadow: the Erdtree's concealed counterpart, gold seen at last against its own darkness.

2.6

THE ELDEN BEAST AND THE RING: LEVIATHAN, NOMOS, AND AMENDMENT

The last adversary of *Elden Ring* is not a person but a law. When Radagon, the second Elden Lord, falls before the shattered Marika, the Elden Beast emerges: a vast, serpentine form of golden light swimming through a void sown with stars, the Greater Will's vassal and the living embodiment of order. The Ring and the Beast are one. The law of the world is an animal, and the decisive combat of the game is fought against it. The image has a precise ancestry in political theology. In the Book of Job the Leviathan is the creature beyond all human mastery ("Canst thou draw out leviathan with an hook?", 41:1), and the chapter closes with a verse that might stand over the Lands Between: "he is a king over all the children of pride" (41:34). Thomas Hobbes took the monster's name for the commonwealth itself. His *Leviathan* (1651) calls the sovereign state an "Artificiall Man" and "that Mortall God, to which wee owe under the Immortall God, our peace and defence," and its frontispiece shows a crowned giant composed of the bodies of his subjects, rising above a landscape with sword and crozier in hand. Carl Schmitt, in his study of the Hobbesian symbol (1938), observed that the Leviathan combines four natures, god, man, animal, and machine. The order of the Lands Between is composed of the same four: a god, the Greater Will; a human sovereign, Marika and her Elden Lords; an animal, the Beast; and a machine, the code of runes that constitutes the Ring.

The difference that matters lies in Hobbes's adjective. The Leviathan is a *mortal* god. Hobbes was emphatic that commonwealths can die, devoting a chapter of *Leviathan* (29) to the diseases that weaken them and tend to their dissolution, and he understood sovereignty as an artifice that must be sustained against a natural tendency to collapse into the war of all against all. The Golden Order made the opposite wager. It sought to make the

mortal god immortal, removing death from the law of the world and thereby exempting its sovereign order from the condition Hobbes regarded as its truth. The result is the Shattering, which is, in Hobbesian terms, the dissolution of a commonwealth by intestine disorder and the return of the state of nature among the demigods. Hobbes described life in that state as "solitary, poore, nasty, brutish, and short" (ch. 13). The demigods' condition after the Shattering inverts the final term. Their war has no victor because none of them can die by ordinary means, and their life is solitary, poor, nasty, brutish, and interminable. The Hobbesian state of nature is terrible because it is short; the state of nature after the Shattering is terrible because it is endless. That the Tarnished must kill the demigods in order to end their war is, on this reading, not a heroic convention but a political necessity. An immortal war can end only when death is restored to its combatants.

Schmitt's later work supplies a spatial complement. In *The Nomos of the Earth* (1950) he argued that every legal order rests upon an originary act of land-appropriation (*Landnahme*), and that the Greek *nomos*, from *nemein*, to take, to divide, to pasture, names this unity of order and orientation before it names any law. Marika's order was such an appropriation: an arrival, a conquest in alliance with Godfrey, wars against the giants and against Caria, the planting of a tree at the center of the world, and the extension of the tree's claim to the dead beneath the earth. The expansion discloses the underside of that *nomos*. The Land of Shadow is the land in which Marika first set foot and which she afterward veiled; there Messmer, her son, carried out a purge of the Hornsent by fire, a crusade whose ruins and pyres the player traverses. Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) distinguished the violence that founds law from the violence that preserves it, and both from a "divine" violence that destroys law without founding any. The Land of Shadow is the site of the Golden Order's law-founding violence, hidden behind its law-preserving glory; and Marika's shattering of her own Ring, considered in Chapter 4, may be the nearest the Lands Between come to Benjamin's third kind.

The Ring itself is a text. Its constituents are runes, and the word preserves a double sense the game exploits: Old Norse *rún* and Gothic *rūna* signify a secret, a mystery, a counsel, and also a written character, so that Odin in the *Hávamál* wins the runes as knowledge and as script at once. The Elden Ring is a ring of letters, a written law, its Great Runes the articles of a constitution. The founding act of the Golden Order was the excision of one rune, the Rune of Death, so that the law of the world became a text from which a single clause had been struck: the clause of mortality. The game's vocabulary of repair is correspondingly legal and philological. English *mend* is an aphetic form of *amend*, from Old French *amender* and Latin *emendare*, to free from fault, the root of the philologist's *emendation*, the correction of a corrupt text. The Mending Runes by which the Tarnished may restore the Ring are amendments in the constitutional sense and emendations in the textual sense; each proposes the correction of a corrupt law. The Tarnished who chooses among them exercises what Emmanuel-Joseph Sieyès called *pouvoir constituant*, the constituent power that stands outside and before every constituted order, and which Schmitt's *Constitutional Theory* (1928) defined as the political will capable of

the concrete decision on the type and form of a people's existence. The final scene of the game is a constituent moment: an exile before an empty throne and a broken text, deciding by which amendment the world shall henceforth be governed.

Paul wrote that "the letter killeth, but the spirit giveth life" (2 Corinthians 3:6). The Golden Order inverts the dictum with lethal irony. Its letter does not kill; that is its curse. A law from which the clause of death has been struck is a law that will not let die, and what it produces is not eternal life but its parody: demigods who cannot be succeeded, a dead prince whose body will not stop living, a tree that cannot fall. The Ring had to be amended because, as written, it could end nothing, and a law that can end nothing cannot give life.

2.7

THE THEOGONY OF DEPARTURES: ABSENCE, THE GOLDEN CALF, AND FREEDOM

Hesiod's gods succeed one another by violence. Ouranos is castrated by his son; Kronos swallows his children and is overthrown by the one he failed to swallow; the reign of Zeus is secured by war. The Hurrian-Hittite cycle of Kumarbi and the *Enuma Elish* share the pattern of generational overthrow. The gods of the Lands Between succeed one another differently, and the figure who discloses the difference is Placidusax. The dragon who ruled as Elden Lord before the Erdtree did not fall to a younger god's violence. His god departed, and he remains, in a city held outside time, awaiting a return that has not come. The Greater Will, in its turn, arrives, establishes its order, and withdraws. Divine history in the Lands Between is not a series of victories but a series of desertions, and its faithful are those who keep vigil for gods who have left: a dragon in a storm of time, Fingers that continue to speak, a Reader who continues to translate.

The expansion gives this vigil its most desolate form. In the Finger Ruins of Miyr lies Metyr, Mother of Fingers, the matriarch of the Greater Will's emissaries, abandoned in the aftermath of the voice she once relayed, while above, in the Cathedral of Manus Metyr, a priesthood maintains the institutions of an oracle whose source has gone silent. The classical tradition knew this condition. Plutarch's dialogue *On the Obsolescence of Oracles* asks why the oracles of Greece have fallen silent, and it preserves the story of the pilot Thamus who, passing the island of Paxi, was commanded by a voice to announce that the Great Pan was dead, and who heard, when he did so, a great cry of lamentation rise from the sea. Max Weber described the sociological counterpart as the routinization of charisma (*Veralltäglichung des Charismas*): when the bearer of extraordinary authority departs, that authority survives by being converted into tradition and office, administered by those who did not themselves receive it (Weber 1978 [1922]). The Golden Order is the routinized charisma of the Greater Will's arrival, an apparatus of Fingers, Readers, Maidens, priests,

and knights that persists after the event that founded it, administering the letter of a will that no longer speaks.

2

Gold is what remains when a god withdraws. The biblical paradigm is exact. When Moses delays upon the mountain, the people, deprived of their mediator, demand gods to go before them; Aaron melts their earrings into a golden calf, and they proclaim, "These be thy gods, O Israel" (Exodus 32:4). The golden image is the answer to the absence of presence, a substitute that makes the departed divine visible, permanent, and incorruptible in the most durable of metals. Moses, descending and seeing the calf, casts the tablets of the law from his hands and breaks them beneath the mountain (32:19); afterward he hews a second pair, and the law is given again (34:1–4). Read against this narrative, the chrysopoeic project acquires its theological motive. The Golden Order is a golden calf: gold as the substitute for a presence that has withdrawn, the attempt to secure in incorruptible form what can no longer be secured in living relation. Its shattering is the breaking of the tablets, a law broken in the presence of its idol, and the Mending is the hewing of a second law. Rabbinic tradition preserved a detail of this history that will prove decisive in Chapter 10. According to the Babylonian Talmud (*Berakhot* 8b), the fragments of the first, broken tablets were not discarded. They were placed in the Ark beside the whole tablets of the second giving and carried with them through the wilderness. The repaired law traveled with its own fragments. No image could better anticipate what this thesis calls fracture-faithful repair.

The Homeric frame introduced in §2.3 now yields its formula. The *Odyssey* is a poem of return. An exile, long absent, crosses the sea, enters his own house unrecognized in the guise of a beggar, is tested and mocked, strings the bow no suitor can bend, and reclaims the hall; throughout, a goddess guides him in a succession of disguises, appearing as a guest-friend, a girl with a water jar, a young shepherd, the old companion Mentor. The Tarnished's itinerary repeats the structure: exile beyond the sea, return in the lowest guise, the trials of the suitors, and the guidance of Melina, who appears at sites of grace and vanishes at will, and whose origin and purpose remain veiled until the Forge. But the *Odyssey* restores a lord to his own house, and *Elden Ring* does not. The absent lord of the Lands Between does not return. The one who returns is the exile, and the exile does not reclaim a throne but assumes one that was never his. In the vocabulary appropriate to a theogony of departures, *nostos* replaces *parousia*: the second coming of the god is replaced by the homecoming of the outcast, and it is the outcast, not the god, who decides the shape of the world to come.

The three readings of withdrawal set out in §2.2 can now be adjudicated. The Platonic reading, on which the god's departure is a neglect to be repaired by the god's return, is embodied in Placidusax, and it is the reading the game most clearly declines: no god returns, and the dragon's fidelity has become indistinguishable from imprisonment in a storm of time. The tragic reading, on which the god is hidden but watching, is embodied in the Fingers and in Marika, and the game sustains it as the horizon of the Golden Order's own consciousness. But the structure of the whole privileges the Lurianic reading, on which withdrawal is the condition of freedom. Only in the silence of the Greater Will can alternative orders be conceived, proposed, and chosen; only because the god has withdrawn

can an exile stand before the Ring and decide. Simone Weil's theology of creation as abdication and Hans Jonas's God who renounced power so that the world might be its own describe with uncomfortable precision the condition of the Lands Between at the moment of the endings. The game does not, however, permit the Lurianic reading to become a consolation. The withdrawal that opens the space of freedom opens it equally to the Outer Gods: rot, frenzy, and blood enter the world through the same absence that permits choice. Freedom and catastrophe share a single condition. *Elden Ring* thus offers something rarer than a theodicy, which would justify the god, and rarer than an atheology, which would dispense with it: a theology of absence in which the god's departure is at once the source of the world's ruin and the ground of its liberty, and in which the only response adequate to that departure is neither to await the god's return nor to fix the god's law in gold, but to decide.

2.8

CONCLUSION: THE GOLDEN TABLES IN THE GRASS

THE COSMOLOGY reconstructed in this chapter may be summarized in six propositions. First, the cosmos of the Lands Between is exogenous: its order arrived from outside a world that preceded it, and the native condition of that world is mixture. Second, its highest power is an alien demiurge, a will that both transcends the world and legislates for it, ruling through an angelic bureaucracy and now withdrawn into silence, so that the Gnostic flight to a higher god is foreclosed. Third, its theology is polarized between law and contagion, between the *nomos* of the Greater Will and the *miasma* of the other Outer Gods, and the collapse of the former has returned the world to a Weberian war of impersonal gods. Fourth, its history is a stratigraphy of sealed orders (Crucible, dragons, giants, gold) in which each age imprisons its predecessor rather than abolishing it, and in which the golden age stands at the turning point between a theogonic ascent and a metallic decline. Fifth, its world tree is a gallows fed by the dead and guarded by thorns, which must be burned before any future can begin. Sixth, its Ring is a Leviathan of law, a mortal god whose mortality was struck from its own text, so that the end of the game takes the form of a constituent moment in which an exile amends a corrupt law before an empty throne.

Taken together, these propositions describe a theogony without precise precedent: a theogony of departures, in which gods succeed one another not by overthrow but by abandonment, in which gold is what remains when presence withdraws, and in which the homecoming of the outcast takes the place of the return of the god. The chrysopoeia of the Golden Order appears, in this light, as the response of an abandoned world to its abandonment: the attempt to fix in incorruptible form a law whose author had fallen silent, and to secure it by sealing away everything that could corrupt it, above all death. Chapter 3 examines that sealing.

The *Völuspá* closes with an image that may stand as this chapter's emblem. After Ragnarök, after the fire of Surtr and the sinking of the earth, the earth rises a second time from the sea, green and renewed. The surviving gods meet again on the plain of Iðavöllr, where once they played at tables lacking nothing of gold; they speak of the great serpent, and they recall the mighty judgments and the ancient runes of Fimbultýr. And there, in the grass, they find again the wondrous golden tables, *gullnar töflur*, which they had owned in the days of old. The word signifies both gaming pieces and tablets. What survives the twilight of the gods is not their order but its pieces, found in the grass and recognized: the runes remembered, the game resumed. It would be difficult to devise a more exact figure for the relation of the player to the Golden Order. The order is gone. What the player finds, scattered through the grass of the Lands Between, are its golden pieces and its ancient runes; and the gods' game, recovered in fragments, is the game the player plays.

What survives the twilight of the gods is not their order but its pieces, found in the grass and recognized: the runes remembered, the game resumed.

CHAPTER 2 · §2.8

ME ONLY CRUEL IMMORTALITY CONSUMES · ME ONLY CRUEL IMMORTALITY CONSUMES · ME ONLY CRUEL IMMORTALITY CONSUMES · ME ONLY CRUEL IMMORTALITY CONSUMES ·

CHAPTER

3

THE SEALING OF DEATH

Immortality Projects and the Pathology of the Deathless

lest he put forth his hand, and take also of the tree of life, and eat, and live for ever

— Genesis 3:22

Me only cruel immortality Consumes

— Alfred Tennyson, "Tithonus" (1860)

3.1

THE EXCISION: DESTINED DEATH AND THE FOUNDING OF THE GOLDEN ORDER

The Golden Order began with a subtraction. The game's texts relate that it was inaugurated when the Rune of Death was removed from the Elden Ring and sealed within the blade of Maliketh, Marika's Shadowbound Beast; with that act, Destined Death was taken out of the law of the world, and the age of the Erdtree began. The Japanese name of what was removed, 運命の死 (*unmei no shi*), is more exact than its English rendering. It designates not death as such, which in some form persists, but fated death: death as the destiny proper to each being, the death that completes a life rather than merely ending it. Under the Golden Order mortals still perish, cut down by blade and plague, but their perishing is no longer the fulfillment of a destiny. The dead are gathered into the roots of the Erdtree and held there, and the demigods, Marika's offspring, cannot die at all until a fragment of the sealed rune is stolen and turned against one of them. The age of gold was therefore not an age without dying. It was an age without the death that ends.

The founding act inverts the founding prohibition of the biblical tradition. In Genesis, after the expulsion from the garden, God sets cherubim and a flaming sword that turns every way to keep the way of the tree of life, lest the man put forth his hand, take of its fruit, and live forever (3:22–24). Death is preserved by guarding the tree; a sword stands between humanity and deathlessness. In the Lands Between the relation is reversed. The tree becomes the instrument of deathlessness, and a sword is set to guard not the tree from humanity but humanity from death: Maliketh's Black Blade holds Destined Death away from the world as the cherub's sword held the world away from eternal life. Maliketh is the cherub of Eden turned inside out. The inversion is not a parody but a precise transformation. Genesis treats mortality as the condition of a fallen creature that must not be permitted to perpetuate its fall; the Golden Order treats mortality as a defect that a perfected order may abolish. The narrative of *Elden Ring* will vindicate Genesis against the Golden Order, though not for Genesis's reasons.

Two modern philosophies of death frame the excision. Ernest Becker argued in *The Denial of Death* (1973) that the human being, a creature conscious of its own mortality, cannot bear that consciousness directly and therefore constructs immortality projects (religions, nations, works, heroisms) through which it seeks to become *causa sui*, its own cause, exempt from the creaturely condition. The Golden Order is an immortality project of cosmic scale, distinguished from those Becker analyzed only in that it accomplishes literally what human cultures achieve symbolically. Martin Heidegger argued in *Being and Time* (1927) that death is Dasein's ownmost, non-relational, certain, and indefinite possibility, the possibility of its own impossibility, and that only in anticipatory resoluteness toward

that possibility can existence become whole and authentically its own; the everyday "they" (*das Man*) flees the possibility by converting it into an event that happens to someone else, sometime, a case of death. The Golden Order institutionalizes the flight of the "they" at the level of metaphysics. It does not merely tranquilize the thought of death; it removes the possibility itself. In Heidegger's terms it produces a world in which no existence can become whole, because none can come to an end, and the pathologies examined in this chapter are the consequences of that impossibility.

The excision has a lineage within FromSoftware's own corpus that clarifies its significance. *Dark Souls* (2011) imagined an Age of Fire artificially prolonged by its lord's self-immolation, a prolongation motivated, as the primordial serpent Kaathe alleges, by fear of the coming dark and of the age of humanity it would bring; its undead are cursed to rise again and again, hollowing as they lose themselves. *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice* (2019) made the critique of immortality explicit and mechanical. Its protagonist, bound to an immortal lord, can return from death, but each return spreads among the people around him a wasting sickness called Dragonrot: the protagonist's deathlessness is paid for by the world's illness. Its most celebrated ending is titled "Immortal Severance," and it consists precisely in cutting the bond of deathlessness so that death may resume its course. *Elden Ring* generalizes this structure from a person to a cosmos. Its Golden Order is the immortal lord of *Sekiro* written into the law of the world, and its Shattering is Dragonrot raised to the scale of a civilization.

3.2

THE DISPLACEMENT OF THE DEAD: GHOSTFLAME, BURIAL, AND THE NECROPOLITICS OF GOLD

Every regime of death is also a regime of the dead. The Golden Order did not merely remove Destined Death from the law of the world; it reorganized what was to be done with those who die. Item lore associates an older funerary dispensation with the Deathbirds, gaunt avian figures that still stalk the Lands Between by night, and with ghostflame, the cold blue fire they wield: before the Erdtree claimed the dead, it appears, the dead were given to this fire. The Golden Order replaced cremation with interment. Its dead are laid in catacombs beneath the land, guarded by the feline statues called Erdtree Burial Watchdogs, which recall the animal guardians of the Egyptian necropoleis, so that they may be taken up into the roots of the tree. The change is the funerary correlate of the excision of Destined Death. A fire that consumes the dead releases them; a tree that absorbs the dead retains them. Cremation is an end. Arboreal burial is storage.

The comparative history of funerary practice gives the contrast its depth. In the Vedic hymn for the cremation of the dead (*Ṛgveda* 10.16), Agni, the fire, is implored not to burn the dead man wholly away but to make him ready and send him on to the Fathers; cremation

is a passage, and the fire a psychopomp. The excarnation practiced in the Zoroastrian *dakhmas* and in the Tibetan sky burial, in which the dead are given to vultures, makes the bird the agent of the body's release, and the Deathbirds of the Lands Between, which unite the avian psychopomp with the cremating fire, condense both traditions into a single figure of release. Christian inhumation, by contrast, plants the dead in the earth like seed in expectation of a bodily resurrection; the Roman catacombs were, in this sense, granaries of the resurrection. The Erdtree burial resembles Christian inhumation in form and inverts it in meaning. Its dead are not sown for the resurrection of their own bodies but composted for the perpetual life of the tree. The grave is not a waiting room but a root system.

Michel Foucault characterized the emergence of modern biopolitics as the replacement of the sovereign's ancient right to take life or let live by a power to foster life or disallow it to the point of death (Foucault 1978 [1976]). Achille Mbembe's "Necropolitics" (2003) insisted that sovereignty continues to express itself, at its limit, as the power to dictate who may live and who must die, and to administer death-worlds in which whole populations are held in the status of the living dead. The Golden Order is biopolitical and necropolitical at once, in a sense neither theorist anticipated. It fosters life absolutely, by forbidding the death that ends it, and it extends sovereignty over the dead themselves, appropriating their bodies as the substance of its central symbol. Robert Pogue Harrison, in *The Dominion of the Dead* (2003), argued that human beings are the species that buries, that the grave humanizes the ground, and that the institutions of the living rest upon a relation to the dead of indebtedness and inheritance: the dead hold dominion over the living through the places, words, and forms they bequeath. The Golden Order reverses the direction of that dominion. It is not the dead who hold dominion over the living but the order that holds dominion over the dead, and the dead do not found human places but feed a sovereign tree. The gold of the Erdtree is, in the most literal sense, a necropolitical gold.

The dead, however, do not consent to their storage. After the Night of the Black Knives, the death that should have completed Godwyn's body did not complete it. His soul died, but his flesh lived on, and from his corpse there spread through the roots of the Erdtree a growth called Deathroot, which carried into the tree's vascular system a death that could neither finish nor be finished. From the Deathroot arose Those Who Live in Death: skeletons that reassemble after being struck down, revenants that wander catacombs and battlefields, the dead who will not stay dead. The tree that fed upon the dead was poisoned by a death it could not digest. The storage of the dead became the revolt of the dead, and the Golden Order, which had appropriated death's substance, found itself occupied by death's specter.

3.3

THE NIGHT OF THE BLACK KNIVES: GODWYN, BALDR, OSIRIS

The Night of the Black Knives is the first event of the Shattering and the hinge of the Lands Between's history. On that night, assassins bearing daggers imbued with a fragment of Destined Death, stolen from Maliketh's seal, struck down Godwyn the Golden, firstborn of Marika and Godfrey and the most beloved of the demigods. In the same hour Ranni, the Carian princess and Empyrean who had orchestrated the theft, used the stolen death to slay her own flesh, discarding the body through which the Two Fingers had meant to bind her to their design. The assassins were women, reputed to be Numen of Marika's own kin, a detail that has led many interpreters to suspect that the god was complicit in the murder of her son. The killing was incomplete in a precise and consequential way. Godwyn died in soul but not in body: the first demigod ever to die was only half dead. Ranni died in body but not in soul, and continued as a spirit housed in a doll. The single act that returned death to the deathless order thus divided death itself along the line between body and soul, producing a corpse without a person and a person without a corpse.

The structural antecedent is the death of Baldr. In Snorri's *Gylfaginning* (49), Baldr, the most beautiful and best-loved of the gods, dreams of his death, and his mother Frigg exacts an oath from fire and water, iron and every metal, stones, earth, trees, sicknesses, beasts, birds, and serpents that they will not harm him. The gods make sport of his invulnerability by hurling weapons at him. Only the mistletoe, which Frigg thought too young to be put on oath, is exempt; Loki fashions a dart from it and guides the hand of Baldr's blind brother Höðr, and Baldr falls, the first death among the gods and the greatest misfortune ever to befall them. The correspondences are structural and exact: a beloved golden god rendered invulnerable by a universal exemption from harm; a single exception withheld from that exemption, the mistletoe in one case and the sealed rune in the other; a conspirator who weaponizes the exception, Loki and Ranni; an instrument whose agency is borrowed, the blind Höðr and the Black Knives; and a first death among the immortals that inaugurates the end of their age. The parallel extends to the sequel. Hermóðr rides to Hel to beg Baldr's release, and Hel consents on condition that all things in the world weep for him; all weep but one giantess in a cave, whom the tradition identifies as Loki in disguise, and Baldr remains among the dead. Yet the *Vǫluspá* promises in its closing stanzas that after Ragnarök Baldr will come back to the renewed world. Fia's Mending Rune of the Death-Prince, which would make Godwyn the sovereign of an age in which those who live in death are welcomed, is Baldr's return transposed into the Lands Between.

The Egyptian myth of Osiris supplies the sequel that the Norse myth leaves implicit. In Plutarch's account (*Isis and Osiris* 13–18), Osiris is lured by his brother Set into a coffer, cast into the Nile, and later dismembered, his body scattered across Egypt; Isis gathers the pieces and restores him, and he becomes lord of the dead in the Duat. Egyptian sources

add what Plutarch's Greek decorum softens. The Great Hymn to Osiris on the stela of Amenmose describes Isis hovering over the inert body of her husband in the form of a bird, making shade with her feathers and breath with her wings, rousing the weary one from his inertness, receiving his seed, and bearing the heir, Horus, who will claim the throne (Lichtheim 1976). A goddess lies with a dead god and brings forth the instrument of a new order. Fia, the Deathbed Companion, follows this pattern with remarkable fidelity. Having warmed the living Tarnished in her embrace, she descends to the Deeproot Depths and lies with the corpse of Godwyn, the Prince of Death, and from that union brings forth the Mending Rune of the Death-Prince, the instrument of an order in which life and death are no longer held apart. Godwyn is Osiris, the dead god who becomes lord of the dead; Fia is Isis, who conceives the future upon the corpse; and the Age of the Duskborn she would inaugurate is the Egyptian answer to the problem the Golden Order created: neither the abolition of death nor its simple return, but its enthronement.

A third ancient text illuminates the most poignant of Godwyn's survivals. The ancient dragon Fortissax, defeated by Godwyn in battle and thereafter his friend, entered the dead prince's dreams to fight the death that festered there, and was himself corrupted by it, becoming the Lichdragon whom the Tarnished meets in the Deeproot Depths. The friend who will not surrender his friend to death is the hero of the oldest epic in the world. In the *Epic of Gilgamesh*, when Enkidu dies, Gilgamesh refuses to give up the body for burial until a maggot drops from its nostril (Tablet X), and then sets out across the world in search of a life that will not end. The alewife Siduri tells him, in the Old Babylonian version, that when the gods created humankind they allotted death to it and kept life in their own hands; and the plant of rejuvenation he finally wins from the bottom of the sea is carried off by a serpent while he bathes. Gilgamesh returns to Uruk with nothing but the sight of its walls, the human work that will outlast him (George 1999). Fortissax is Gilgamesh without the return: the friend who fights death on behalf of the beloved and is consumed by the fight, because in the Lands Between there is no Siduri to say that death belongs to mortals, and no wall to which the mourner can go home.

3.4

THE PATHOLOGY OF THE DEATHLESS: TITHONUS, THE STRULDBRUGS, AND THE MAKROPULOS CASE

If the Night of the Black Knives shows what happens when death returns to the deathless partially and by theft, the condition of the surviving demigods shows what happens when it does not return at all. The Shattering has lasted an age without a victor, and its protagonists have not died; they have deteriorated. Each embodies a distinct pathology of deathlessness, and the literature of immortality, from the Homeric hymns to analytic philosophy, has anticipated every one of them.

TABLE 3.1

Pathologies of the deathless.

PATHOLOGY OF DEATHLESSNESS	FIGURE	CONDITION IN THE PRESENT	COMPARATIVE FIGURE
Accumulation without growth	GODRICK THE GRAFTED	Grafts the limbs of the slain onto his body	*Tithonus, withering toward the cicada*
Grief without end	RENNALA, QUEEN OF THE FULL MOON	Cradles an egg of rebirth in her library, abandoned by Radagon	*Miss Havisham and her stopped clocks*
War without end	STARSCOURGE RADAHN	Wanders the dunes of Caelid, his mind consumed by rot	*The einherjar of Valhalla*
Appetite without satiety	RYKARD, LORD OF BLASPHEMY	Has given himself to a serpent that devours gods	*Erysichthon, who devoured himself*
Fidelity without reciprocity	MORGOTT, THE OMEN KING	Guards an order that despised him from birth	*Kafka's doorkeeper before the Law*
Development without maturation	MIQUELLA	Afflicted with eternal childhood	*Barrie's Peter Pan*

The archetype is Tithonus. In the *Homeric Hymn to Aphrodite* (218–238), Eos, the Dawn, asks Zeus to make her mortal lover immortal and forgets to ask that he remain young. While youth lasts they live together at the ends of the earth; when age comes upon him, she shuts him in a chamber, where his voice flows on endlessly though his limbs have lost their strength. Later tradition turned him into a cicada, all voice and no body. Tennyson gave him a dramatic monologue (1860) in which he begs the Dawn to take back her gift: the woods decay and fall, man comes and tills the field and lies beneath, and only he is consumed by cruel immortality; he asks to be released and restored to the ground. Godrick the Grafted is a Tithonian figure in the register of the grotesque. The least of the golden lineage, his blood thinned by generations, he compensates for his decline by grafting to his body the arms and heads of the slain, accumulating limbs as Tithonus accumulates years, growing larger without growing stronger. Rennala, abandoned by Radagon when he left her to become Marika's consort, is the Tithonian condition seen from the side of the one left behind. She sits in the Grand Library of Raya Lucaria cradling the amber egg by which she grants rebirth to others, lost in a grief that time cannot heal because time no longer brings an end. Her literary sister is Dickens's Miss Havisham, who, jilted on her wedding day, stopped every clock in Satis House at twenty minutes to nine and has worn her bridal dress ever since, while the wedding feast rots upon the table (*Great Expectations*, 1861). Rennala's full moon is Miss Havisham's stopped clock.

Jonathan Swift supplied the satirical form of the same insight. In the third part of *Gulliver's Travels* (1726), Gulliver learns of the Struldbrugs of Luggnagg, born immortal, and rhapsodizes about the wisdom and riches he would accumulate in their place, until he is told the truth: they age without dying, are reckoned dead in law at eighty and stripped of their property, lose their memories, and at length lose even the power to converse, since the language of their country changes while they do not; they are, Gulliver concludes, the most mortifying sight he ever beheld. Swift's lesson, that immortality without youth is not a gift but a sentence, is the lesson of the Lands Between, and it is enacted with particular violence in the warrior-demigods. Starscourge Radahn, once the mightiest of them, who mastered gravity to halt the stars, fought Malenia to a standstill at Aeonia and was there consumed by the Scarlet Rot; he now wanders the dunes of Caelid, a husk animated by the habit of war, and the festival held in his name summons warriors to fight him again and again. He is the einherjar of Valhalla without the feast: the chosen slain of Odin's hall, Snorri reports, arm themselves each day, go out into the court, fight and kill one another, and rise again to drink at evening (*Gylfaginning* 41). Rykard, Lord of Blasphemy, who sought to devour the gods themselves and fed himself to the God-Devouring Serpent of Volcano Manor in order to do so, is Erysichthon, the Thessalian king who felled the sacred grove of Ceres and was punished with a hunger no food could satisfy, until at last he consumed his own body (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 8.738–878). That Erysichthon's crime was the felling of a sacred tree adds an irony the game need not state.

The most rigorous philosophical statement of the problem is Bernard Williams's "The Makropulos Case: Reflections on the Tedium of Immortality" (1973). Williams took his

example from Karel Čapek's play *Věc Makropulos* (1922), set as an opera by Janáček (1926), whose heroine has lived for more than three hundred years by virtue of an elixir taken in youth and has become cold, bored, and indifferent, until she declines to renew the elixir and dies. Williams argued that what gives a person reason to go on living are "categorical desires," desires not conditional upon being alive but constitutive of the reasons for living; that an endless life would exhaust them, since a character fixed enough to remain the same person would in time have done everything its character could want; and that a character mutable enough to avoid exhaustion would not survive as the same person. Immortality is therefore either tedious or not one's own. Simone de Beauvoir had dramatized the same dilemma in *All Men Are Mortal* (*Tous les hommes sont mortels*, 1946), whose protagonist, Raymond Fosca, a thirteenth-century Italian lord, drinks an elixir of immortality in order to realize his political ambition across the centuries, and discovers that ambition dissolves when there is infinite time in which to fulfil it, until nothing he does can matter to anyone, himself included. The demigods are Makropulos cases and Foscas. Their categorical desires, the ambitions that critics and the game's own texts alike identify as the motive force of its demigods, have been neither fulfilled nor abandoned; they have curdled into compulsion. Godrick grafts, Rykard devours, Rennala mourns, Radahn fights, Morgott guards, and none of them can stop, because stopping, in a world without Destined Death, has no form. They have come to the end of themselves without coming to an end.

Two further figures complete the clinical picture and anticipate Chapter 5. Morgott, an Omen imprisoned at birth beneath the capital, became the capital's defender, guarding under a veil and a false name an order that had despised him from the cradle; he resembles the doorkeeper of Kafka's parable "Before the Law" (1915), who keeps a door that stands open and that he himself will never pass through. Miquella, the Empyrean afflicted with eternal childhood, embodies the pathology of arrested development: a being that cannot age cannot mature. J. M. Barrie closed *Peter and Wendy* (1911), the book of the boy who would not grow up, by observing that the cycle would go on so long as children are gay and innocent and heartless. The expansion's revelation that Miquella discarded his love in pursuit of godhood gives Barrie's last adjective a theological weight examined in Chapter 5.

3.5

DEATHLESSNESS AND SUCCESSION: THE KING'S TWO BODIES AND THE INVENTION OF SOCIAL DEATH

THE PATHOLOGIES of the deathless are individual; their consequence is political. Ernst Kantorowicz's *The King's Two Bodies* (1957) reconstructed the doctrine by which the jurists of Tudor England resolved the problem of royal mortality. The king, they held, has two bodies: a body natural, mortal and subject to every infirmity that comes by nature or accident, and a body politic, which cannot be seen or handled, consists of policy and

government, and is, in the words reported by Edmund Plowden, "utterly void of Infancy, and old Age, and other natural Defects and Imbecilities." The body natural dies; the body politic does not. At the death of the king, the body politic passes instantaneously to his successor, a transfer the jurists called the "demise" of the crown, and the cry of the French heralds, *le roi est mort, vive le roi*, enacts the doctrine in a single breath. Ralph Giesey's study of the royal funerals of Renaissance France (1960) documented its ceremonial form: for days after a king's death, a lifelike effigy, robed and crowned, received the honors of the living sovereign and was served meals at table, while the corpse lay hidden in its coffin. The immortal dignity and the mortal body were displayed apart so that the one could survive the other. The entire apparatus served a single purpose, which was to permit succession. A dignity that never dies can pass from body to body only because bodies die.

The Golden Order abolished the condition on which the doctrine rests. By removing Destined Death from the law of the world, it made the body natural of its sovereigns as undying as their body politic. Marika and her offspring do not die; the dignity of the Ring and the persons who bear it therefore coincide, and no demise is possible. An undying sovereign cannot be succeeded. This is not a contingent misfortune of the Lands Between but a structural consequence of their founding act, and it explains the peculiar form of the Shattering. When Marika broke the Ring, the body politic of the Golden Order shattered into Great Runes, and the fragments of the dignity lodged in bodies natural that could not die. Each demigod holds a piece of a sovereignty that cannot be transmitted, because transmission requires the death of its holder. The war of the demigods is a war of succession that cannot be concluded, since no claimant can be removed and no inheritance can pass. The mechanics of the game make the point with a literalism that is easily missed. The Tarnished obtains each Great Rune only upon the death of the demigod who holds it. The player does not inherit the runes by right, conquest, or acclamation; the player releases them by killing their bearers. Every Great Rune acquired is a demise of the crown enacted in play, the transfer of a fragment of dignity at the moment of its holder's death. The Tarnished's labor is the restoration of the possibility of succession, which is to say, the restoration of death to the sovereigns.

Fumito Ueda's *Shadow of the Colossus* (2005), the work of the designer whose earlier *Ico* Miyazaki has credited with his decision to make games, gave this logic its most haunting interactive form. Its young protagonist, seeking to revive a dead girl, bargains with a disembodied voice called Dormin and sets out to slay sixteen colossi scattered across a forbidden land. Each colossus falls with a lament, and each death releases a dark stream that enters the hero's body, until it emerges that the colossi held the sealed fragments of Dormin itself, and that the player, in killing them, has been reassembling a divided god. The demigods of the Lands Between stand in the same relation to the Great Runes as the colossi to the fragments of Dormin, and the Tarnished, like Ueda's wanderer, gathers a broken sovereignty by killing its vessels. The difference lies in what the gathering serves. Ueda's hero restores a sealed power at the cost of his own corruption; the Tarnished releases

what the demigods could not surrender because they could not die, and the restoration it serves is the restoration of death.

The anthropology of sacred kingship, whatever the defects of its method, preserves the mythic form of this logic. James George Frazer's *The Golden Bough* (1890; third edition 1906–15) opens with the priest-king of Diana's grove at Nemi, the *rex Nemorensis*, who holds his office until a successor plucks a golden bough from the sacred tree and slays him, and builds upon that rite the thesis that divine kings, on whose vigor the fertility of the land depends, must be put to death before their powers decline, lest the land decline with them. Frazer's comparative edifice has not survived the criticism of modern anthropology, and Jonathan Z. Smith's dissection of the category of "dying and rising gods" (1987) is decisive on its scholarly merits. But as a structure of the mythic imagination, which is what *Elden Ring* reworks, Frazer's divine king retains its force; and his golden bough, which he identified with the mistletoe that killed Baldr, is not far from the golden runes that the Tarnished plucks from its kings. The medieval romance of the Grail, as Jessie Weston read it (1920) and as T. S. Eliot borrowed it for *The Waste Land*, gives the same logic a Christian inflection: the Fisher King is wounded and cannot die, and his land lies waste around him until the questing knight arrives. Wagner's *Parsifal* (1882) made the point unbearable. Its Amfortas, wounded by the spear he failed to guard, is kept alive against his will by the sight of the Grail, and in the final act he begs his knights to kill him. The demigods of the Lands Between are Amfortases, kept alive by the sacred fragments they hold, ruling a waste land that their survival perpetuates.

One further consequence of the Golden Order's deathlessness has passed almost unremarked in the criticism of the game, and it bears directly on the identity of its protagonist. If no sovereign can die, how was Godfrey, the first Elden Lord, ever replaced by Radagon? The lore's answer is exile. Godfrey was not killed. Grace faded from his eyes, and he and his warriors were driven across the sea to wage war in other lands, becoming the first of the Tarnished. In an order without death, removal takes the form of banishment, and the fading of grace performs the function that death performs in a mortal polity: it ends a tenure, vacates an office, and permits a successor. Tarnishment is the death that the deathless order invented to replace the one it had abolished. Orlando Patterson's comparative study of slavery (1982) defined the slave's condition as "social death," constituted by natal alienation, the severance of every claim of kinship and ancestry; by generalized dishonor; and by permanent subjection to another's will. The Tarnished are socially dead in Patterson's precise sense: severed from the Lands Between, dishonored by the loss of grace, subject to the Order's judgment of exclusion. The opening narration's address to them as dead who yet live is therefore not a figure of speech but a juridical description. The Golden Order abolished biological death for its elect and instituted social death for its exiles. Its deathlessness was purchased, here as in the sewers beneath its capital, by the production of a class of the living dead. That this class should be summoned back to restore death to the world is the deepest irony of the game's design and the clearest evidence for the thesis that

its protagonist is the subject of a counter-ontology. The Tarnished bring back the death that the Order had replaced with them.

3.6

THOSE WHO LIVE IN DEATH: ABJECTION, ABISHAG, AND THE ARS MORIENDI

THOSE WHO LIVE in Death occupy, within the imaginary of the Golden Order, the position Julia Kristeva assigned to the corpse. In *Powers of Horror* (1980), Kristeva defined the abject as that which disturbs identity, system, and order, which respects no border, position, or rule; and she identified the corpse, seen without God and outside of science, as the utmost of abjection, death infecting life. The abject is not simply other. It is what the subject has expelled in order to constitute itself, and it horrifies because it was once of the self and threatens to return. The Golden Order constituted itself by expelling death, and Those Who Live in Death are death's return, not as an ending but as a contaminant, life and death mingled in a single body. Hence the peculiar violence of the Order's response. The undead are hunted by D, Hunter of the Dead, and his twin, inquisitors of an order that cannot tolerate the evidence of its own repression, and the Order's clergy treat them as an abomination to be purged. The literary ancestor of this horror is the vampire, whose modern form Bram Stoker fixed in *Dracula* (1897), a novel he long worked on under the title *The Un-Dead*: an aristocratic sovereign who cannot die, who sustains himself on the blood of the living, and whose hunters wield the sacred instruments of the order he threatens. Mohg, Lord of Blood, examined in Chapter 5, inherits the vampire's sovereignty; Those Who Live in Death inherit its abjection.

Against this horror stands Fia, the Deathbed Companion, whose very title names a role of great antiquity. When King David was old and could not get warm, his servants sought throughout Israel a young woman to lie in his bosom, and they found Abishag the Shunammite, who cherished the king and ministered to him, though the king knew her not (1 Kings 1:1–4). The deathbed companion is the one who warms the dying sovereign. The biblical narrative then does something the game reproduces with uncanny exactness: it entangles the deathbed companion in the succession. After David's death his son Adonijah asks for Abishag as his wife, and Solomon, recognizing in the request a claim upon the throne, has him executed (1 Kings 2:13–25). The woman who warmed the dying king becomes the token of the kingdom's inheritance. Fia warms the Tarnished in her embrace, as she has warmed the champions whose spirits will later rise to defend her; then she descends to the corpse of the Prince of Death and, lying with him, brings forth the Mending Rune that would determine the succession of the Lands Between. She is Abishag and Isis at once: the companion of the dying king and the bride of the dead god, the warmth at the deathbed and the womb of a new law.

The late medieval *ars moriendi*, the art of dying well, offers the most illuminating contrast. The *Tractatus artis bene moriendi* (c. 1415) and the block-book editions that illustrated it (c. 1450) staged the deathbed as a battlefield, on which demons tempted the dying to unbelief, despair, impatience, pride, and avarice, while angels and saints offered the corresponding inspirations; the woodcuts crowd the bed with figures contending for a soul at the moment of its passage. The art presupposed that death is an end and a judgment, and that its moment must be prepared for and accompanied. Fia's companionship inverts every term. She does not prepare the living for a good death; she embraces the living in order to gather strength for a death that will not end, and she seeks not the passage of souls across a threshold but the abolition of the threshold itself, in an age in which life and death would no longer be held apart. Her project is therefore not the opposite of the Golden Order's but its mirror. Where the Order abolished death in order to secure life, Fia would abolish the separation of life and death in order to secure the dead; both refuse the threshold. Mikhail Bakhtin's reading of the "pregnant death" of grotesque realism (1965), exemplified by the terracotta figurines from Kerch of senile, pregnant hags who laugh, in which death and birth coincide in a single ambivalent body, discloses the positive potential of Fia's vision: a life that carries death within it need not be abjection; it may be fecundity. Whether the Age of the Duskborn realizes that potential or merely enthrones the abject is a question for Chapter 9.

3.7

THE RETURN OF DEATH: MALIKETH, EARTHSEA, AND THE GIFT OF MEN

The keeper of Destined Death has spent the age of the Shattering in disguise. In the Bestial Sanctum, a remote temple in the Dragonbarrow of Caelid, the Tarnished meets Gurranq, Beast Clergyman, a hulking, half-feral figure who begs for Deathroot, devours it, and rewards each offering with a gift. Only later, at Crumbling Farum Azula, is he revealed as Maliketh, the Black Blade, Marika's shadow, who has been eating the death that leaked from Godwyn's corpse in order to contain it, and who has been driven half mad by the meal. The guardian of death has become its scavenger. The figure condenses two ancient types: the psychopomp who keeps the boundary between the living and the dead, and the devourer who consumes what must not pass, like Ammit, the composite beast of the Egyptian judgment hall who eats the hearts of the unjustified dead. The combat with Maliketh is the hinge of the narrative, and its procedural rhetoric is exact. The Black Blade's strikes inflict Destined Death, which reduces the player's maximum health for a time: the first death the game returns to the world is a shortening of the player's own life. When Maliketh falls, the seal is broken, the Rune of Death is released, and the way lies open, through the Ashen Capital, to the Elden Throne. Every ending passes through this

moment. Whatever the Tarnished will choose, the choosing takes place in a world to which death has returned.

Black Isle Studios' *Planescape: Torment* (1999) imagined the externalization of mortality with a precision that anticipates Maliketh. Its protagonist, the Nameless One, wakes on a mortuary slab unable to remember his past and unable to die; each death returns him to life with fragments of his memory erased. He learns that a night hag named Ravel once severed his mortality from him at his own request, and that the mortality so severed did not vanish but took on a separate existence as the Transcendent One, who awaits him at the game's end in the Fortress of Regrets; every one of his resurrections, meanwhile, has cost the life of someone else, whose death was taken in place of his. The game's climax is the Nameless One's reunion with his own death, the reabsorption of a mortality that had become a separate power, and the acceptance of an end. Its refrain asks what can change the nature of a man, and its answer is close to the one the Lands Between give: not deathlessness, but the reclaiming of death. Maliketh, Marika's shadow, is the Transcendent One of the Golden Order, mortality externalized as a guardian, and the Tarnished's victory over him is the Golden Order's reunion with its death.

No modern fantasist understood the logic of re-mortalization more profoundly than Ursula K. Le Guin. In *The Farthest Shore* (1972), the third book of Earthsea, a sorcerer named Cob, terrified of death, opens a door between the land of the living and the dry land of the dead in order to live forever, and through that door the meaning of the world drains away. Wizards forget their spells and craftsmen their crafts, singers lose their songs, the true names of things are forgotten, and joy goes gray. Ged and the young prince Arren follow the breach to its source in the land of the dead and close it, at the cost of all Ged's power. The diagnosis is the one this chapter has reached by another road: the refusal of death does not preserve life but empties it. Le Guin carried the argument further in *The Other Wind* (2001), the late book that revised her own mythology. The dry land of the dead, it emerges, is not the natural destination of souls but an artifact, a realm walled off long ago by the mages of the Archipelago, who took a part of the dragons' domain in order to secure for their own kind a personal immortality; the dead, held there as shadows, could neither return to the earth nor go on. The novel ends with the breaking of the wall, and the dead, released, pass back into the living cycle of the world. The parallel with the Erdtree burial is close enough to startle. In both, a civilization's fear of death produces an artificial afterlife that imprisons the dead, and in both the restoration of the world requires that the enclosure be broken and the dead set free.

J. R. R. Tolkien, reflecting in his letters on what *The Lord of the Rings* was about, answered that it concerned not power and dominion so much as death and the desire for deathlessness. His mythology made the theme cosmological. To the Elves Ilúvatar gave a life bound to the world for as long as the world endures; to Men he gave the Gift of Ilúvatar, death, by which they pass beyond the circles of the world to a destiny unknown even to the Valar. The tragedy of Númenor, told in the *Akallabêth* (in *The Silmarillion*, 1977), is the tragedy of a people who came to regard the Gift as a doom. The fear of death grew dark

upon them; they built great houses for their dead and embalmed them; and at last their king, seduced by Sauron, sailed against the Undying Lands to seize a deathlessness that was not his, and the island was swallowed by the sea. The Golden Order is Númenor before the fall: a civilization of splendid architecture, an elaborate cult of the dead, and a profound refusal of mortality. Tolkien's theology supplies the counter-thesis to chrysopoeia in its purest form. Death is not a defect to be engineered away but a gift, the condition of a freedom that exceeds the world, and its refusal is not the triumph of life but its corruption. *Elden Ring* does not share Tolkien's faith that the Gift leads anywhere beyond the circles of the world; its re-mortalization is resolutely immanent. It shares, however, his conviction that the desire for deathlessness, once satisfied, is a catastrophe.

3.8

CONCLUSION: THE THORN AND THE DROP OF BLOOD

Jorge Luis Borges's "The Immortal" (1947) is the manuscript of a Roman tribune who sets out in search of the river whose waters confer immortality, drinks from it, and finds beyond it the City of the Immortals: a labyrinthine architecture of corridors that lead nowhere, windows that cannot be reached, and stairways that end in the void, built by beings who, having all of time before them, could no longer tell purpose from caprice. The immortals themselves live in a torpor of indifference. In infinite time, the narrator comes to understand, every man does everything and suffers everything, so that no act retains its weight, and among them a ragged troglodyte proves to be Homer, who has all but forgotten the *Odyssey*. The narrator wanders for centuries, until, drinking from a stream on the coast of Eritrea, he scratches the back of his hand on a thorny tree and watches, incredulous and joyful, the slow formation of a drop of blood. He is mortal again. The manuscript is found among the effects of an antiquarian named Joseph Cartaphilus, the name medieval legend gave to the Wandering Jew, condemned to walk the earth until the end of days.

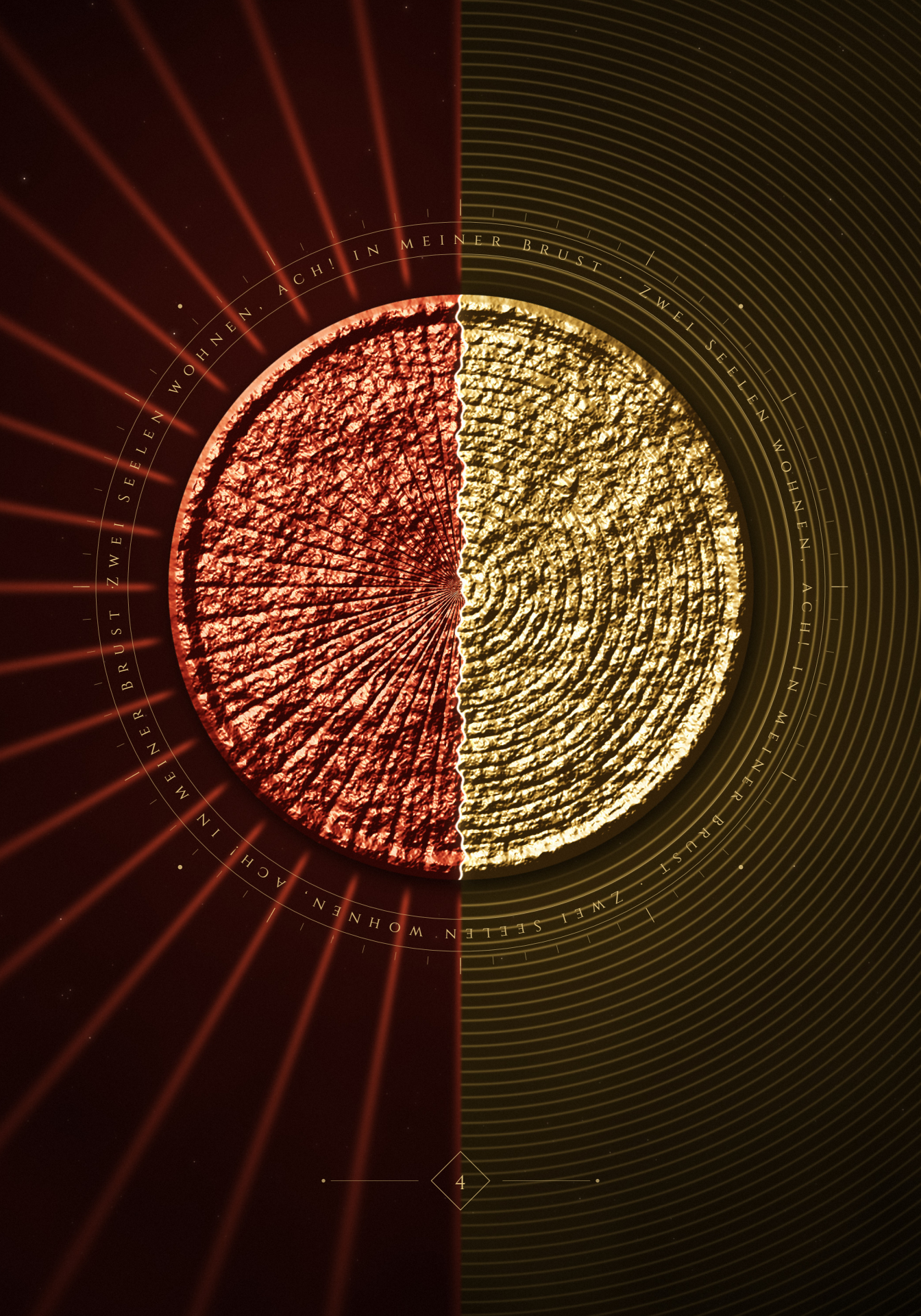
The Lands Between are Borges's City of the Immortals, and the Tarnished, an exile condemned to wander, is its Cartaphilus. The argument of this chapter can be restated in the terms of the parable. The Golden Order drank from the river of deathlessness when it sealed Destined Death away. Its dead were not released but stored in the roots of its tree, until the tree was poisoned by a death it could not digest. Its gods did not live forever; they decayed forever: a Tithonus grafting limbs, a Miss Havisham cradling an egg, einherjar fighting without a feast, an Erysichthon devouring himself. Its sovereignty could not be inherited, because inheritance requires death, and so it invented in place of death the social death of exile, and produced in its exiles the very class of beings who would return to undo it. The death that returned by theft on the Night of the Black Knives returned divided, a corpse without a soul and a soul without a corpse, and gave rise to the living dead, whom the Order hunted as abominations and whom Fia would enthrone. Only when the keeper

of the seal, who had become the eater of leaked death, was struck down at the summit of a crumbling city could death return whole, and only then could the Ring be mended.

The thorns that sealed the Erdtree, examined in Chapter 2, and the thorn that pierces the hand of Borges's immortal belong to a single figure. The one bars the way to a world without death; the other announces, in a drop of blood, the return of mortality and with it the preciousness of everything that ends. The Tarnished passes through the first in order to restore the second. Chapter 4 turns from the sealing of death to the god who sealed it, and to the discovery, inscribed upon her statue, that she was never one.

The one bars the way to a world without death; the other announces, in a drop of blood, the return of mortality and with it the preciousness of everything that ends.

CHAPTER 3 · §3.8


ZWEI SEELEN WOHNEN, ACH! IN MEINER BRUST · ZWEI SEELEN WOHNEN, ACH! IN MEINER BRUST

CHAPTER

4

TWO SOULS IN ONE BREAST

Radagon, Marika, and the Self-Fracture of God

Zwei Seelen wohnen, ach! in meiner Brust
— Goethe, *Faust I* (1808), 1112

Without Contraries is no progression.
— William Blake, *The Marriage of Heaven and Hell* (c. 1790)

4.1

THE INSCRIPTION: GOLDEN ORDER FUNDAMENTALISM AND THE THEOREM OF IDENTITY

The Golden Order had theologians, and the most rigorous of them were its fundamentalists. Golden Order Fundamentalism appears in the game as a scholastic movement within the Order's clergy, represented in the Roundtable Hold by Brother Corhyn, a cleric of gentle piety, and embodied in its purest form by Goldmask, an emaciated ascetic who never speaks, who stands at the edge of a broken bridge on the Altus Plateau absorbed in silent calculation, and whom Corhyn follows as a disciple follows a master. The movement's doctrine is organized around two principles, which the game names in the incantations that bear them: the Law of Causality, which holds that all things are bound together in a single web of causes, and the Law of Regression, which holds that all things tend to return to their origin, toward a primordial unity. Its program is to perfect the Golden Order by grounding it in these laws alone, purged of whatever in the Order derives not from law but from the will, and the passions, of its gods.

The movement's decisive discovery is made in the Erdtree Sanctuary of the royal capital, before a statue of Marika. When the Law of Regression, whose incantation the Tarnished obtains in exchange for the treatise called the Golden Order Principia, is cast before the statue, an illusion is dispelled and a hidden inscription appears: "Radagon is Marika." The formula is the theorem toward which Fundamentalism had been reasoning, and its form is significant. It is not a revelation granted but a truth extracted, the product of applying the Law of Regression to the image of the god: when the two persons of the divine marriage are traced back toward their origin, they converge upon one. Goldmask, informed of the result, completes his reasoning and conceives the Mending Rune of Perfect Order, the design of an order perfected by the excision of the very thing the theorem had disclosed: the fickle, passionate, self-contradicting will of a god who was two.

Three features of the episode organize this chapter. The first is that the Golden Order's own rational theology, pursued to its conclusion, discovers that its god is not one but two-in-one; the Order's highest principle of unity, applied to its own foundation, yields a duality. The second is that the duality takes the form of a marriage and a gender. Marika, the god, and Radagon, her consort and the second Elden Lord, are the feminine and masculine aspects of a single being, which married itself. The third is that the discovery issues not in reverence but in a project of purification: Goldmask's perfect order would remove from the Order its god's capacity for contradiction. The Fundamentalists thus repeat, at the level of theology, the chrysopoeic gesture of the Order itself. Having found mixture at the heart of the gold, they propose to refine it out. The sections that follow read the theorem through the Neoplatonic metaphysics it presupposes (§4.2), the theology of the coincidence of opposites it instantiates (§4.3), the structure of divided sovereignty it reveals (§4.4), the

alchemical marriage it enacts (§4.5), and the self-destruction of the god to which it leads (§§4.6–4.7).

4.2

PROCESSION AND REVERSION: PROCLUS AND THE THEOLOGY OF THE TWO LAWS

THE TWO LAWS OF Golden Order Fundamentalism are the two movements of Neoplatonic metaphysics. For Plotinus, all reality proceeds from the One, the absolutely simple first principle, by an overflowing that diminishes nothing in its source, and all reality longs to return to it; the philosopher's highest act is the ascent by which the soul, stripping away multiplicity, attains union (*henōsis*) with the One, in Plotinus's famous phrase the flight of the alone to the alone (*Enneads* 6.9.11). Proclus, fifth-century scholarch of the Athenian school, systematized the scheme in the *Elements of Theology* into a triadic law that governs every relation of cause and effect. Every effect remains in its cause, proceeds from it, and reverts upon it (prop. 35), and everything that proceeds from a principle reverts in respect of its being upon that from which it proceeds (prop. 31). Remaining (*monē*), procession (*proodos*), and reversion (*epistrophē*) are not three events but three aspects of a single relation: the cause abides in itself while giving rise to its effect, and the effect, by the very fact of its derivation, is turned back toward its source.

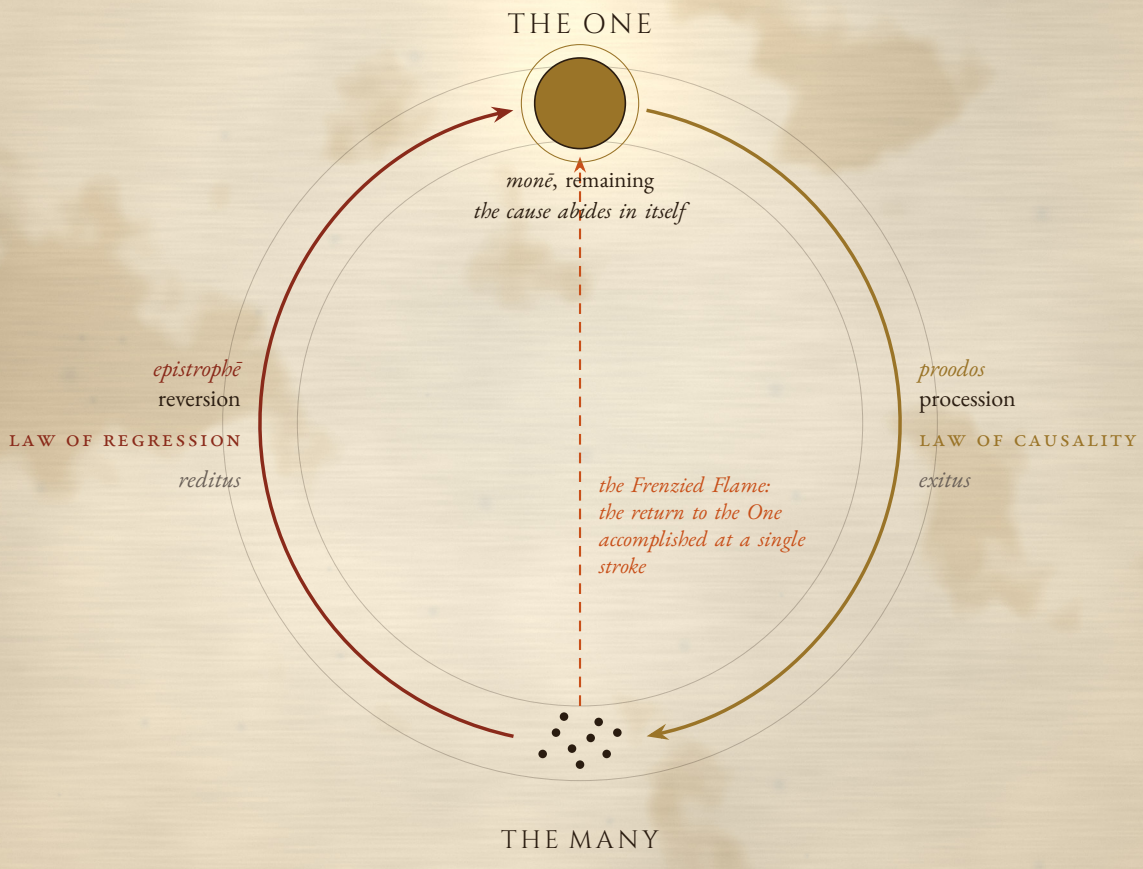
The correspondence with the Fundamentalist laws is close enough to be structural. The Law of Causality is the law of procession: it describes the world as a single web in which every being is derived from and connected to every other through the chain of causes, a world whose unity is that of its common derivation. The Law of Regression is the law of reversion: it describes the tendency of every being to return toward the principle from which it proceeded. Golden Order Fundamentalism is, in this sense, a Neoplatonism of the Elden Ring, a theology in which the Ring's order is the source from which all things proceed and to which all things tend to return. The discovery that Radagon is Marika is what a Proclean theology would predict when applied to a dyad. A pair of principles that appears as two in the order of procession must, in the order of reversion, be traced back to the one from which their duality proceeded. The inscription on the statue is a theorem of reversion. Goldmask, silent, ascetic, absorbed in calculation upon a ruined bridge, is the Proclus of the Lands Between, and the role fits him the better in that Proclus, too, was an ascetic of legendary discipline who composed hymns to the gods while systematizing their metaphysics, and whom his biographer Marinus presented as the embodiment of every philosophical virtue (*Proclus, or On Happiness*).

The Latin Middle Ages inherited the scheme as *exitus* and *reditus*, the going-out of creatures from God and their return to him. John Scottus Eriugena's *Periphyseon* (c. 867) organized the whole of nature into a fourfold division that ends where it began, in a nature

PLATE II

Procession and reversion

AFTER §4.2



They are two velocities of a single desire.

that neither creates nor is created, God as the end into which all things return, and the plan of Aquinas's *Summa theologiae* has long been read as built upon the same circle. The circle is the form of chrysopoeic metaphysics in its theological register: the many come from the One and are destined to return to it, so that multiplicity is a provisional dispersion and unity the final truth. Its danger, which Chapter 7 examines at length, is that reversion pursued without remainder becomes indistinguishable from annihilation. The Frenzied Flame, which would melt all things into one, is the Law of Regression stripped of hierarchy, procession, and patience, the return to the One accomplished at a single stroke. That the Golden Order's most rational theology and its most terrible heresy share a henological logic is not an accident. They are two velocities of a single desire.

The Neoplatonic tradition also knew a check upon its own confidence. Damascius, the last scholarch of the Athenian school before its closure in 529, opened his *Problems and Solutions Concerning First Principles* with the aporia that the first principle cannot properly be called a principle, or even one, since every name draws it into relation with what derives from it; beyond the One lies the ineffable. Fundamentalism lacks this apophatic humility. It believes that the first principle can be inscribed, and it reads its inscription as a warrant for reform. In this, too, it is chrysopoeic: it mistakes the formula of unity for unity itself, and the gold of the statue for the god.

4.3

COINCIDENTIA OPPOSITORUM: CUSANUS, ARDHANĀRĪŚVARA, AND THE ANDROGYNE

If Proclus supplies the logic of the discovery, Nicholas of Cusa supplies its theology. In *De docta ignorantia* (1440) Cusanus argued that God is the absolute maximum, which, being all that can be, coincides with the absolute minimum; in God the opposites that reason keeps apart coincide, and the human mind can approach this coincidence only through a learned ignorance that knows the limits of its own discursive oppositions. In *De visione Dei* (1453) he gave the doctrine its most memorable image. God dwells beyond a wall, the wall of paradise, which is the coincidence of contradictories, and reason, which proceeds by distinguishing contradictories, cannot pass through it. "Radagon is Marika" is a coincidence of opposites in Cusanus's precise sense. The two persons are not merely complementary; they are opposed in nearly every determination the game assigns them. Marika is the god, Radagon the consort; Marika the founder of the Order, Radagon its champion; Marika the breaker of the Ring, Radagon, as he is widely understood, its would-be restorer, who confronts the Tarnished wielding a golden hammer of the kind with which Marika is shown shattering the Ring. The echo of Marika's voice preserved in the capital addresses Radagon as one who has yet to become her, yet to become a god, and calls upon

him: let us shatter together. In a single being, one hand breaks and the other mends. The wall of paradise is the place where breaking and mending are the same act.

Indian iconography had given the coincidence of opposites a body centuries before Cusanus gave it a theology. Ardhanārīśvara, "the Lord who is half woman," is the form of Śiva in which the god's right half is male and his left half is Pārvatī, his consort, fused along a vertical axis into a single figure; the image appears from the Kushan period onward and attains classical expression in the cave temple at Elephanta and the bronzes of the Chola period. Its theology is the inseparability of Śiva and Śakti, consciousness and power, a god inert without the energy that is his own feminine aspect. Radagon and Marika are Ardhanārīśvara unfolded in time rather than in space. Where the Indian icon presents the two halves simultaneously, side by side, the Lands Between present them in alternation, one persona emerging as the other recedes, so that the god's duality takes the form of a history: a goddess who reigned, a consort who served her, and a single being who was both. The final encounter makes the alternation visible. Before the broken body of Marika, Radagon rises to bar the way; when he falls, the Elden Beast emerges, and beyond it lies the shattered Marika. The persons succeed one another in the same place, as aspects of one figure disclosed one at a time.

The Western tradition offers two myths of a primordial double being and its division. In Aristophanes' speech in Plato's *Symposium* (189c–193d), the first human beings were doubled creatures, round, with four arms, four legs, and two faces, some male and male, some female and female, some androgynous; Zeus cut them in two for their presumption, and love is the longing of each half for the other, the desire to restore an original wholeness. The rabbis read the first chapter of Genesis in a similar sense: according to *Genesis Rabbah* (8.1), the first Adam was created androgynous, with two faces, and afterward sawn apart. In both myths, sexual difference is the division of an originally unified being, and love is the memory of that unity. Radagon and Marika invert the myth. They are not two halves seeking reunion but one being that divided itself in order to marry itself, a love in which the beloved is the self in another persona. Ovid's tale of Hermaphroditus and the nymph Salmacis (*Metamorphoses* 4.285–388) supplies the converse image: two bodies fused by a desperate embrace into one, which seems, in Ovid's phrase, neither and both (*neutrumque et utrumque videntur*). Ovid's lovers become one body against the will of one of them; Marika becomes two persons by her own will; and the result in each case is a being that is neither and both.

Jewish mysticism developed the most elaborate theology of a divine duality seeking union. In the Kabbalah of the *Zohar* and its successors, the *sefirot*, the ten emanated aspects of the divine, include a masculine principle, Tiferet, often called the Holy One, blessed be He, and a feminine principle, Malkhut, the Kingdom, identified with the Shekhinah, the indwelling divine presence. Exile, sin, and the disorder of the worlds are understood as their separation, and redemption as their reunion, and the Kabbalists who followed Luria prefaced the performance of the commandments with a declaration of intention, *le-shem yiḥud*, for the sake of the unification of the Holy One, blessed be He, and His Shekhinah,

so that every human act might contribute to the healing of a division within God (Scholem 1941). The resonance noted in Chapter 1, that the name of Marika's shadow, Maliketh, echoes Malkhut, here acquires a further dimension. The Fundamentalists' theorem is a *yiḥud* read in reverse. Where the Kabbalist labors to unite a divine masculine and feminine that have been separated, the Fundamentalist discovers that the masculine and feminine persons of the divine marriage were never two, and draws from the discovery not a liturgy of union but a program of purification.

Modern fiction has twice imagined sovereigns whose sex is not fixed, and both are instructive. Virginia Woolf's *Orlando* (1928) follows an Elizabethan nobleman who lives for more than three centuries and, during an embassy at Constantinople, wakes as a woman, unchanged in every respect but this; the narrator insists that the person is the same. Orlando is the comic counterpart of the Lands Between's tragedy, an undying being whose sex changes while the self persists. Ursula K. Le Guin's *The Left Hand of Darkness* (1969) imagines the planet Gethen, whose people are ambisexual, sexed only in the recurrent phase of kemmer, in which they may become either male or female; its envoy reports with bemusement that the king is pregnant. A world in which any sovereign might be mother or father is a world in which the distribution of gender across the offices of power cannot be naturalized. FromSoftware's own corpus offers a closer precedent still. In *Dark Souls*, Dark Sun Gwyndolin, youngest son of the sun-lord Gwyn, is raised as a daughter because of his affinity with the moon, and sustains in the deserted city of the gods an illusion of his departed sister, the Princess of Sunlight; when the illusion is dispelled, the radiant city is revealed in its true, desolate state. A divine person who maintains through illusion the appearance of another divine person, and an act of dispelling that reveals the truth behind the gold: this is the structure the Law of Regression performs upon the statue of Marika.

4.4

DIVIDED SOVEREIGNTY: MITRA-VARUNA, THE DOUBLE, AND THE SHADOW

THE IDENTITY OF Radagon and Marika is not only a theological paradox; it is a structure of sovereignty. Georges Dumézil argued in *Mitra-Varuna* (1940) that Indo-European ideology conceived the sovereign function as double. Varuṇa is the terrible, magical, remote sovereign, master of binding and of the cosmic order, whose power is violent, sudden, and inscrutable; Mitra is the near, juridical, contractual sovereign, guarantor of oaths and of the peace of agreements. The pairing recurs, Dumézil argued, in Rome as the opposition between Romulus, the violent founder, and Numa, the priestly lawgiver, and in Scandinavia as the complementarity of Odin and Týr. Sovereignty is not one but two: the creative violence that founds and the regulated order that sustains. Marika and Radagon distribute the two aspects with remarkable fidelity. Marika is the Varuṇic sovereign: the god of the founding,

who arrived from the Land of Shadow, conquered with Godfrey, removed Destined Death from the Ring, at the least permitted the Night of the Black Knives, and shattered her own Order in a single act of inscrutable violence. Radagon is the Mitraic sovereign: the loyal champion of the Order who keeps its law, who strives to mend what Marika breaks, and whose very title in the final encounter, Radagon of the Golden Order, binds him to the regime rather than to its founder. The Golden Order Fundamentalists, who would purge the Order of its god's passions, are Mitraic partisans in a theological civil war. They would keep Radagon and dissolve Marika.

Goethe gave modern literature its canonical formula for the divided self. Two souls, alas, dwell in my breast, Faust laments, and each would part from the other, the one clinging to the world with sensual desire, the other rising toward the fields of high ancestors (*Faust I*, 1112–1117). The nineteenth century multiplied the figure into a genre, the literature of the double: E. T. A. Hoffmann's *The Devil's Elixirs* (1815–16), Edgar Allan Poe's "William Wilson" (1839), Dostoevsky's *The Double* (1846), and its most famous instance, Robert Louis Stevenson's *Strange Case of Dr Jekyll and Mr Hyde* (1886), in which a respectable physician separates his darker self into a second person who gradually usurps the first. In the classic narrative of the double, the second self embodies what the first represses, and the drama is one of usurpation: Hyde grows stronger as Jekyll weakens. Radagon and Marika reverse the polarity the genre usually assigns. The public, lawful, orderly persona is the masculine double, Radagon; the hidden persona, revealed only when an illusion is dispelled, is the god herself, whose will is the source of the Order's founding violence and of its destruction. In the Lands Between the double is not the repressed. It is the institution.

The divided sovereign has a third part, which the game calls her shadow. Each Empyrean, each candidate for godhood chosen by the Two Fingers, is assigned a Shadowbound Beast: Maliketh to Marika, Blaidd to Ranni. Marika's shadow is the keeper of her Destined Death. The god who removed death from the law of the world did not destroy it; she gave it to her shadow to hold. The European imagination knows two shadowless figures whose fates illuminate hers. Adelbert von Chamisso's Peter Schlemihl (1814) sells his shadow to a mysterious man in gray in exchange for an inexhaustible purse of gold, and discovers that a man without a shadow is shunned by all; he spends the rest of his life crossing the world in seven-league boots as a solitary naturalist, an outcast from human society. Gold is purchased at the price of the shadow, and the shadowless man is no longer wholly human. Hugo von Hofmannsthal and Richard Strauss's *Die Frau ohne Schatten* (1919) imagines an Empress, daughter of a spirit-king, who casts no shadow and therefore cannot bear children; unless she acquires one, her husband will be turned to stone. She could take the shadow of a mortal woman, but at the climax she refuses to purchase her own humanity with another's loss, and the shadow is granted her. In both works the shadow is what binds a being to the human condition, to finitude, fertility, and belonging. Marika, who gave her death to her shadow and bound it in a beast, is a woman without a shadow in Hofmannsthal's sense, and the chrysopoeic bargain she struck is Schlemihl's: gold in exchange for the shadow.

The expansion's title, *Shadow of the Erdtree*, can be read as a promise that the shadow will be found.

Two further frames complete the picture. Jung's syzygy, the paired archetypes of anima and animus, the contrasexual image in each psyche, describes an economy in which the integration of the opposite is the condition of wholeness and the failure of integration produces possession by the unintegrated image (Jung 1959 [1951]). Shinto theology knows a doubling of the divine closer still to the Lands Between. A kami may manifest as *aramitama*, its rough, violent, active spirit, and as *nigimitama*, its gentle, harmonizing spirit, and the two may be enshrined apart, as the *Nihon Shoki* records of the deity whose gentle spirit was to attend the Empress Jingū's person while its rough spirit led her fleet (Aston 1896). Marika is the *aramitama* of the Golden Order and Radagon its *nigimitama*. The Fundamentalists would enshrine the gentle spirit alone, and forget that the rough one founded the shrine.

4.5

THE ALCHEMICAL MARRIAGE: SOL, LUNA, AND THE ARRESTED OPUS OF THE EMPYREANS

The alchemical tradition, introduced in Chapter 1 as the key to the Golden Order's chromatic theology, also supplies the key to its marriages. The culminating operation of the opus was the *coniunctio*, the sacred marriage of opposites: Sol and Luna, the red king and the white queen, sulphur and mercury, gold and silver. The *Rosarium philosophorum* (1550) illustrated the operation in a celebrated sequence of woodcuts. King and queen meet, unclothe, and descend into a bath, where they embrace; their conjoined body lies dead in a sarcophagus, in the stage the text calls putrefaction; a soul ascends from it and descends again as dew; and the dead body rises as a single crowned figure with two heads, the hermaphroditic *rebis*, the "double thing," the philosophers' stone in human form. Jung devoted "The Psychology of the Transference" to these woodcuts, reading them as an image of the union of opposites in the psyche (Jung 1954 [1946]).

Read against this sequence, the marriages of Radagon compose an alchemical narrative. Radagon, red-haired, came to Liurnia as a champion of the Golden Order to war upon Caria, and married instead its queen, Rennala of the Full Moon, presiding figure of a sorcerous realm whose theology is lunar. The red king wed the white queen: the first *coniunctio* of the opus, the sulphur of Sol with the mercury of Luna. From this marriage came three children: Ranni, the witch of the moon; Radahn, whose red mane gave his knights their name; and Rykard. Then Radagon left Rennala to become the consort of Marika and the second Elden Lord, and the second *coniunctio* was celebrated. The red king wed the gold. But the gold was himself. The second marriage is a *coniunctio* in which the opposites are not two substances but two aspects of one, a self-union that the alchemists would have recognized as the final mystery of the work and that the Lands Between present

as a catastrophe. Its children were twins, Malenia and Miquella, the Empyreans, and in them the alchemical narrative reaches its most striking form.

Malenia, with hair as red as her father's, bore from birth the Scarlet Rot, the bloom of an Outer God within her body, held at bay only by the Unalloyed Gold Needle her brother forged; when she unleashed it at Aeonia, she blossomed into a goddess of rot. Miquella, golden-haired, bore the affliction of eternal childhood. In the alchemical sequence, the death of the conjoined body must precede the resurrection of the *rebis*, and the product of the completed work is often figured as a child, the *filius philosophorum*, the philosophers' son, who must grow to become the stone. The Empyrean twins are the two moments of the opus arrested and separated. Malenia is a putrefaction that never completes, a rot that blooms without end, decay without the resurrection that should follow it. Miquella is the philosophers' child who never matures, the *filius* who remains a child forever, the stone that never sets. Jungian psychology later named the eternal child the *puer aeternus*, a figure, as Marie-Louise von Franz described it, of a provisional life that refuses the limitations of time and commitment (von Franz 1970). The red twin and the golden twin, rot and childhood, are the opus of the Golden Order divided against itself. The *coniunctio* of a god with herself, instead of producing the stone, produced its two stalled phases in two afflicted bodies.

The Empyreans, the Two Fingers' candidates for godhood, numbered three in the present age: Malenia, Miquella, and Ranni, the daughter of the first, lunar marriage. Each was destined, it seems, to become a god in succession to Marika, and each failed or refused the destiny in a distinct way. Malenia's destiny was rot. Miquella's was an eternal childhood he sought to transcend by growing a new tree and, as the expansion reveals, by shedding his flesh, his lineage, and his love in order to ascend in the Land of Shadow. Ranni's was a godhood under the Fingers that she escaped by killing her own body. In each case the Empyrean's affliction or rebellion marks the Golden Order's failure to reproduce its god. Deathless gods need no successors, and a deathless order that nonetheless prepares successors, as the Fingers prepared the Empyreans, produces candidates for an office that cannot fall vacant. The Empyreans are at once the offspring of the *coniunctio* and the symptoms of the succession crisis examined in Chapter 3.

4.6

MYSELF TO MYSELF: THE SELF-FRACTURE OF GOD

At the center of the Lands Between's history stands an act whose motive the game refuses to disclose. Marika shattered the Elden Ring. The opening cinematic shows a hammer raised against the Ring; the echo of her voice preserved in the capital summons Radagon, who is herself, to shatter together; and the Greater Will, in answer, imprisons the god within the Erdtree. The interpretive tradition has proposed many motives: grief and

rage at the death of Godwyn, perhaps compounded by her own complicity in it; rebellion against the Greater Will, whose order she had come to experience as a cage; despair at the stagnation of a deathless world; a calculated destruction meant to free the world from the Fingers' design. The texts support each reading without confirming any. What they confirm is the form of the act: a god destroying the order that is her own law, and in so doing destroying herself. The Ring's shards became the Great Runes of her children, and the god's body was broken and bound. The Shattering is the self-fracture of God.

Two traditions of thought allow the act to be read. The first is the theology of divine self-sacrifice, whose Northern form Chapter 2 encountered in the *Hávamál*: Odin hanging on the tree, given to Odin, himself to himself, the god as both sacrificer and victim. Christian theology developed the same structure into the doctrine of a God who gives himself in the Son, and Hegel made of it the center of a philosophy. In *Faith and Knowledge* (1802) he spoke of the infinite grief, the feeling that God himself is dead, citing a Lutheran hymn, and of a speculative Good Friday in which that death must be thought through to its end; in the *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807) and the lectures on the philosophy of religion, the death of God becomes the moment of the divine life in which the infinite empties itself into the finite and returns as Spirit. In this tradition the self-sacrifice of God is the condition of the world's reconciliation. Marika's self-fracture belongs to this family, but it lacks the third moment. There is no resurrection and no return as Spirit; there is only the god's broken body in the tree, and the shards in the hands of her children.

The second tradition is darker and more exact. Philipp Mainländer's *Die Philosophie der Erlösung* (1876), published in the year its author took his own life at the age of thirty-four, proposed a metaphysics of divine self-annihilation. Before the world, Mainländer argued, there existed a simple unity, God, which willed its own non-being; but a being that is simply one cannot simply cease, and so God could attain non-being only by shattering itself into the multiplicity of the world, whose entire history is the progressive dissolution of that multiplicity toward nothing. God has died, Mainländer wrote, and his death was the life of the world. The world is the decomposing body of a god. No philosophy describes the Lands Between more literally. Their present is the debris of a god's self-destruction; their demigods are the shards into which the divine unity broke; and their history since the Shattering is a slow decomposition, in rot, in war, in the drift of the Outer Gods into a world without a center. Mainländer's God sought non-being, and whether Marika did is uncertain. What is certain is that the god of the Lands Between, like Mainländer's, could end her order only by breaking herself, and that the world after her is the life of her death.

The Vedic tradition knew both the dismemberment and its remedy. In the *Puruṣasūkta* (*Ṛgveda* 10.90), the gods sacrifice the cosmic Person, Puruṣa, and from his divided body come the moon from his mind and the sun from his eye, the sky from his head and the earth from his feet, and the four estates of society from his mouth, arms, thighs, and feet; the world is the sacrificed body of a god. The Brāhmaṇas add the sequel. Having emitted the creatures, Prajāpati, Lord of Creatures, fell apart, his joints loosened and his breath gone out of him, and the gods restored him by building the fire altar, whose bricks reassemble

his body (*Śatapatha Brāhmaṇa* 6.1.2; Eggeling 1882–1900). The great fire ritual of the Agnicayana is the periodic reassembly of a dismembered creator. Here is the precise mythic form of what the Tarnished does. The Great Runes are the shards of a broken god; the Tarnished gathers them as the priests gather the bricks; and the mending of the Ring is a reassembly of the god's scattered body by human hands. Chapter 10 returns to this structure, with its Lurianic counterpart, as a foundation of fracture-faithful repair.

4.7

THE PERSECUTED BECOME PERSECUTORS: MARIKA'S ORIGINS AND MESSMER'S CRUSADE

THE EXPANSION of 2024 added to Marika a dimension the base game had only intimated: an origin. The Land of Shadow, veiled by the Erdtree, is where she first set foot, and its ruins suggest the shape of her beginning. Through a ravaged village of shamans, the testimony of surviving Hornsent, and the iconography of the Hornsent's towers and ritual vessels, the expansion intimates, on the reading most interpreters have adopted, that Marika arose from a people the Hornsent had subjugated and used in their rites, and that her order later turned that violence back upon the Hornsent through the crusade of fire waged by her son Messmer, whose fortresses, burned settlements, and impaled dead the player traverses. The god of the Golden Order was, on this reading, once a victim. Her order was founded upon the memory of persecution, and its first act in the land of her origin was to persecute the persecutors. A Hornsent warrior who travels the Land of Shadow in Miquella's company seeks in his turn to avenge his people upon Marika. The cycle has no exit.

René Girard's theory of mimetic violence provides the most penetrating frame for this cycle. In *Violence and the Sacred* (1972), Girard argued that human desire is mimetic, that it imitates the desire of the other and so converges upon the same objects, generating rivalries that tend to escalate into a sacrificial crisis, a reciprocal violence in which distinctions collapse and every party becomes the double of every other. Communities escape the crisis by uniting against a single victim, the scapegoat, whose expulsion or death restores peace and is afterward sacralized, and the founding murder is concealed by the myths that commemorate it, which tell the story from the persecutors' point of view. Girard's later *Things Hidden Since the Foundation of the World* (1978) argued that the biblical tradition progressively revealed the mechanism by taking the side of the victim. The structure of the Golden Order is Girardian in every respect. Its golden myth conceals its founding violence: the war upon the giants, the subjugation of Caria, the purge of the Hornsent, the imprisonment of the Omens. Its founder emerged from a cycle of reciprocal violence in which persecuted and persecutor exchanged places, each becoming the other's double. And the expansion performs the Girardian revelation, opening the hidden land in which

the founding violence was committed and inviting the player to regard the Golden Order from the side of its victims.

Nietzsche's warning in *Beyond Good and Evil* (§146), *wer mit Ungeheuern kämpft, mag zusehn, dass er nicht dabei zum Ungeheuer wird*, that whoever fights monsters should see to it that he does not become a monster in the process, names the moral of Marika's trajectory with an economy no commentary can improve. The game's insight, however, exceeds the aphorism. It is not simply that a persecuted god became a persecutor. It is that her chrysopoeic project, the purification of the world, was itself the form her memory of persecution took. An order founded by a people once used as material in another's rites became an order that treats its own impure as material to be expelled. The Golden Order's horror of mixture, the subject of the next chapter, has its root in the Land of Shadow. Its gold is the armor of a wound.

4.8

CONCLUSION: THE GOD WHO WAS NEVER ONE

The Golden Order proclaimed a theology of the One. Its Fundamentalists reasoned from the Law of Causality to the Law of Regression, from the web of causes to the return of all things to their source, and when they applied that reasoning to their god, they found that she was two. The discovery was not a failure of their method but its triumph: a rigorous henology, applied to the foundation of a chrysopoeic order, disclosed that the foundation was a *coniunctio* of contraries passing itself off as gold. Marika was Radagon: the terrible sovereign and the lawful one, the breaker and the mender, the god and the consort, the Varuṇa and the Mitra of a single throne. Her marriages were an alchemical work that produced not the stone but its two stalled phases, rot and the eternal child. Her shadow held her death. Her origin was a persecution she repaid. And her decisive act was the self-fracture of a god who could end her order only by breaking herself, so that the world that followed was, in Mainländer's phrase, the life of her death.

The chrysopoeic dream of unity rested, then, upon a duality it could not acknowledge, and the Fundamentalists' proposal to perfect the Order by purging its god's contradictions would have repeated the original error at a higher level: refining the mixture out of a gold that had never been anything but mixture. Blake, who understood contraries better than any theologian of the Golden Order, wrote that without contraries there is no progression, and that attraction and repulsion, reason and energy, love and hate are necessary to human existence. The god of the Lands Between was a marriage of contraries; the Order made in her image attempted to be one; and the Shattering was the moment at which the contraries reasserted their rights. Chapter 5 turns from the divided god to what the Order excluded in her name: the Omens, the rot, the blood, the mixed, and the impure.

WITHOUT THE CAMP SHALL HIS HABITATION BE · WITHOUT THE CAMP SHALL HIS HABITATION BE · WITHOUT THE CAMP SHALL HIS HABITATION BE · WITHOUT THE CAMP SHALL HIS HABITATION BE ·

CHAPTER

5

MATTER OUT OF PLACE

Omens, Rot, Blood, and the Politics of the Abject

he shall dwell alone; without the camp shall his habitation be.

— Leviticus 13:46

Et le ciel regardait la carcasse superbe
Comme une fleur s'épanouir.

— Charles Baudelaire, "Une Charogne" (1857)

5.1

DIRT AS MATTER OUT OF PLACE: THE PURITY CODES OF THE GOLDEN ORDER

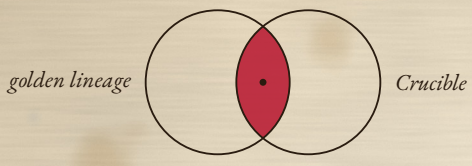
Mary Douglas's *Purity and Danger* (1966) begins from a definition that has become proverbial: dirt is matter out of place. Dirt, Douglas argued, is never an isolated event but the by-product of a system of classification; it is whatever a given order cannot place, and the anxiety it provokes is the anxiety of the order itself, confronted with the limits of its categories. Her most celebrated application concerned the abominations of Leviticus (11). The forbidden animals are neither arbitrarily chosen nor selected for hygiene. They are anomalies of the Israelite taxonomy of creation, creatures that fail to conform to the defining characteristics of their element: the pig, which divides the hoof but does not chew the cud; the creatures of the waters without fins or scales; the swarming things that are neither fish nor fowl nor beast. Holiness, Douglas argued, is wholeness and completeness, each thing conforming to its class, and impurity is the mixing of what should be kept apart.

The Golden Order is a Levitical order in Douglas's sense. Its taxonomy is golden, comprising the lineage of Marika, the grace that shines in the eyes of the favored, and the dead returned to the tree, and its abominations are the beings that confound the categories this taxonomy presupposes. The Omens are born into the golden lineage with the horns of the Crucible, at once of the royal blood and of the primordial mixture the royal order disowned. The albinaurics are living beings that did not issue from the Erdtree's grace, made rather than born. Those Who Live in Death are neither living nor dead. The bearers of the Scarlet Rot are alive and decomposing at once. The cursed dead of the Dung Eater are dead who cannot return to the tree. Each is matter out of place, and the Order's response to each is the response Douglas predicts: separation, confinement, expulsion, or destruction.

The Japanese text sharpens the Levitical reading. The term that designates the Omen, 忌み (*imi*), belongs to the vocabulary of Shinto ritual avoidance: the abstentions and seclusions by which a community protects itself from *kegare*, the pollution that clings above all to death, blood, and disease. *Kegare* is not sin. It is not the result of a transgression but a condition, contracted by contact and transmitted by proximity, to be removed by purification (*harae*, *misogi*) rather than atoned for. The Omen is thus not guilty but taboo, contaminating by existence rather than by act, and the Golden Order, whose Japanese name is a legal statute, administers beneath its law a purity code that operates according to the far older logic of pollution. Robert Parker's account of Greek *miasma*, encountered in Chapter 2, and the Shinto conception of *kegare* converge on the same structure: impurity as a quasi-physical substance, indifferent to intention, contagious by contact. The Golden Order's justice is a hygiene.

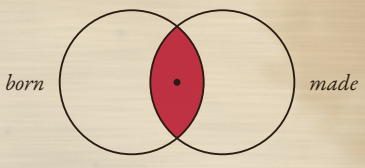
TABLE 5.1

The abjects of the Golden Order.



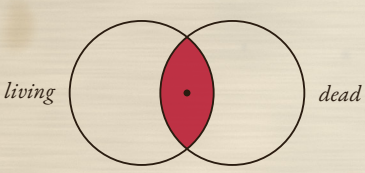
THE OMENS

CATEGORY CONFOUNDED Golden lineage and primordial Crucible; human and beast
THE ORDER'S RESPONSE Confinement beneath the capital; the Omenkillers
COMPARATIVE FIGURE The Levitical anomaly; Agamben's *homo sacer*



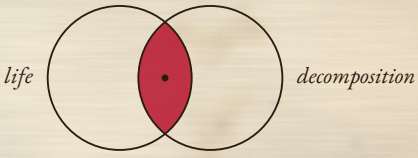
THE ALBINAURICS

CATEGORY CONFOUNDED Born and made; grace and artifice
THE ORDER'S RESPONSE Persecution; refuge sought in the Haligtree
COMPARATIVE FIGURE Frankenstein's creature; the golem



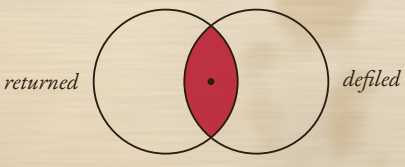
THOSE WHO LIVE IN DEATH

CATEGORY CONFOUNDED Living and dead
THE ORDER'S RESPONSE Hunted by D and his brother
COMPARATIVE FIGURE Kristeva's corpse; Stoker's Un-Dead



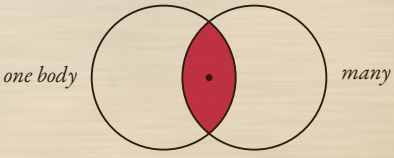
THE ROT-AFFLICTED

CATEGORY CONFOUNDED Life and decomposition
THE ORDER'S RESPONSE Quarantine of whole provinces
COMPARATIVE FIGURE The leper of Leviticus 13; the *kusōzu* corpse



THE DUNG EATER'S CURSED DEAD

CATEGORY CONFOUNDED The returned and the defiled dead
THE ORDER'S RESPONSE The defiler imprisoned beneath the capital
COMPARATIVE FIGURE Bakhtin's material bodily lower stratum



THE GRAFTED

CATEGORY CONFOUNDED One body and many
THE ORDER'S RESPONSE Tolerated within the lineage itself
COMPARATIVE FIGURE Shelley's assembled body

Paul Ricoeur's phenomenology of defilement, invoked in Chapter 1, described exactly this archaic stratum of evil: a stain that infects by contact, a dread that precedes ethics, a purity that is quasi-material. The Tarnished, Chapter 1 argued, bear the oldest symbol of evil in their name. This chapter examines the beings who bear it in their bodies, and argues that the Golden Order's abjects are not its outside but its own repressed substance: the Crucible from which its blood descends, the death it sealed away, the blood and rot its gold denied. Each returns as the vessel of an Outer God or as a counter-sovereignty, and each discloses a form of life that the chrysopoeic order could not accommodate.

5.2

POWERS OF HORROR: KRISTEVA, BAKHTIN, AND THE GROTESQUE BODY

Julia Kristeva's *Powers of Horror* (1980) radicalized Douglas by locating the logic of pollution in the formation of the subject. The abject, for Kristeva, is neither subject nor object but what the subject must expel in order to become a subject at all: the food whose skin makes the gorge rise, the excrement, the corpse, and at the root of them all the maternal body from which the infant must separate in order to exist as a distinct self. Abjection is the violent, never-completed act by which a boundary is drawn between the self and what it came from. Hence the abject's characteristic ambivalence. It repels because it threatens the boundary, and it fascinates because it recalls the undifferentiated state the boundary severed. Religion, in Kristeva's reading, is a technology for managing the abject, purifying it through prohibition and rite, and the Levitical code is its paradigmatic instance. The Golden Order's abjects fit the scheme with unusual precision. The Crucible is a maternal matrix, the primordial body of mixed life from which the golden lineage emerged and which it must disown in order to be golden; its vestiges in the Omens are the mother's mark upon her children, the return of the matrix in the blood of the line. The Formless Mother, to whom Mohg consecrated his dynasty, names the abject maternal outright (§5.4).

Mikhail Bakhtin's *Rabelais and His World* (1965) supplies the positive image of what Kristeva describes as horror. Bakhtin opposed two canons of the body. The classical body is closed, finished, smooth, and self-contained, its orifices sealed and its protuberances concealed: the body of the statue on its pedestal. The grotesque body is open, unfinished, and in perpetual becoming. It bulges, protrudes, swallows, excretes, and gives birth; it mingles with the world and with other bodies; and its essential images are the gaping mouth, the belly, and the protuberant parts, the places where the body exceeds its own limits. The grotesque body is never merely individual. It is the collective, ancestral body of the people, dying and being born at once. The aesthetic of the Golden Order is classical in Bakhtin's sense. Its statues of Marika are sealed and serene, its golden knights encased, its Erdtree the image of an organism that never ages. The aesthetic of its abjects is grotesque.

The incantations of the Crucible make horns, tails, and wings erupt from the caster's body; Godrick's body bristles with the limbs of others; the Scarlet Rot opens the flesh into blossoms; Mohg's rites open the body into wounds.

The tension has a medieval precedent in the art from which much of the game's architecture descends. Bernard of Clairvaux, in his *Apologia* to William of Saint-Thierry (c. 1125), denounced the carved capitals of Cluniac cloisters, crowded with centaurs, half-men, and beasts with one head and many bodies or one body and many heads, a fish's tail on a quadruped and a beast's head on a fish: a marvelous deformed beauty and beautiful deformity (*deformis formositas ac formosa deformitas*) that distracted monks from meditation on the law of God. Bernard's phrase describes the aesthetic of the Lands Between better than any modern term. The Golden Order is Bernard's Cistercian purity, and its world is overrun by the Cluniac capitals he condemned; the game's visual genius lies in refusing to choose between them, rendering the grotesque with the same devotion as the gold. The difference from Bakhtin is nonetheless decisive. Rabelais's grotesque body is festive, comic, and regenerative: its deaths are pregnant with births, and its laughter defeats fear. The grotesque bodies of the Lands Between are, for the most part, tragic. Their openings do not regenerate, because the world they inhabit cannot die. The grotesque body requires mortality in order to be fecund; in a deathless order it becomes merely monstrous. Remortalization, on this reading, is the condition under which the grotesque could recover its Rabelaisian meaning.

5.3

THE OMENS: HOMO SACER, OMELAS, AND THE MELANCHOLY SOVEREIGN

The Omens are the purest case of the Golden Order's abjection, because they are born of the Order itself. Children of the golden lineage born with the horns of the Crucible are, the lore relates, not put to death when they are royal but confined in the depths beneath the capital, in the Subterranean Shunning-Grounds, a labyrinth of sewers and cells beneath the foundations of Leyndell; Omens of humbler birth are hunted by the Omenkillers. Giorgio Agamben's *Homo Sacer* (1995) provides the political theory of this condition. Agamben recovered from archaic Roman law the figure of the *homo sacer*, a man who could be killed with impunity but not sacrificed, excluded from both human and divine law, included in the political order only through his exclusion, his life reduced to "bare life" (*zoē*) stripped of political form (*bios*). Sovereignty, Agamben argued, is constituted precisely by its power over such life, and its paradigmatic space is the camp, the zone in which the exception becomes the rule. The Shunning-Grounds are the camp of the Golden Order. They lie, literally, beneath the capital's foundations: the Order's center rests upon a zone of exception

in which its own children are kept as bare life. Their inclusion is their exclusion. They belong to the golden lineage only as what the lineage cannot acknowledge.

Ursula K. Le Guin gave this structure its most famous parable. In "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973), a city of perfect happiness is sustained by a single condition: in a basement beneath one of its buildings a child is kept in filth and darkness, and every citizen, on coming of age, is taken to see it and told that the city's happiness depends upon its misery. Most return to their lives. A few walk away and do not come back. Le Guin subtitled the story as variations on a theme by William James, who had imagined in "The Moral Philosopher and the Moral Life" (1891) a world of millions kept permanently happy on the one condition that a certain lost soul on the far-off edge of things should lead a life of lonely torture, and who held that our moral sense recoils from the bargain. Leyndell is Omelas. Its golden splendor, its eternal tree, and its deathless lineage rest upon a basement in which its own horned children are kept, and the parable's question, whether one can remain in a city whose happiness is purchased in this way, is posed to the Tarnished as to every inhabitant of the capital. Chapter 6 returns to the question, because one of the endings, Ranni's, takes the form of walking away.

Morgott, the Omen King, is the most poignant figure the Golden Order produced, and its most loyal. An Omen confined at birth beneath the capital with his twin, Mohg, he became the capital's defender during the Shattering, ruling as the Veiled Monarch and haunting the approaches to Stormveil in the guise of Margit, the Fell Omen, to turn back the Tarnished who would claim the throne. He defends the Erdtree that despised him, and he dies presenting himself as the last of the kings. Walter Benjamin's study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928) found in the baroque mourning-play a sovereign of a peculiar kind: not the decisive sovereign of political theory but the melancholy prince, paralyzed before decision, at once tyrant and martyr, a creature among creatures whose fall reveals the transience of all worldly power. In the *Trauerspiel*, Benjamin argued, tyrant and martyr are the two faces of the crowned head. Morgott is both. To the Tarnished he is a tyrant, a guardian who kills claimants to protect an order whose legitimacy has collapsed. To the Order he is a martyr, a despised son who gives his life for the regime that imprisoned him. His literary ancestor is Victor Hugo's Quasimodo (*Notre-Dame de Paris*, 1831), the deformed foundling raised within the cathedral, who guards its towers and serves the archdeacon who took him in with a fidelity the world repays with mockery. Morgott's loyalty is the loyalty of the abject to the institution that constituted it as abject, and it is the deepest form of the Order's power, which reaches its victims not only through their bodies but through their love.

Morgott's twin chose otherwise. Mohg descended deeper into the darkness beneath the capital and there found, the lore relates, a god of his own, the Formless Mother, and with her blood he founded a dynasty that parodies the golden one at every point. Where Morgott internalized the Order's contempt as loyalty, Mohg converted it into a counter-sovereignty. The twins enact the two responses to domination that Frantz Fanon analyzed in *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961): the internalization of the master's order and its values,

5

and the dream of occupying the master's place. Neither escapes the master's terms. Mohg's dynasty is the subject of the next section.

5.4

THE FORMLESS MOTHER: BLOOD, KHŌRA, AND THE SOVEREIGNTY OF THE WOUND

Mohg, Lord of Blood, greets the Tarnished at the heart of his palace with the courtesy of a host, welcoming an honored guest to the birthplace of his dynasty. The palace lies deep beneath the earth under a sky the color of blood, its approaches lined with the bodies of pilgrims and the cocooned faithful, its rites performed in a lake of blood. Mohg's dynasty is a counter-lineage. Where the Golden Order traced its legitimacy through gold, Mohg traces his through blood; where the golden lineage descends from Marika, his descends from a mother without form. His ambition was to found his dynasty upon a marriage of the two. He stole from the Haligtree the cocoon of Miquella, the purest of the golden line, intending to raise him to godhood and to reign as his consort. Mohg's project is a mimetic reproduction of the Golden Order's own founding marriage, a god and a consort, with the substance changed from gold to blood. In Girard's terms, introduced in Chapter 4, the despised double imitates the model he hates, and the counter-sovereignty is the sovereignty's mirror.

The god of this dynasty bears a name the history of philosophy has long been waiting to hear. In the *Timaeus* (48e–52d), Plato introduced, beside the eternal forms and their sensible copies, a "third kind," the receptacle (*hypodochē*) of all becoming, which he called the nurse (*tithēnē*) of generation and, in a celebrated analogy, likened to a mother, the forms being the father and the generated world their offspring. Because it must receive every form, the receptacle must itself be formless (*amorphon*), as the base of a perfume must be odorless. It is apprehended, Plato said, by a kind of bastard reasoning and is scarcely an object of belief, and he called it *khōra*, place or space. The Formless Mother of Mohg is Plato's *khōra* deified. She is the matrix, maternal and without form, from which forms emerge and into which they dissolve, and her medium is blood, the substance that flows when the formed body is opened and its boundaries are breached. Julia Kristeva borrowed the term in *Revolution in Poetic Language* (1974) for the "semiotic chora," the pre-symbolic space of drives and rhythms bound to the maternal body, which precedes the subject's entry into language and law and continues to disturb them from within; Jacques Derrida's essay "Khōra" (1993) dwelt on its resistance to every name, its being neither sensible nor intelligible, neither mother nor nurse except by figure. The Formless Mother belongs to this lineage. She is the matrix that the Golden Order's law of form, its gold, its lineage, and its classifications presuppose and disown, and Mohg, the abjected son, returns to her as the Omen returns to the Crucible.

Georges Bataille supplies the theory of Mohg's rites. In *Erotism* (1957) Bataille argued that human beings are discontinuous, each enclosed in the solitude of an individual existence and haunted by nostalgia for a lost continuity, and that eroticism, death, and sacrifice are the experiences in which the boundaries of discontinuous beings are violated and continuity is glimpsed. In *Theory of Religion*, written in 1948 and published posthumously in 1973, he described sacrifice as the operation that withdraws the victim from the world of things, of utility and order, and returns it to the intimacy of the sacred. Blood is the sign of this passage, the opening of a closed body onto what it is not. Mohg's bloodflame and his cult of wounds are Bataillean sacraments: they open the classical body of the golden order into the continuity of the Formless Mother. Mesoamerican theology furnishes the cosmological scale of such a sacrament. In the Nahua account recorded by Bernardino de Sahagún of the birth of the Fifth Sun at Teotihuacan, the gods give themselves to the fire so that the sun may rise and move, and blood becomes thereafter the substance by which the cosmos is sustained in motion. Blood, in such a theology, is not pollution but the currency of continuance, and Mohg's dynasty is the Lands Between's version of it: a sovereignty whose gold is blood.

Yet Mohg's counter-sovereignty is no more an alternative to chrysopoeia than Morgott's loyalty. It inverts gold into blood without abandoning the structure of the golden order: a lineage, a consort, a god to be made, a dynasty to be founded. The Formless Mother is formlessness enthroned, and enthroned formlessness is a contradiction that resolves itself in the only way available to it, by consuming the bodies it opens. Mohg's palace is lined with the dead. The abject that becomes sovereign does not cease to be abject. It becomes the new law of abjection.

5.5

THE SCARLET ROT: BATAILLE'S FLOWERS, NAUSICAÄ'S SEA, AND THE ETHICS OF DECOMPOSITION

Malenia, Blade of Miquella, is the most formidable warrior of the Lands Between and the most tragic of its vessels. Born with the Scarlet Rot, the influence of an Outer God of decay, coiled within her body, she has lost limbs to it and replaced them with prostheses, and she holds it at bay with the Unalloyed Gold Needle her brother forged: a needle of pure gold set against an Outer God. She introduces herself to those who reach her as one who has never known defeat, and she fought Starscourge Radahn to a standstill at Aeonia; there, to break the deadlock, she released the rot, and bloomed. A vast scarlet flower opened over the swamp of Aeonia, and Caelid, the province around it, became a wasteland of rot under a crimson sky, its dogs and carrion birds swollen with disease. When the Tarnished confronts her at the roots of the Haligtree, she enters her second phase by rising from just such a flower as the Goddess of Rot. Her knights serve her in armor named for the paradox

of a clean rot, and beneath the Lake of Rot a race of insect-like beings, the Kindred of Rot, worship the decay as a god.

Georges Bataille's "The Language of Flowers," published in *Documents* in 1929, anticipated the iconography of the Goddess of Rot with remarkable exactness. Against the idealizing tradition that reads flowers as emblems of purity and love, Bataille insisted that the flower's beauty is inseparable from its sexual organs, displayed with an obscenity idealism ignores, and from its fate: the flower rises from roots that writhe in rot and darkness, and its bloom is brief, its petals withering into a ragged ugliness that betrays the ideal they seemed to promise. The bloom is not the opposite of rot but its moment. Baudelaire had given the insight its most scandalous lyric form in "Une Charogne" (1857), in which a lover recalls the carcass they passed on a summer morning, split open in the sun and swarming with life, which the sky watched blossom like a flower, and reminds his beloved that she too will become such filth. Malenia is Baudelaire's carcass and Bataille's flower made a goddess: the bloom of decay, the beauty of rot, the flowering of a body opened by an Outer God.

Japanese Buddhist art developed a contemplative genre organized around the same figure. The *kusōzu*, "paintings of the nine aspects," depict the corpse of a beautiful woman in nine successive stages of decay, from fresh death through bloating, discoloration, and the attentions of birds and dogs, to scattered bones and dust. They served the meditation on impurity (*fujōkan*; Sanskrit *aśubha*) by which the practitioner dissolved attachment to the body and realized its impermanence, and later tradition attached them to famous beauties, among them the poet Ono no Komachi. Fusae Kanda has shown how these images, sensational to modern eyes, functioned as instruments of religious insight (Kanda 2005). Malenia's rot is a *kusōzu* in motion, a beautiful body undergoing decomposition while still alive. But where the Buddhist contemplation of decay leads to release, an insight into impermanence that frees the mind, the Scarlet Rot in a deathless world leads nowhere. The body decays but does not die, and the stages of the *kusōzu* never reach their last. Decomposition without death is the precise horror of the rot, and it is a horror the Golden Order produced: in a world from which Destined Death has been removed, rot can only be pathology. It cannot be what decomposition is in a mortal world, the return of matter to the cycle of life.

No work of the imagination has pressed this point further than Hayao Miyazaki's manga *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94), the work of an artist unrelated to the director of *Elden Ring*, whose world is being swallowed by the Sea of Corruption, 腐海 (*fukai*), literally the "rotting sea," a vast toxic jungle of fungi and giant insects that its human survivors fear and make war upon. The character for rot, 腐, is the same that names the Scarlet Rot in the Japanese text of *Elden Ring*, 朱い腐敗 (*akai fuhai*). Nausicaä discovers that the Sea of Corruption is not the world's disease but its cure: its plants draw the poisons of an ancient catastrophe out of the soil and crystallize them, leaving pure earth and water beneath the forest floor. The rot is purifying the world. In the manga's conclusion she discovers more. The entire ecology, including the human beings adapted to its poisons, was engineered by the ancients, who planned that once the world had been

cleansed, a purified humanity held in reserve would replace the present one, which could not survive in clean air. Confronting the keeper of this design, Nausicaä refuses it and destroys it, choosing a contaminated, mortal, imperfect life over an engineered purity that would annihilate those who now live. The parallel with the Lands Between is exact at the level of structure. Malenia's rot, like the Sea of Corruption, is feared as contamination by an order of purity, and the deepest choice in both works is a refusal of the purified world, whether engineered by ancient technicians or decreed by a Golden Order, in favor of the impure life that exists.

Contemporary ecological thought has given this refusal a theoretical vocabulary. Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* (2016) urges a turn from fantasies of transcendence to the "compost" of multispecies entanglement, proposing that we are compost rather than posthuman and that the task of the present is to make kin across species in damaged worlds. Anna Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* (2015) follows the matsutake mushroom, which flourishes in forests disturbed by human ruin, as an exemplar of collaborative survival amid what she calls capitalist ruins. The Kindred of Rot, who dwell beneath the Lake of Rot and revere the decay that destroyed so much else, are Haraway's kin made literal: beings who have made of rot a home and a religion. The game does not idealize them, and it would be a misreading to make the Scarlet Rot an ecological good. But it permits the question to be posed: in a world returned to mortality, would rot remain an Outer God's curse, or become compost? The figure who embodies the question is Millicent, a young woman raised by the sage Gowry as a vessel for the Goddess of Rot, who, freed by the Unalloyed Gold Needle from the rot's compulsion, refuses the bloom that her sisters in the rot would impose upon her and insists on choosing her own path. Millicent is neither the gold nor the rot. She is a life that carries the rot within it and declines to let either the rot or the order that fears it decide her form.

5.6

GRAFTS, ALBINAURICS, AND DUNG: THE HYBRID, THE ARTIFICIAL, AND THE ACCURSED

NOT EVERY ABJECT of the Lands Between stands outside the golden lineage. Godrick the Grafted, lord of Stormveil and the first demigod most players meet, is abjection at the heart of the line itself. The least of Marika's descendants, his blood thinned by generations, he has made of his body an assemblage of the limbs of the slain, grafted to his torso and back in a bristling mass, and when he begins to lose his duel with the Tarnished he severs his own arm and grafts in its place the head of a dragon. His castle breeds grafted creatures, the Grafted Scions, spider-like bodies composed of many arms. Godrick is Bakhtin's grotesque body produced not by the festive excess of the people but by the panic of a declining aristocracy, and he is the inverse of Donna Haraway's cyborg. Haraway's "Manifesto for

Cyborgs" (1985) celebrated the hybrid of organism and machine as a figure that confounds the boundaries of purity, nature, and origin on which domination depends. Godrick's hybridity serves purity. He grafts in order to restore the power his golden blood no longer provides, and his mixture is a prosthesis for a lost gold. Mary Shelley's *Frankenstein* (1818) remains the founding text of the assembled body, and the difference is instructive. Victor Frankenstein assembles a creature from the dead and abandons it, and the creature becomes eloquent in its abjection; Godrick assembles himself from the dead and becomes a lord, and his eloquence is a tyrant's bluster. The creature is the abject made subject. Godrick is the abject made sovereign.

The albinaurics are the Lands Between's artificial people. The lore presents them as a race made rather than born, regarded by the Order as lesser, hunted by Omenkillers in their Liurnian village, and drawn to the promise of Miquella's Haligtree as a refuge for those whom the Golden Order had spurned. Latenna, an albinauric archer whom the Tarnished carries in spirit toward the Haligtree, gathers the longing of her people into a single figure. Their condition recalls two traditions of artificial life. The golem of Jewish legend, a figure of clay animated by a divine name, was in its best-known modern form, the legend of Rabbi Judah Loew of Prague, the protector of a persecuted community; Frankenstein's creature, assembled by science, became the figure of the artificial being's exclusion from the human community that made it. The albinaurics stand nearer the creature than the golem. They are not the protectors but those who would be protected, if the Haligtree's promise held; and it did not, for the Haligtree, when the Tarnished reaches it, is rotting.

The Dung Eater is the abject made agent. A murderer known by that name, imprisoned in a gaol beneath the capital, he defiles the bodies of the dead with the Seedbed Curse so that they cannot return to the Erdtree, condemning them to the condition the Order reserved for its outcasts, and he speaks of the curse as a blessing. His practice belongs to Bakhtin's material bodily lower stratum, the realm of excrement and decay to which the grotesque degrades whatever is high, and to Kristeva's abject, of which excrement is a primary form; but his defilement is not festive. It is revenge. His ultimate design, the Mending Rune of the Fell Curse, would extend to all who are born the curse that the Omens bear, so that none could ever again be despised for bearing it. The theology of that design, a salvation through universal defilement, belongs to the apocalyptic imagination examined in Chapter 7. Here it suffices to observe that the Dung Eater completes the circuit of the Golden Order's abjection. The Order made pollution the condition of exclusion; the Dung Eater would make it the condition of all.

5.7

THE HALIGTREE AND THE TYRANNY OF COMPASSION: MIQUELLA

Against the abjections of the Golden Order, one figure seemed in the base game to offer a remedy. Miquella the Kind, Empyrean, twin of Malenia, afflicted with eternal childhood, forged the Unalloyed Gold Needle to resist the Outer Gods and grew in the frozen north a second tree, the Haligtree, which the lore presents as a sanctuary promised to those the Golden Order had spurned: albinaurics, the misbegotten, the accursed. Miquella's gold was unalloyed, pure, yet his purity seemed to be placed in the service of the impure, a gold that would shelter the tarnished rather than expel them. For many players he was the game's figure of hope, and his absence its wound: Mohg had stolen his cocoon from the Haligtree, and the tree, untended, was rotting.

The expansion of 2024 revised this image. Following Miquella into the Land of Shadow, the Tarnished finds the stations of an ascent marked by crosses at which, their inscriptions relate, he discarded in turn his flesh, his golden lineage, and his love, in order to become a god. Miquella's kindness, it emerges, had always operated through a power the expansion calls his charm: those who looked upon him came to love him, and his followers, the knights and pilgrims who cross the Land of Shadow in his name, learn in the course of the expansion that their devotion was not wholly their own; some of them, as the charm weakens, turn against one another. At the end of the ascent, Miquella has resurrected his half-brother Radahn as his promised consort and prepares to inaugurate an age bound together by love, a love from which, in the logic of the charm, no one could abstain. The champion of the outcast proves to embody the most refined chrysopoeia of all: a purification of the world not of its impurity but of its capacity to refuse.

Dostoevsky foresaw the structure in the most famous chapter of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1880). Ivan Karamazov's poem of the Grand Inquisitor imagines Christ returning to Seville in the sixteenth century and arrested by the aged Inquisitor, who explains why the Church has corrected his work. Christ, the Inquisitor charges, burdened humanity with a freedom it cannot bear, the freedom to choose good and evil without compulsion; the Church, out of love for weak humanity, has relieved it of that burden, ruling through miracle, mystery, and authority and giving people the bread and the happiness for which they will gladly surrender their freedom. The Inquisitor loves humanity, and his love takes the form of its domination. Miquella's age of compassion is the Grand Inquisitor's kingdom realized by a god: a world in which all are bound in love, and in which the freedom to withhold love, without which love is not love, has been abolished by a charm. Christ's answer to the Inquisitor in Ivan's poem is a silent kiss. The Tarnished's answer to Miquella is a sword.

Nietzsche's critique of pity, developed across *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) and *The Antichrist* (1895), anticipated the second half of the diagnosis. Pity, Nietzsche argued, is

not innocent: it multiplies suffering, preserves what life would let perish, and conceals a will to power over the pitied, who become the occasion of the pitier's superiority. A compassion that would bind all things to itself is, in Nietzsche's terms, the will to power in its most ingratiating form. Frank Herbert, who spent the *Dune* novels anatomizing the charismatic messiah, warned in a late essay that superheroes are disastrous for humanity, because their followers surrender to them a responsibility that ought to remain their own; Paul Atreides foresees the holy war that will be waged in his name and cannot prevent it, because his followers' love has become a force he no longer controls. And J. M. Barrie, whose eternal child Chapter 3 placed beside Miquella, ended *Peter and Wendy* with the cycle of children who are gay and innocent and heartless; the boy who would not grow up enchants children into a land without time and forgets them when they are gone. The expansion's revelation that Miquella discarded his love gives Barrie's adjective its theological weight. A god of compassion who has renounced love is a heartless child with the power to compel devotion.

The documented influence of Kentaro Miura's *Berserk* makes a final comparison unavoidable. Griffith, the beautiful, androgynous, universally beloved leader of the Band of the Hawk, pursues the dream of a kingdom of his own; at the Eclipse he sacrifices every comrade who loved him in order to be reborn as Femto of the God Hand; and in the later arcs he returns as a messianic savior adored by all, the builder of a utopian city whose people worship him. Miquella is Griffith's double in the Lands Between: the charming, androgynous child-lord whose apotheosis requires the renunciation of love and the use of the love of others, and whose kingdom of compassion would have been the Falconia of a god. Miura died in 2021 and did not live to see *Elden Ring* released, but the expansion's portrait of Miquella may be the most searching homage FromSoftware has paid him.

5.8

CONCLUSION: THE ORDER OF THE CLEAN AND THE ETHICS OF THE UNCLEAN

The abjects of the Golden Order are not its outside. They are its own substance returned. The Omens are the Crucible in the blood of the golden line; the albinaurics, the life the Erdtree did not author; Those Who Live in Death, the death the Order sealed; the Scarlet Rot, the decomposition a deathless world can experience only as disease; the Formless Mother, the matrix every form presupposes; the Dung Eater's curse, the pollution the Order used to exclude, turned into a weapon. Each was produced by the purity code that named it impure, and each returns as a counter-sovereignty or as the vessel of an Outer God. Morgott internalized the Order's contempt as loyalty and died for it. Mohg inverted gold into blood and built a dynasty of wounds. Malenia carried an Outer God within her and fought it with gold until she bloomed. Godrick grafted the dead onto his body to restore a lost gold. The Dung Eater would curse all to avenge the cursed. And Miquella,

who seemed to offer the outcast a home, proved to embody the most refined form of the Order's will to purity: a compassion that would cleanse the world of the freedom to refuse it.

The lesson the chapter draws is that every attempt to resolve the problem of the unclean by purification, whether by exclusion, by inversion, or by love, reproduces the chrysopoeic error. The order of the clean cannot be redeemed by a cleaner order. What the Lands Between require, and what the patinal ontology of this thesis names, is an ethics of the unclean: a hospitality to mixture, decay, and the abject that does not compel, an acceptance of tarnish that neither excludes it nor makes it the new law. Millicent, who carries the rot and refuses the bloom, and who chooses her own form, is its nearest figure in the game. Chapter 6 turns to the one claimant to the Ring who seeks to escape both the gold and its abjects, not by purifying the world but by withdrawing the order from it: Ranni the Witch, and the cold, distant age of the stars.

The order of the clean cannot be redeemed by a cleaner order.

CHAPTER 5 · §5.8

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CHAPTER

6

GRAVITY AND GRACE

Ranni, the Stars, and the Ethics of Distance

E quindi uscimmo a riveder le stelle.
— Dante, *Inferno* 34.139

Le silence éternel de ces espaces infinis m'effraie.
— Blaise Pascal, *Pensées*

6.1

The Witch Who Killed Her Body: Ranni's Rebellion

Of all the claimants to the Ring, only one refuses both the gold and its abjects. Ranni the Witch, the Lunar Princess, is the daughter of Rennala, Queen of the Full Moon, and of Radagon before he left Caria to become Marika's consort; she was one of the Empyreans, the candidates the Two Fingers had chosen to become gods in succession to Marika. She refused the destiny. She stole a fragment of Destined Death from Maliketh's seal, and on the Night of the Black Knives she used it twice: through the assassins, to kill Godwyn in soul, and by her own hand, to kill her own body, discarding the flesh through which the Fingers could bind her to their design. She survives as a spirit inhabiting a small, cold, four-armed doll in a tower of the Carian royal family in Liurnia, attended by a giant smith, a half-wolf warrior, and a scheming preceptor, and from there she enlists the Tarnished in a quest that leads beneath the earth to the Eternal Cities, through the Lake of Rot, and at last to a cathedral of the moon, where, receiving from the Tarnished's hand a ring of the dark moon, she becomes the god of a new order. Her ending removes that order from the Lands Between altogether, carrying it into the stars on a voyage reckoned in a thousand years, with the Tarnished at her side as consort.

Ranni's founding act is a theft, and its mythic form is Promethean. Prometheus stole fire from the gods and gave it to mortals, for which Zeus bound him and sent an eagle to devour his liver (Hesiod, *Theogony* 507–616). Ranni stole death from the god who had sealed it and turned it against that god's own order. The Akkadian myth of Anzû, introduced in Chapter 2, supplies a closer template still: the bird-demon seizes the Tablet of Destinies from Enlil while the god bathes, and for a time the order of the world is in the thief's possession. But the substance of Ranni's theft distinguishes her from both. What she stole was not power over fate but the capacity to end, the one law the Golden Order had excised. If Tolkien was right that death is a gift, Ranni is the Prometheus of that gift, the thief who returned to the world, in fragmentary and violent form, what its god had withheld. That the gift's first effects were murder and the Shattering is the measure of how deformed death had become through its sealing.

Albert Camus defined metaphysical rebellion in *The Rebel* (1951) as the movement by which a human being protests against the condition imposed upon it and against the whole of creation; the metaphysical rebel does not simply deny the master but defies him, refusing the order of the world in the name of a value the world does not honor. Camus traced the history of this refusal from the Promethean myth through Sade, Ivan Karamazov, and Nietzsche, and warned that it tends to end in the tyranny it opposed, when the rebel, having dethroned God, takes God's place and rules in his name. Ranni is a metaphysical rebel in Camus's precise sense. She refuses not a particular injustice but the order of fate itself, the design of the Fingers and the will behind them. The question her ending poses is whether

she escapes the trap Camus described. She does become a god. But the use she makes of godhood is singular: she takes the order away. The rebel who seizes the throne abdicates it in the same act, and this paradox is what the rest of the chapter seeks to understand.

The Gnostic tradition knew a heroine of this type. In the *Hypostasis of the Archons*, one of the texts recovered at Nag Hammadi, the spiritual feminine principle enters the serpent of Eden and becomes the instructor who teaches the first humans to eat of the tree of knowledge against the command of the archons, the rulers of fate; the transgression is liberation, and the serpent's counsel is the beginning of gnosis. Ranni, who defies the Fingers, the archons of the Lands Between, and who teaches the Tarnished to seek the knowledge hidden beneath the earth, occupies the instructor's place. The sections that follow examine the physics of the fate she defied (§6.2), the astral theology on which her rebellion draws (§§6.3–6.4), the apparatus of surveillance she escaped (§6.5), the body she discarded and the marriage she made (§6.6), and the age she would inaugurate (§6.7).

6.2

GRAVITY: RADAHN, THE HALTED STARS, AND THE PHYSICS OF FATE

In the Lands Between, fate is written in the stars and held in place by gravity. Ranni's destiny, the lore relates, was bound to the movement of the stars, and in his prime her half-brother Radahn, mightiest of the demigods, halted them. Radahn had studied gravity sorcery at Sellia, the town of sorcery in Caelid, so that, the lore adds with a touch of comedy, his enormous frame could go on riding his beloved and undersized horse; but the art he learned there made him the Starscourge, the warrior who defeated the stars and fixed them in their places. With the stars halted, Ranni's fate could not advance. The Tarnished's part in her design is to end the stasis. At the festival held in Radahn's name at Redmane Castle, warriors are summoned to fight the rot-maddened general, and when he falls a star falls with him, crashing into Limgrave and opening the way to the Eternal Cities beneath the earth. The stars move again.

Ancient astral fatalism gives the image its depth. For the Stoics, fate (*heimarmenē*) was the ordered chain of causes binding all events, and Chrysippus's doctrine, preserved in Cicero's *De fato*, reconciled it with responsibility only through subtle distinctions; for the astrologers, the stars were fate's script. Manilius, the Roman poet of the *Astronomica*, compressed the doctrine into a single line: *fata regunt orbem, certa stant omnia lege* (4.14), the fates rule the world, and all things stand fixed by settled law. The Gnostics turned the same cosmology into a prison. In their systems the planetary spheres are the domains of the archons who govern fate, and the soul's liberation is an ascent through the spheres past the powers that would detain it; the *Poimandres* describes the soul at death surrendering to each sphere the passion it received from it in its descent, until it arrives, stripped, at the eighth (*Corpus Hermeticum* 1.24–26). Radahn's gravity is the archon's power in its purest

form, the force that holds the stars, and with them the fates, in place. To defeat him is to set fate in motion, which is to say, to make the future possible again.

Simone Weil's *Gravity and Grace* (1947) supplies the moral physics that the game's two forces invite. Weil opens her notebooks with the proposition that all the natural movements of the soul are governed by laws analogous to those of physical gravity, and that grace alone is the exception. Gravity, for Weil, is the downward pull of necessity in the soul: the mechanical tendencies of desire, self-preservation, imagination, and force, by which the self fills every void and seeks compensation for every loss. Grace is the supernatural counterforce, which can enter only where a void has been left open, and which descends rather than being seized. *Elden Ring* contains both forces as literal powers. Gravity is a school of sorcery, mastered by Radahn and embodied in the Alabaster and Onyx Lords who wield it; grace is the golden light that guides the Tarnished from site to site. The confrontation between the Tarnished and Radahn is, in Weil's terms, a confrontation between grace and gravity, and the Tarnished's victory unbinds the stars. The irony, which Weil would have appreciated, is that grace in the Lands Between belongs to the Erdtree, the very order Ranni opposes. The Tarnished defeats gravity with the gift of the god whose order that defeat will help to end.

Weil's thought also marks the limit of Ranni's project. For Weil, necessity is not merely an enemy. The obedience of matter to necessity is the beauty of the world, and the soul's task is not to escape necessity but to consent to it, loving the order of the world as the visible face of a divine love that withdrew in order to let the world be. Weil was drawn to the Cathars and to Gnostic currents, but she refused their contempt for creation. Ranni's revolt is Weilian in its refusal of the Fingers' design and in the decreation by which she freed herself from it (§6.6). It is Gnostic in its refusal to consent to the world as it is and in its removal of order from the world to the stars. Whether her Age of Stars is grace, or only a more distant gravity, is the question §6.7 must address.

6.3

GLINTSTONE AND THE PRIMEVAL CURRENT: ASTRAL MAGIC, STAR-SOULS, AND THE ETERNAL CITIES

Ranni's realm draws upon a theology of the stars that the Golden Order never absorbed. The sorcerers of the Academy of Raya Lucaria practice an art derived from glintstone, a blue crystal that the lore describes as amber holding the life of stars, and they hold that life itself came from the stars. Their most extreme adepts, the primeval sorcerers Azur and Lusat, sought the Primeval Current, the cosmic source from which the stars and their sorcery flow, and were encrusted with glintstone by what they found. The Academy's scholars wear crowns of glintstone over their heads, enclosing themselves in starlight, and their academy rises above a lake beneath the moon. Glintstone sorcery is the astral religion

of the Lands Between, and its alliance with Caria makes it the natural rival of the Erdtree's earthbound gold.

Its deepest European analogue is Platonic. In the *Timaeus* (41d–42b), the demiurge fashions the immortal part of souls from the residue of the world-soul and assigns each soul to a star, showing it the nature of the universe as from a chariot; the soul that lives justly will return at death to dwell in its native star. The doctrine that life comes from the stars and returns to them, which the sorcerers of Raya Lucaria profess, is Platonic astral eschatology in the vocabulary of a mineral. The Renaissance revived it as practice. Marsilio Ficino's *De vita coelitus comparanda* (1489), the third of his *Three Books on Life*, taught how the life of the heavens could be drawn down into the human spirit through images, music, odors, and stones attuned to the stars, a natural magic of celestial influence; glintstone is a Ficinian talisman, starlight condensed in stone. Giordano Bruno pushed the astral imagination to the infinite. In *De l'infinito, universo e mondi* (1584) he taught a universe without center or circumference, filled with innumerable worlds, and in 1600 he was burned in Rome. Azur and Lusat, who gazed upon the Primeval Current and were consumed into crystal, are Bruno's heirs in the Lands Between, heretics of the infinite.

Beneath the earth lie the Eternal Cities of the Nox, Nokron and Nokstella, whose people, the lore suggests, were punished by the Greater Will for an ambition that many interpreters read as an attempt to make a lord of their own, and whose cities were cast down beneath the earth. Over the subterranean rivers of Siofra and Ainsel arches a false night sky, glittering with stars that are not stars. The Nox were makers of silver: their silver tears, the substance of the Mimic Tear that copies whatever stands before it, are the lunar metal answering the solar gold of the Erdtree. The story has the structure of Babel (Genesis 11:1–9), whose builders sought a tower with its top in the heavens and were scattered by the God whose prerogative they had approached; it has the structure, too, of the cave in Plato's *Republic* (514a–520a), whose prisoners take images for realities, since the Nox, deprived of the true sky, live beneath its imitation. Ranni's quest passes through the Eternal Cities, and on one reading her Age of Stars fulfills their ambition: the people punished for seeking a lord of the night are vindicated by a god of the dark moon, and the false sky beneath the earth is answered by an order removed to the true one.

Dante gave this itinerary its classic form. The *Inferno* ends as the pilgrim climbs out of the underworld and emerges to see the stars again, and each of the three canticles of the *Commedia* ends on the same word, *stelle*. The Tarnished's descent into the Eternal Cities and ascent to the cathedral of the moon is a Dantean itinerary whose goal is not paradise but the stars themselves.

6.4

THE MOON AND ITS WITCHES: CARIA'S LUNAR THEOLOGY

Caria is a realm of the moon. Its queen, Rennala, is the Queen of the Full Moon, whose sorcery calls down a vast, pale moon upon her enemies and who grants rebirth from her amber egg; her daughter Ranni bears the Dark Moon, a cold, dark-blue moon whose sorcery freezes, and whose greatsword she entrusts to her chosen consort. Carian lore associates each of its royal witches with a moon of her own. The lunar theology of Caria is the natural counterpart to the solar gold of the Erdtree, and the first marriage of Radagon, examined in Chapter 4, was an alliance of the two: the red champion of the Golden Order wedded to the Queen of the Full Moon. Ranni's quest restores the moon's independence. Her dark moon is not a reflection of the sun, as the moon is in nature, but a light of its own, cold where the gold is warm, distant where the Erdtree is near.

Japanese myth locates the origin of the separation of sun and moon in an act of violence. In the *Nihon Shoki*, the moon god Tsukuyomi, sent by his sister Amaterasu to visit the food goddess Ukemochi, is so revolted by the manner in which she produces food from her mouth that he strikes her dead; Amaterasu, told of it, declares him a wicked deity and refuses ever again to see him face to face, and from that time the sun and moon dwell apart, the one by day and the other by night (Aston 1896). The separation of the luminaries is the consequence of the moon's act, and the moon's portion is distance. The parallel with Caria is inexact but suggestive. Ranni's separation from the golden order follows her own act of violence, the Night of the Black Knives, and her chosen condition is distance. But where Tsukuyomi's distance is imposed by the sun, Ranni's is chosen, and it is the sun's order that will be removed.

Greek religion supplies the figure of the witch who serves the moon. Hecate, whom Hesiod honored as a goddess of wide powers on land, sea, and sky (*Theogony* 411–452), became in later tradition the patroness of witches, invoked by Medea (Euripides, *Medea* 395–397), worshipped at crossroads, attended by hounds, and represented in three-bodied images facing three ways. Ranni the Witch, with her four arms, her lunar sorcery, and her household of a giant and a wolf, is Hecate's heir, and her wolf, Blaidd, whose name is the Welsh word for wolf, is Hecate's hound. Diana, the Roman huntress identified with the moon, belongs to the same constellation, and the grove at Nemi with which Frazer opened *The Golden Bough* was hers: the priest-king who had to be slain by his successor served the goddess of the moon. The lunar tradition thus already contained the structure Chapter 3 identified at the heart of the Golden Order's crisis, the necessity that sovereigns die. Ranni, the moon's witch who stole death, is its executor.

6.5

THE FINGERS, THE SHADOWS, AND THE GUARDIANS: SURVEILLANCE AND TUTELAGE

Ranni's rebellion is directed against an apparatus. The Two Fingers, the Greater Will's emissaries, select the Empyreans who may succeed to godhood, and to each Empyrean they assign a Shadowbound Beast: Maliketh to Marika, Blaidd to Ranni. The shadow is guardian, servant, and warden at once, bound to protect the Empyrean while she serves the Fingers' design and, the lore implies, to turn against her should she stray from it. When Ranni defied the Fingers, Blaidd's nature turned upon itself. Loyal to her by every affection, he was bound by his making to oppose her, and his story ends in madness and confinement: the guardian broken by the contradiction between the one he loves and the purpose for which he was made. The Fingers' power over the Empyreans is thus exercised not only from above, through command, but from within, through a companion whose love is also surveillance.

Christian angelology knew this structure in a benign form. Thomas Aquinas taught that every human being is assigned from birth a guardian angel, an invisible companion who illuminates, protects, and directs (*Summa theologiae* I, q. 113). Giorgio Agamben, whose genealogy of the providential machine was examined in §2.2, showed how this angelology became a template for governmental administration. The Shadowbound Beasts are guardian angels made instruments of a regime: visible, bestial, and loyal to the authority that assigned them rather than to the soul they guard. Michel Foucault's *Discipline and Punish* (1975) described the modern form of such power through Jeremy Bentham's panopticon, the prison in which every cell is visible from a central tower whose occupant cannot be seen, so that the inmates, never knowing whether they are observed, come to watch themselves. Power is most effective when it has been internalized. The shadow is the panopticon's tower relocated to the side of the one it watches, a surveillance in the form of companionship. Ranni's escape required not only the death of the body through which the Fingers held her, but the loss of the companion through whom they watched her.

Immanuel Kant's answer to the question "What is Enlightenment?" (1784) opens with a definition that might stand over Ranni's ending. Enlightenment is humanity's emergence from its self-incurred immaturity, the inability to use one's own understanding without the guidance of another; its motto is *sapere aude*, have the courage to use your own understanding. Kant observed that the guardians who have kindly taken upon themselves the supervision of others first make their domestic cattle dumb, ensure that these placid creatures dare not take a single step without the leading strings to which they are harnessed, and then show them the danger that threatens them should they try to walk alone. The Two Fingers are Kant's guardians: an apparatus that interprets for the world a will it cannot hear, chooses its gods, binds its successors, and warns of the danger of every alternative.

Ranni seeks a blade said to be capable of wounding the Fingers themselves, and her order of stars, removed from the world, would leave the Lands Between without guardians for the first time since the golden star fell. Whether the world, released from tutelage, will walk is the wager of her ending.

6.6

THE DOLL AND THE GOD: DECREATION, GRACE, AND THE MARRIAGE OF OTHERS

Ranni's most radical act was done to herself. She killed her own body with the stolen death and continued as a spirit housed in a doll, a small, cold figure with four arms and a face of porcelain. Simone Weil coined the term *decreation* for the operation her spiritual physics demanded of the self: to make something created pass into the uncreated, to undo in oneself the self that fills every void, so that grace may enter. God, in Weil's theology, created the world by withdrawing, and the creature can imitate God only by withdrawing in turn, consenting to be nothing so that the good may be. Ranni's death of the body is decreation in a literal and political sense. She undid the flesh through which the Fingers held her, made herself less than she had been in order to be free of a destiny, and survives as a remainder, a will without its creaturely vessel. The decreation is incomplete in Weil's sense, since Ranni does not consent to nothingness but seeks sovereignty; yet the form of her freedom, a freedom purchased by self-subtraction, is Weil's.

Heinrich von Kleist's essay "On the Marionette Theatre" (1810) offers the most surprising key to the figure of the doll-god. Kleist's interlocutor, a dancer, argues that the marionette possesses a grace no human dancer can attain, because it lacks the affectation that consciousness introduces into movement; the puppet's soul is located at its center of gravity, and its limbs follow as pendulums. Human beings, having eaten of the tree of knowledge, have lost this grace and can regain it only by traveling through the infinite and finding paradise, as it were, open again from behind. The essay closes with a sentence that might serve as an epigraph for Ranni: grace appears most purely in that human form which has either no consciousness at all or an infinite one, *d.h. in dem Gliedermann, oder in dem Gott*, that is, in the jointed puppet, or in the god. Ranni is both. A doll who becomes a god, she occupies at once the two places where Kleist located perfect grace, and the convergence of Weil's grace, the supernatural counterforce to gravity, with Kleist's grace, the beauty of movement freed from self-consciousness, is nowhere more exact than in the Lunar Princess. The center of gravity, where Kleist placed the marionette's soul, is the very force her half-brother used to bind the stars.

The doll also carries the charge that E. T. A. Hoffmann's "The Sandman" (1816) gave it and that Freud analyzed in "The Uncanny" (1919). Hoffmann's student Nathanael falls in love with Olimpia, a beautiful automaton he takes for a woman, and is destroyed by the

discovery; Freud, though he located the tale's deepest uncanniness elsewhere, acknowledged the dread provoked by figures whose animation is uncertain. Ranni's doll is uncanny in this sense, an inanimate form that speaks, commands, and loves; but the game reverses Hoffmann's plot. Nathanael's love for the doll is a delusion that ends in madness. The Tarnished's devotion to Ranni, if the player chooses it, ends in a marriage, and the marriage is the condition of a new world.

That marriage deserves attention, because it answers the marriage examined in Chapter 4. In the cathedral of the moon, the Tarnished places the ring of the dark moon upon Ranni's hand, and she takes the Tarnished as her consort. Radagon and Marika married themselves: a god divided into two persons and united to its own other aspect, a *coniunctio* without an other. Ranni and the Tarnished are radically other to one another: a god and an exile, a spirit and a body, a lunar witch and a bearer of the Erdtree's grace, an Empyrean who killed her flesh and a mortal who has died a thousand times. Their union is a *coniunctio* of genuine opposites, the alchemical marriage that the Golden Order's self-union failed to achieve. Whether it produces the stone, or only a more distant order, is again the question of the ending.

6.7

THE AGE OF STARS: FROM THE CLOSED WORLD TO THE INFINITE UNIVERSE

In the ending that bears her name, Ranni, the Lunar Princess become a god, takes the order of the Lands Between away. She neither restores the Golden Order nor founds another order upon the world. She removes order to a great distance, into the stars, on a voyage she reckons in a thousand years, and she departs with the Tarnished as her consort. The Lands Between are left beneath a sky of moving stars, ungoverned by any present god. It is the only ending in which no order is imposed upon the world from within it.

Aristotle's cosmology provides the frame in which the ending's logic becomes clearest. In *On the Heavens* the region beyond the moon is composed of a fifth element, ungenerated and indestructible, moving in perfect circles; in *On Generation and Corruption* the region beneath the moon is the domain of the four elements, of coming-to-be and passing-away, of mixture, change, and death. The moon is the boundary between the incorruptible and the corruptible. Read in these terms, the Golden Order's chrysopoeia was an attempt to impose the incorruptibility of the superlunary heavens upon the sublunary world, to make gold, which does not tarnish, the law of a realm whose nature is generation and corruption. Ranni, the moon's witch, restores the boundary. She carries incorruptible order back into the heavens where it belongs and leaves the sublunary world to the processes that are its life: change, mixture, decay, and death. The Age of Stars is the Aristotelian cosmos restored

after a chrysopoeic transgression. In the vocabulary of this thesis, it is the return of the patinal world to itself, with the gold removed to the only place where gold does not tarnish.

Alexandre Koyré described the scientific revolution of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries as a passage *From the Closed World to the Infinite Universe* (1957): the destruction of the finite, hierarchically ordered cosmos of medieval thought, with the earth at its center and the heavens in their spheres, and its replacement by an infinite, homogeneous universe without center or hierarchy. The Golden Order is a closed world in Koyré's sense, organized around a single axis, the Erdtree, at the center of a finite realm ruled by a single law. Ranni's age opens it to the infinite. Pascal registered the existential cost of that opening in the sentence that has become the motto of modern cosmic solitude: the eternal silence of these infinite spaces frightens me. In the same pages he gave humanity its compensating dignity. A human being is only a reed, the weakest thing in nature, but a thinking reed; the universe could crush it, yet it would still be nobler than what kills it, because it knows that it dies. The Age of Stars is Pascal's universe, silent, infinite, without a present god, terrifying and dignifying at once, and it is the only ending in which the inhabitants of the Lands Between are left to discover what they might become without a guardian.

Emmanuel Levinas's *Totality and Infinity* (1961) supplies the ethical vocabulary for the ending's distinctive structure. Levinas opposed totality, the system that comprehends every particular and absorbs it into a whole, to infinity, the relation with the other that exceeds every system and preserves the other's separateness. Separation, for Levinas, is not the failure of relation but its condition: only a being separate from me can be other to me, and the ethical relation is a relation across a distance it does not abolish. The Golden Order was a totality, a Ring binding the world into a single law; the Frenzied Flame, as Chapter 7 shows, is totality's annihilating limit, the fusion of all into one. Ranni's order is an order of separation. It governs, if it governs at all, by distance, and it respects the world by not being present in it. The ending also inverts the Gnostic myth it otherwise resembles. In the Gnostic exodus the soul flees the cosmos toward a distant god; in the Age of Stars it is the order that leaves and the world that remains. And it repeats the Greater Will's withdrawal as a deliberate act. Chapter 2 argued that the Lands Between suffered a theogony of departures, in which gods abandoned the world they had ordered. Ranni is the first god to depart for the world's sake: a *tsimtsum* chosen rather than suffered, a god who withdraws so that the world may be its own.

Chapter 5 promised that one ending would take the form of walking away from Omelas. Le Guin's walkers leave the city of happiness for a place, she wrote, even less imaginable than the city itself, and they seem to know where they are going. Ranni walks away and takes the city's order with her, leaving the basement and its prisoner, the Lands Between and their abjects, to whatever they can make of themselves. The ending does not pretend that this is a consolation. Plato's *Statesman* warned that a cosmos released by its helmsman forgets its maker's instruction and drifts toward the sea of unlikeness, and the Lands Between, left without a present order, may do the same. The Age of Stars is a wager that the world, freed from gold and from guardians, can live in its own corruptible time. Its risk is loneliness,

the cold of a sky without a god. Its promise is that the world, for the first time, will be answerable to itself.

6.8

CONCLUSION: GRACE AT A DISTANCE

Ranni is the Lands Between's metaphysical rebel and its most original theologian. She stole death and returned it, in a violent and fragmentary form, to a world that had sealed it away. She killed her own body to escape a destiny written in stars held fast by gravity. She drew upon an astral theology older than the Erdtree, a Platonic and Hermetic tradition of star-souls, celestial influence, and infinite worlds. She defied an apparatus of guardians that ruled through love as surveillance. She became, as a doll and a god, the locus of a grace that Kleist and Weil, from opposite directions, placed beyond the reach of ordinary consciousness. And she married an exile, a true other, in a union that answers the self-marriage of Radagon and Marika. Her age removes incorruptible order to the heavens and returns the earth to generation and corruption.

The chapter's title names the paradox her ending embodies. In Weil's physics, grace is the force that counters gravity, and it enters only where a void has been left open. Ranni's gift to the Lands Between is a void: the absence of a present god, the removal of the Ring's law to the stars. Whether grace will enter that void, or whether the world, unguided, will fall back into the gravity of its old compulsions, the game does not say. It offers the Age of Stars as one answer to the Mending Problem among six, and the only one in which the mending consists in a departure. Chapter 7 turns to the answers that consist in fire: the Frenzied Flame that would unmake every distinction, and the despair that would curse every birth.

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CHAPTER

7

THE FIRE THAT UNMAKES

Frenzy, Despair, and the Apocalyptic Imagination

Sabbaṃ, bhikkhave, ādittaṃ.
— *Ādittapariyāya Sutta* (*Saṃyutta Nikāya* 35.28)

Burning burning burning burning
— T. S. Eliot, *The Waste Land* (1922), 308

7.1

THE THREE FINGERS AND THE YELLOW FLAME

Beneath the capital of the Golden Order, below the sewers in which it confines its Omens, below its gaols and catacombs, lies a door that opens only to those who have cast off everything they carry. Behind it wait the Three Fingers, emissaries of the Outer God called the Frenzied Flame. The Tarnished who strips to the skin and enters is embraced by them and rises with eyes burning yellow, marked as the Lord of Frenzied Flame. In the ending that follows, the Elden Ring is not mended but consumed. The yellow fire spreads across the Lands Between, melting the world and its creatures into a single conflagration, and Melina, who has guided the Tarnished from the beginning, appears only to renounce the new lord and to vow that she will seek them out, however far they travel, to deliver what is owed to them: Destined Death.

The way to the Three Fingers is prepared by figures of mutilated sight. Hyetta, a blind maiden met at the roadsides of Liurnia, asks the Tarnished for grapes and is sustained by fruits that prove to be eyes, until she declares herself a maiden of the flame. Shabriri, whom the lore calls the most reviled man in history, had his eyes gouged out and replaced by the yellow flame; his spirit, inhabiting the corpse of a hunter who had pursued the flame's servants, tempts the Tarnished with its promise. Vyke, a knight of the Roundtable once favored to become Elden Lord, lies imprisoned on the Mountaintops of the Giants, his armor fused with the flame he embraced, and a widely held reading supposes that he took the flame to spare his own maiden the fate of the kindling. The expansion adds Midra, Lord of Frenzied Flame, whose manse in the Land of Shadow it makes a reliquary of the flame's seduction. In each case the flame enters through the eyes, and in the game's mechanics it does so literally: the frenzied incantations pour fire from the caster's eyes, and the madness the flame inflicts accumulates in those who look upon its bearers.

The doctrine of the flame, as its devotees present it, is a doctrine of suffering. Suffering, it holds, arises from distinction itself: from the separation of beings, from the boundaries between self and other, high and low, golden and accursed. The Golden Order multiplied distinctions and called its hierarchy grace; the Frenzied Flame proposes to end suffering by ending distinction, melting all things into one. The flame is yellow, and Chapter 1 observed that its color occupies the position of *xanthosis*, the yellowing that the alchemical tradition itself forgot. It is buried deepest beneath the capital because it is the most radical of the Golden Order's repressed truths: that an order founded on distinction produces, in those it distinguishes as lowest, the desire to annihilate distinction altogether.

Two precedents frame the flame's mode of action. H. P. Lovecraft's "The Colour Out of Space" (1927) imagines a meteorite that brings to a New England farm a color no human eye has seen, which seeps into the soil, the water, and the minds of the family who live there, driving them mad and crumbling them at last into gray dust; the alien is a color, and it infects

by being seen. FromSoftware's *Bloodborne* (2015) made the logic mechanical. Its hunters accumulate Insight by encountering the eldritch, and the greater their Insight, the more vulnerable they become to Frenzy, a madness inflicted by the sight of creatures crowned with eyes. Knowledge itself becomes the channel of madness. The Frenzied Flame inherits both: a color from outside, transmitted by sight, whose ultimate gift is the dissolution of the one who sees.

7.2

THE PRIMORDIAL UNITY: NIETZSCHE, FREUD, AND THE DEATH DRIVE

NIETZSCHE'S *The Birth of Tragedy* (1872) opposed two artistic drives under the names of two gods. Apollo is the god of form, measure, and dream, of the beautiful illusion by which the individual is held within the boundaries of the *principium individuationis*, the principle of individuation that Nietzsche borrowed from Schopenhauer. Dionysus is the god of intoxication, in whose rites the principle of individuation is shattered and the individual, in terror and rapture, is reabsorbed into the primordial unity (*das Ur-Eine*) that underlies all appearances. Attic tragedy, for the young Nietzsche, was the precarious union of the two, in which the Dionysian abyss was given Apollonian form and could therefore be borne. The Lands Between have split the tragic union into two pathologies. The Golden Order is Apollo without Dionysus: form, hierarchy, measure, and individuation fixed in gold and severed from the ground of life, from death, mixture, and intoxication. The Frenzied Flame is Dionysus without Apollo: the dissolution of every boundary into the primordial unity, with no form to make it bearable. Each is the other's consequence. An order that has refused the Dionysian entirely produces, beneath its own foundations, a Dionysian negation of order as such.

Freud gave the same opposition a biological form in *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920). Confronted with the compulsion to repeat traumatic experience, he hypothesized beside the life drives a death drive: a tendency inherent in organic life to restore an earlier state of things, ultimately the inorganic state from which life emerged, so that, in his notorious formulation, the aim of all life is death. Borrowing a term from the psychoanalyst Barbara Low, he called the tendency to reduce internal tension to zero the "Nirvana principle." The Frenzied Flame is the death drive given cosmic scope: the return of every form to the undifferentiated, the reduction of every tension to zero, the end of suffering through the end of the beings who suffer. Its seduction is the one Freud discerned beneath the pleasure principle, a longing not for pleasure but for quiet, for the cessation of the excitation that being alive and separate entails.

Two works of recent decades dramatized the Frenzied Flame's promise with particular force. In Hideaki Anno's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–96) and its cinematic conclusion,

The End of Evangelion (1997), a secret organization pursues the Human Instrumentality Project, the dissolution of the "AT Fields" that separate one person from another, so that all human souls may merge into a single consciousness free of loneliness and pain. At the climax the boy Shinji, offered the merged sea, chooses instead a world of separate others, knowing that separation means the possibility of being hurt. The Frenzied Flame is Instrumentality in the idiom of fire, and the refusal Evangelion's ending stages is the refusal Melina embodies. Team Cherry's *Hollow Knight* (2017) supplies the counterpart in the idiom of light. Its kingdom of Hallownest is threatened by the Radiance, a forgotten god of light whose infection binds the minds of its victims into a single dream, and which the kingdom's king sought to seal within a vessel engineered to have no mind, no will, and no voice. The Radiance and the Frenzied Flame are versions of the same god: a luminous unity that ends the suffering of individuals by ending their individuality.

The opposition of the Golden Order and the Frenzied Flame also places *Elden Ring* within a tradition of fantasy cosmology. Michael Moorcock's Elric stories, beginning in the 1960s, made the war of Law and Chaos the axis of a multiverse held precariously in a Cosmic Balance, and Atlus's *Shin Megami Tensei* (1992) translated the structure into alignments among which its player must choose: an order that crushes freedom, a chaos that crushes the weak, and a neutral path between them. The Golden Order and the Frenzied Flame occupy the poles of this tradition, Law as incorruptible statute and Chaos as total fusion. But the game does not offer neutrality as the balance between them. Its middle term, as the next section argues, is not an equilibrium of order and chaos but something neither pole can accommodate: death.

7

7.3

ALL IS BURNING: THE FIRE SERMON AND THE INVERTED NIRVĀṆA

The most precise key to the Frenzied Flame is a sermon preached some two and a half millennia ago near Gayā. According to the *Ādittapariyāya Sutta* (*Saṃyutta Nikāya* 35.28), the Buddha addressed a thousand monks, formerly fire-worshipping ascetics, with the words that stand as this chapter's first epigraph: all, monks, is burning. And what is the all that is burning? The eye is burning, visible forms are burning, the consciousness of the eye is burning, the contact of the eye is burning, and whatever feeling arises with that contact as its condition is burning: burning with the fire of lust, the fire of hatred, the fire of delusion, burning with birth, aging, and death, with sorrow, lamentation, pain, grief, and despair. The sermon repeats the analysis for each of the senses and for the mind, and concludes that the noble disciple, seeing thus, becomes disenchanted, dispassionate, and freed (Bodhi 2000). The Frenzied Flame literalizes the sermon's diagnosis with uncanny fidelity. It is a fire, and it enters through the eye; its first emissaries are figures whose eyes have been

put out or replaced by flame; and its doctrine names the same root as the Buddha's, the suffering that arises in the separate, sensing self.

Its remedy, however, is the inverse of the Buddha's. *Nirvāṇa* means "extinguishing" or "blowing out": the extinction of the three fires of lust, hatred, and delusion, in whose cooling suffering ceases. The Frenzied Flame proposes not to extinguish the fire but to universalize it, to burn away the distinctions in which suffering lodges until nothing remains to burn. It is an inverted *nirvāṇa*, an end of suffering by conflagration rather than extinction, an end of the self not through the cessation of craving but through the fusion of all selves into fire. T. S. Eliot, who titled the third section of *The Waste Land* "The Fire Sermon" and set the Buddha beside Augustine at its close, remarked in his notes that the sermon corresponds in importance to the Sermon on the Mount; the section ends in a litany of burning, and the poem's relief, if it comes, comes with water. The Lands Between know a comparable alternation. The Frenzied Flame burns, and the only power the game opposes to it in the ending it produces is the promise of death.

Buddhist doctrine also supplies the most exact map of the Frenzied Flame's position, and of the Golden Order's. In the *Kaccānagotta Sutta* (*Saṃyutta Nikāya* 12.15), the Buddha teaches that the world for the most part depends upon a duality, the notion of existence and the notion of non-existence: that everything exists is one extreme, that nothing exists is the other, and the Tathāgata, avoiding both, teaches by the middle, through dependent origination. The tradition named the two extremes eternalism (*sassatavāda*), the doctrine of an imperishable self or substance, and annihilationism (*ucchedavāda*), the doctrine that being ends in nothing. The Golden Order and the Frenzied Flame are the two extremes of the *Kaccānagotta Sutta*. The Golden Order is eternalism institutionalized: an incorruptible order of undying beings, a gold that does not tarnish. The Frenzied Flame is annihilationism enthroned: the end of all beings in a single fire. Chapter 4 called them two velocities of the same henological desire, and the Buddhist analysis shows why. Both refuse dependent origination, the middle way of impermanent, interdependent, conditioned arising and passing away, in which beings neither endure forever nor dissolve into nothing but come to be and cease in relation to one another. The patinal ontology this thesis proposes is, in its own idiom, a philosophy of that middle way.

Greek philosophy knew a cosmic fire of the opposite tendency. Heraclitus described the world-order as an ever-living fire, kindling in measures and going out in measures (fr. B30), and the Stoics, developing his physics, taught a periodic *ekpyrōsis*, a conflagration in which the cosmos is resolved into fire and from which it is reborn, identical, in a *palingenesia* (Kirk, Raven, and Schofield 1983). The decisive term is measure. Heraclitus's fire burns and is quenched in proportion, and the Stoic conflagration is followed by rebirth. The Frenzied Flame knows no measure and promises no return. It is fire as Heraclitus's world-order would be if its measures were abolished: not the life of the cosmos but its end.

7.4

THE WILL TO NON-BEING: SCHOPENHAUER, MAINLÄNDER, AND THE PESSIMIST TRADITION

EUROPEAN PHILOSOPHY produced its own doctrine of the Frenzied Flame's kind, and it did so in conscious dialogue with Buddhism. Arthur Schopenhauer's *The World as Will and Representation* (1819) described the inner nature of the world as a blind, insatiable will, objectified in a multiplicity of individuals through the *principium individuationis*, each striving against the others, so that the will perpetually devours itself, and life oscillates between the pain of unsatisfied desire and the boredom of satisfaction. Salvation lies only in the denial of the will-to-live, achieved by the saint who sees through individuation and ceases to will, and Schopenhauer, who kept a statue of the Buddha in his rooms, identified that denial with *nirvāṇa*. His great work ends with a sentence that states the Frenzied Flame's creed in its most austere form: for those in whom the will has turned and denied itself, this very real world of ours, with all its suns and galaxies, is nothing (*ist diese unsere so sehr reale Welt mit allen ihren Sonnen und Milchstraßen — Nichts*).

Nietzsche, who began as Schopenhauer's disciple and ended as his antagonist, saw in this philosophy the most uncanny symptom of European culture, its detour, he wrote in the preface to the *Genealogy of Morality* (1887), toward a new Buddhism, a European Buddhism, toward nihilism. The detour had already been taken. Eduard von Hartmann's *Philosophy of the Unconscious* (1869) projected a future in which humanity, its consciousness sufficiently advanced, would collectively will the end of the world-process; Philipp Mainländer, whose *Philosophy of Redemption* (1876) Chapter 4 read as a metaphysics of Marika's self-fracture, held that the cosmos is the decomposing body of a God who willed non-being and that its history tends toward nothing. In the twentieth century the Norwegian philosopher Peter Wessel Zapffe imagined, in "The Last Messiah" (1933), a prophet who tells humanity that its overdeveloped consciousness is its curse and that its only redemption is to cease, and who is killed for his message; Thomas Ligotti's *The Conspiracy Against the Human Race* (2010) revived the tradition for contemporary horror. The Lord of Frenzied Flame is the last messiah of the Lands Between, the redeemer whose redemption is extinction.

Elden Ring gives this tradition its most seductive form and its most decisive answer. The seduction lies in the Frenzied Flame's diagnosis, which the game does not refute: the Lands Between are a world of suffering, and much of that suffering is produced by the distinctions of the Golden Order. The answer lies in the structure of the ending. The flame does not relieve suffering in a world of beings who suffer; it ends the world, and no one remains to be relieved. Its peace is the peace of a world with no one in it, and Melina's vow, examined in this chapter's conclusion, names the only power in the Lands Between that can oppose it: not a better order, but death.

7.5

THE FELL GOD AND THE KINDLING MAIDEN: RAGNARÖK, BRÜNNHILDE, AND THE MEASURED FIRE

The Lands Between contain two fires capable of burning the Erdtree, and the difference between them is the difference between renewal and annihilation. The first is the flame of the Fell God, sealed in the Forge of the Giants after Marika's war, which the Tarnished reaches at the summit of the Mountaintops of the Giants. It can be lit only with kindling, and the kindling is Melina, the maiden who has accompanied the Tarnished since the first night and who gives herself to the fire so that the Erdtree may burn and the Ring may be mended. The second is the Frenzied Flame, which needs no kindling but the Tarnished's own surrender, and which burns not to open the way to the Ring but to consume everything, the Ring included. The one is the fire of Heraclitus, kindling in measure; the other is fire without measure.

Northern myth supplies the frame for the first fire. In the *Völuspá* Surtr comes from the south with fire, the bane of branches, and the sun glitters from the sword of the gods of the slain; rocks split, troll-women stumble, the dead tread the road to Hel, and heaven is cloven; the sun turns black, the earth sinks into the sea, the bright stars fall from the sky, and steam and flame play high against heaven itself. Yet the poem does not end there. The earth rises a second time from the sea, green and renewed; the surviving gods gather on Iðavöllr; Baldr returns; and, as Chapter 2 observed, the golden tables are found again in the grass. The fire of Ragnarök is the fire of an ending that is also a beginning. The Fell God's flame, which Marika sealed as the Æsir could not seal Surtr's, belongs to this type: it burns the world tree so that a world may begin again.

Wagner gave this fire its operatic apotheosis, and its kindling a name. At the end of *Götterdämmerung*, the last drama of *Der Ring des Nibelungen*, Brünnhilde orders a pyre built for Siegfried, takes from his hand the ring forged from the stolen gold, mounts her horse, and rides into the flames. The fire consumes the hall, the Rhine overflows its banks, the Rhinemaidens reclaim the ring and return the gold to the river, and in the distance Valhalla, the citadel of the gods, is seen burning with the gods within it. A woman who has loved and been betrayed gives herself to the fire, and her immolation ends the order of the gods and returns the gold to its source. Melina is the Brünnhilde of the Lands Between. Her sacrifice at the Forge ends the Erdtree's reign, and the Ring she makes it possible to mend is the gold returned, if not to a river, then to a world that can again change. Wagner, who drafted Brünnhilde's final words more than once under the successive influences of Feuerbach and Schopenhauer and in the end left the meaning of her act to the music, bequeathed to the last scene of the *Ring* the same ambiguity that Melina's sacrifice retains: whether it is redemption through love, renunciation of the will, or simply the end of a world.

The kindling maiden also belongs to a darker lineage, that of the daughter sacrificed so that an enterprise may proceed. Iphigenia was slain at Aulis so that the Greek fleet might sail for Troy, and in Euripides' *Iphigenia at Aulis* she ends by consenting to her death and claiming it as her own gift to Greece; Jephthah's daughter, in the Book of Judges (11:29–40), was offered as a burnt offering in fulfillment of her father's vow, after asking only for two months to mourn upon the mountains with her companions. These narratives disclose the cost the Golden Order's renewal exacts: the world tree can burn only if a maiden burns with it. Melina differs from both in one crucial respect. Her purpose, she says, was given by her mother, and she accepts it; but she can also refuse. When the Tarnished embraces the Frenzied Flame, Melina does not consent to be its kindling. She withdraws, and vows instead to bring the Lord of Frenzied Flame the death that is owed. Her sacrifice is not unconditional obedience. It is a choice for one kind of fire against another.

7.6

THE BLACK FLAME AND THE GODSKINS: THE THEOLOGY OF GOD-SLAYING

A THIRD FIRE BURNS in the Lands Between, and it is black. The Godskin Apostles and their corpulent counterparts, the Godskin Nobles, wield the Black Flame, a fire that the lore associates with the power to kill gods and, on many readings, with Destined Death itself. Their order once served a figure called the Gloam-Eyed Queen, a wielder of the Black Flame whom Maliketh, keeper of Destined Death, is said to have defeated. The Apostles' name is literal. They are clothed in the skins of gods, their weapon, the Godskin Peeler, is the instrument by which divine hides are flayed, and their incantations imitate the fire of their vanished queen. They are a priesthood of theocide, a church whose sacrament is the killing of gods and the wearing of what remains.

Nietzsche's madman, running into the marketplace with a lantern in the bright morning, announced that God is dead and that we have killed him, and asked the question the Godskins answer: how shall we comfort ourselves, the murderers of all murderers, and must we not ourselves become gods simply to appear worthy of the deed (*The Gay Science* §125)? The Godskins become gods by wearing them. The practice has a terrible precedent in the Nahua festival of Tlacaxipehualiztli, the "flaying of men," recorded by Sahagún, at which the priests of Xipe Totec, "Our Lord the Flayed One," wore the skins of sacrificial victims in a rite of renewal, the dead skin shed as the earth sheds its husk in spring. The Greek myth of Marsyas inverts the relation: the satyr who challenged Apollo to a contest of music was flayed alive by the god (Ovid, *Metamorphoses* 6.382–400), and Dante, beginning the *Paradiso*, asked Apollo to enter his breast and breathe as when he drew Marsyas from the sheath of his limbs (*Paradiso* 1.19–21), making the flaying a figure of the soul's release into divine song. Michelangelo, painting the Last Judgment in the Sistine Chapel, set his

own features upon the flayed skin held by Saint Bartholomew. Flaying, in these traditions, is at once violation, divestment, and transfiguration. The Godskins' theology is its darkest form: not the god flaying the mortal to release the soul, but mortals flaying gods in order to wear their divinity.

The Godskins are the Tarnished's dark mirror. The Tarnished, too, kills gods. Every demigod who falls in the game's present falls to the Tarnished's hand, and at the end the Tarnished fells the second Elden Lord and the vassal beast of the Greater Will itself. The difference lies in what follows. The Godskins kill gods in order to become them, to wear divinity like a garment, and theirs is a theocide that perpetuates the logic of godhood by changing its occupants. The Tarnished kills gods in order to restore death to the world, returning the divine to finitude. The Godskins flay the gods and keep the skin. The Tarnished releases the runes and lets the bodies die.

7.7

THE BLESSING OF DESPAIR: THE DUNG EATER, RESSENTIMENT, AND REDEMPTION THROUGH SIN

The Dung Eater's ending, called the Blessing of Despair, is the most disturbing of the six, and it completes the logic of abjection traced in Chapter 5. With the Mending Rune of the Fell Curse, the Tarnished mends the Ring so that the curse borne by the Omens falls upon all who are born. The Dung Eater's reasoning, as he presents it, is a theology of revenge: the Golden Order made a curse the sign of exclusion and contempt, and if every being bears the curse, no one can ever again be despised for bearing it. The despised condition becomes universal, and its universality is called a blessing.

Søren Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) offers the deepest anatomy of this blessing. Despair, for Kierkegaard, is the sickness of a self that will not be what it is: either despairingly unwilling to be itself, or despairingly willing to be itself in defiance. Its most intense form he called demonic despair, the despair that wills to be itself in its torment, clinging to its suffering as a protest against existence, and he gave it an unforgettable image. It is as if an author made a slip of the pen, and the error, becoming conscious of itself, refused to be corrected, insisting on remaining as a witness against the author, as proof that the author is a poor writer. The Dung Eater is the Golden Order's demonic despair. He is the error in the Order's text, the defiled and defiling remainder of its purity code, and he refuses correction; he wills instead to make the whole text an error, so that it can no longer be read as anything but testimony against its author. The Blessing of Despair is the slip of the pen that rewrites the book.

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) supplies the political form of the same structure. The slave revolt in morality begins, Nietzsche argued, when *ressentiment* itself becomes creative and gives birth to values. The noble mode of valuation affirms itself and

speaks of the low as "bad" only as an afterthought, while the morality of *ressentiment* begins by saying no to what is outside, different, and other, and calls itself good only by contrast with the evil it has invented in its enemy. The Dung Eater's revaluation is the slave revolt carried to its apocalyptic limit. The Golden Order's "good" was gold and its "bad" the accursed, and the Dung Eater does not reverse these values but abolishes their difference by universalizing the bad. His equality is an equality of degradation, and Nietzsche's diagnosis of *ressentiment* as a morality that cannot affirm but only negate applies with full force. The Blessing of Despair affirms nothing; it ensures only that no one is spared.

Gershom Scholem's essay "Redemption Through Sin" (1937) reconstructed a religious movement whose logic the Dung Eater's design recapitulates. After the self-proclaimed messiah Sabbatai Zevi converted to Islam in 1666 under threat of death, a radical wing of his followers, culminating in the eighteenth-century movement of Jacob Frank, interpreted the apostasy as a messianic descent into the realm of impurity to redeem the holy sparks imprisoned there, and drew the antinomian conclusion that in the messianic age the violation of the law is its fulfillment. Holiness was to be attained through sin; the sparks trapped in the husks could be liberated only by entering the husks. The Lurianic doctrine introduced in Chapter 1 thus contained, in its radical inversion, a theology of redemption through defilement. The Dung Eater is the Frankist of the Lands Between. His Seedbed Curse descends into the impure in order to redeem it, and his Blessing of Despair is an antinomian messianism in which the curse fulfills the law it violates. Scholem's sympathy for the Sabbatians' longing did not blind him to their catastrophe, and the game is equally lucid: the redemption that universal defilement offers is indistinguishable from universal damnation.

7

7.8 CONCLUSION: DEATH AS THE GUARDIAN OF DIFFERENCE

The fires of the Lands Between compose a single argument. The Fell God's flame, kindled by Melina's consent, burns in measure: it destroys the world tree so that a world may begin again, and it belongs with Surtr's fire and Brünnhilde's pyre to the apocalyptic tradition of endings that are also beginnings. The Black Flame of the Godskins kills gods in order to wear them, perpetuating godhood by changing its wearers. The Frenzied Flame burns without measure. It ends suffering by ending distinction: Dionysus without Apollo, the death drive given cosmic scope, the annihilationist extreme that answers the Golden Order's eternalism, a *nirvāṇa* inverted into conflagration. And the Dung Eater's despair, the coldest fire of all, universalizes the curse so that no one may be spared it: the demonic error that rewrites the book.

Against the Frenzied Flame, the game sets one power only, and its identity is the culmination of this chapter's argument. When the Tarnished becomes Lord of Frenzied Flame,

Melina does not promise a better order. She promises death. She vows to find the lord, however far they go, and to deliver Destined Death. The opposition is exact. The Frenzied Flame would end suffering by dissolving every individual into one; Destined Death ends each individual within a world that remains a world of individuals. Death, in this light, is not the enemy of difference but its guardian. It is what Heidegger called the ownmost possibility, the one thing no one can do for another, the boundary that makes each life its own. The Golden Order abolished death in order to preserve its distinctions and produced beneath its foundations a fire that would abolish distinction itself; the restoration of death is the only answer to both. Between the eternalism of gold and the annihilationism of frenzy lies the middle way of beings that arise and pass away in relation to one another, which is the way of the tarnished. Chapter 8 turns from the world's fires to the form in which the world is given to the player: an archive of the dead, read through ruins and fragments, and learned through dying.

WRÆTLIC IS ÞES WEALSTAN, WYRDE GEBRÆCON · WRÆTLIC IS ÞES WEALSTAN, WYRDE GEBRÆCON · WRÆTLIC IS ÞES WEALSTAN, WYRDE GEBRÆCON · WRÆTLIC IS ÞES WEALSTAN, WYRDE GEBRÆCON ·

CHAPTER

8

THE ARCHIVE OF THE DEAD

Ruin, Fragment, and the Hermeneutics of Play

Wrætlic is þes wealstan, wyrde gebræcon;
burgstede burston, brosnað enta geweorc.
— *The Ruin* 1–2

Qui a appris à mourir, il a désappris à servir.
— Montaigne, *Essais* 1.20

8.1

Allegory and Ruin: The Lands Between as Trauerspiel

The preceding chapters read the world of *Elden Ring*. This chapter reads the form in which that world is given. It was argued at the outset (§1.2) that the game's narrative is distributed across fragments, item descriptions, ruined architecture, and the speech of survivors, which the player must assemble; it remains to ask what kind of meaning such a form produces, what kind of reader it creates, and what relation obtains between the form and the ontology this thesis has reconstructed. The answer advanced here is that the form of *Elden Ring* is itself patinal. Its meaning is produced by decay, held in fragments, transmitted by the dead, and learned through dying, so that the player's mode of understanding enacts, at the level of interpretation, the counter-ontology that the Tarnished embodies at the level of the world.

Walter Benjamin's study of the German *Trauerspiel* (1928) remains the most penetrating theory of such a form. Against the Romantic privileging of the symbol, in which meaning and image are fused in an instantaneous totality, Benjamin rehabilitated allegory, in which meaning is arbitrary, fragmentary, and dependent upon the decay of the natural image it inhabits. In allegory, he wrote, the observer is confronted with the *facies hippocratica* of history, the face of the dying, as a petrified primordial landscape; everything about history that has been untimely, sorrowful, and unsuccessful from the beginning is expressed in a face, or rather in a death's head. Allegories, in Benjamin's formula, are in the realm of thought what ruins are in the realm of things. The baroque loved ruins because in the ruin history has merged physically into its setting, so that the transience of everything worldly becomes visible as nature. The Lands Between are an allegorical world in exactly this sense. Nothing in them signifies wholly by itself. Every object refers to a lost whole, every ruin to an event that can no longer be witnessed, every corpse to a story that only its equipment tells. Meaning in *Elden Ring* is not given in presence; it accrues in decay. The game's aesthetic of ruin is not atmosphere but the condition of its legibility.

Benjamin's last text gave the allegorical gaze its most famous figure. In the ninth of his "Theses on the Philosophy of History" (1940), he described Paul Klee's *Angelus Novus* as the angel of history, his face turned toward the past. Where we perceive a chain of events, the angel sees one single catastrophe that keeps piling wreckage upon wreckage and hurls it at his feet. The angel would like to stay, awaken the dead, and make whole what has been smashed; but a storm blowing from Paradise has caught his wings with such violence that he can no longer close them, and it propels him irresistibly into the future to which his back is turned, while the pile of debris before him grows toward the sky. That storm, Benjamin wrote, is what we call progress. The player of *Elden Ring* occupies the angel's posture with uncanny precision. The guidance of grace, a golden light streaming from the Erdtree, drives the Tarnished forward from region to region and from boss to boss, while

the player's attention, absorbed in item descriptions and ruined halls, is turned toward the past, toward the wreckage of the Shattering. And at the end the Tarnished arrives where Benjamin's angel never could: before the broken Ring, with the power to make whole what has been smashed. Whether, and how, to do so is the Mending Problem of Chapter 9. Benjamin's angel teaches the cost of the question. To make whole what has been smashed is the deepest desire of the one who looks at ruins, and the most dangerous, for the whole it would restore is the order that produced the wreckage.

Benjamin found the purest instance of allegory in the emblem books of the sixteenth and seventeenth centuries, and here the formal kinship with *Elden Ring* becomes exact. The emblem, as Andrea Alciato's *Emblematum liber* (1531) established it, consists of three parts: a picture (*pictura*), a motto or title (*inscriptio*), and a short explanatory text (*subscriptio*), usually an epigram, which together yield a meaning none possesses alone. Every item in *Elden Ring* is an emblem in this tripartite sense, an icon, a name, and a brief text often ending in a gnomic sentence, whose meaning emerges only in their conjunction and in their relation to the lost whole to which they refer. The player's inventory is an emblem book of a dead world, assembled not by an author but by the player's own traversal.

8.2

THE WORK OF GIANTS: OLD ENGLISH ELEGY AND THE POETICS OF RUIN

THE VERNACULAR poetry that first gave English its imagination of ruin was written among the wreckage of an empire. *The Ruin*, preserved in the damaged leaves of the Exeter Book and generally thought to contemplate the Roman remains at Bath, opens with the lines that stand as this chapter's first epigraph: wondrous is this wall-stone; fates broke it; the city-places burst; the work of giants decays. The poet sees fallen roofs and ruined towers, frost upon the mortar, and imagines the bright halls that once stood there, the bathhouses and the mead-halls full of revelry, the warriors in ring-mail gazing upon treasure, until days of pestilence came and the brave men died. The Anglo-Saxons called such remains *enta geweorc*, the work of giants, attributing to a vanished race the masonry no living people could build. The Lands Between are composed of such work. Their Divine Towers, cathedrals, and catacombs, the colossal ruins of the Mountaintops, and the fallen Eternal Cities beneath the earth are the work of giants in the literal sense the game supplies and in the Anglo-Saxon sense: the remains of an age whose builders cannot be imagined from the present.

Beowulf supplies the template for the game's most ubiquitous object, the treasure in the tomb. In the passage known as the Lay of the Last Survivor (2247–2266), the last living member of a forgotten people carries his nation's treasure into a barrow and commits it to the earth: *Heald þū nū, hrūse, nū hæleð ne mōston, / eorla æhte*, hold now, earth, now that

heroes cannot, the possessions of nobles. He laments the fallen, the silent harp, the hawk no longer swinging through the hall, and wanders alone until death takes him. A dragon finds the open hoard and broods upon it for three hundred winters, and when a thief steals a cup from it, the dragon wakes and burns the land, and the aged Beowulf goes out to fight it and dies. Every chest in the catacombs of the Lands Between, every relic guarded by a dragon or a beast, every weapon recovered from a corpse at a cliff's edge, belongs to this structure: the treasure of a people who are gone, entrusted to the earth, guarded by monsters, and recovered at mortal risk by a wanderer who will read in it the story of its owners.

J. R. R. Tolkien's lecture "Beowulf: The Monsters and the Critics" (1936) reread the poem as an elegy whose subject is man at war with the hostile world and his inevitable overthrow in Time, and identified at its heart what he called the Northern theory of courage: the creed of warriors and gods who fight on in full knowledge that they will be defeated, the gods of the North themselves destined to fall at Ragnarök and resolved to fight regardless. The monsters, Tolkien argued, are not an embarrassment to the poem's seriousness but its essence, the shapes in which the hostile world presents itself to the mortal who resists it. FromSoftware's monsters stand in the same relation to its world. They are not obstacles placed before a story but the forms in which the ruin resists its reader, and the courage they demand, examined in §8.5, is Tolkien's Northern courage: the will to fight again an enemy one is likely to lose to, because the fighting is what one has.

The modern theory of ruin begins with Georg Simmel's essay "The Ruin" (1911), which saw in the ruined building the moment at which the balance between human will and the forces of nature tips toward nature, so that the work of spirit becomes the material of a new and natural form; nature takes its revenge for the violence spirit did it in shaping it, and the ruin attains a peculiar peace, the present form of a past life. European painting had long cultivated the pleasure such forms afford, the *Ruinenlust* that Rose Macaulay chronicled in *Pleasure of Ruins* (1953): Piranesi's etched visions of Rome and his imaginary prisons, colossal and labyrinthine; Hubert Robert, called "Robert of the Ruins," who painted the Grand Gallery of the Louvre as it would one day appear in ruin; Caspar David Friedrich's abbeys among oaks and his wanderer above a sea of fog. In the twentieth century the Polish painter Zdzisław Beksiński, often cited as an aesthetic touchstone for FromSoftware's art, painted cathedrals of bone and figures dissolving into landscapes beneath bloodied skies. *Elden Ring* is heir to all of them. Its Leyndell, gold over ash, is Robert's Louvre; its Raya Lucaria is a Piranesian prison of stairs; its Tarnished, looking out from the cliffs of Limgrave toward the distant Erdtree, is Friedrich's wanderer; and its Caelid and Mohgwyn are Beksiński's.

8.3

SPEAKING OBJECTS: EPIGRAPHY, TSUKUMOGAMI, AND THE NECROMANTIC ARCHIVE

THE ITEM DESCRIPTION descends from the oldest form of written memory, the inscription. Greek and Latin epitaphs habitually address the passer-by: *siste, viator*, stop, traveler, and read; the epigram attributed to Simonides for the Spartans who fell at Thermopylae asks the stranger to tell the Lacedaemonians that here their dead lie, obedient to their words (Herodotus 7.228). The dead speak to the living through objects placed in their path. The item descriptions of *Elden Ring* are epitaphs of this kind, addressed to the wanderer who stops beside the corpse. They are brief, formulaic, often elegiac, and partisan, written from within the perspectives of the factions whose gear they describe, and like epitaphs they speak of their owners in the past tense, as of persons whose lives are complete. An item description is what remains when a life has become a text.

Japanese folklore offers a richer theory of the speaking object. The *tsukumogami*, "artifact spirits," are household tools, umbrellas, lanterns, sandals, and kettles, that acquire a spirit after long use, traditionally after a hundred years. The Muromachi-period picture scroll *Tsukumogami-ki* tells of discarded implements that, resenting their abandonment, come to life to take revenge upon the humans who threw them away, and Toriyama Sekien's illustrated catalogues of the eighteenth century gave them their canonical forms. The belief encodes a theory of patina. An object becomes animate not by being made but by being used, its spirit accreted through time and contact; age does not degrade it but ensouls it. The objects of the Lands Between are *tsukumogami* in this sense. A sword bears the memory of the hand that held it; a ring remembers a marriage; a torn robe testifies to a persecution. The inventory is a gathering of objects ensouled by use, and the descriptions are their speech. The patinal ontology of this thesis finds here one of its oldest cultural forms: the conviction that time, wear, and use do not diminish things but give them souls.

The early modern cabinet of curiosities, the *Wunderkammer*, gathered such objects into a microcosm of shells and fossils, antiquities and automata, relics and monsters, arranged to mirror the order of the world, as in the celebrated frontispiece of Ole Worm's *Museum Wormianum* (1655). The player of *Elden Ring*, who gathers every weapon, garment, talisman, and relic of a dead world into an inventory that is at once arsenal and museum, is a collector in the sense Walter Benjamin explored in "Unpacking My Library" (1931): one for whom the object, released from its function, enters a magic circle in which it becomes a reliquary of its own history. The completionist impulse, the drive to possess every item, is often dismissed as compulsion, but Benjamin saw in collecting a form of renewal, the rescue of things from the drudgery of usefulness into the order of memory. The inventory of the Lands Between is such an order: the world's only complete chronicle, compiled by its last reader.

The dead of *Elden Ring* do not only speak through objects; they can be summoned. Early in the journey the Tarnished receives a Spirit Calling Bell from a mysterious witch, the first guise in which Ranni appears, and with it the power to call up the Spirit Ashes of the dead, remains that rise as phantoms to fight beside the living. The rite has an ancient pedigree. In the eleventh book of the *Odyssey*, Odysseus digs a trench at the edge of the world and pours blood into it, and the shades crowd up to drink and, having drunk, to speak, telling him of his future and their pasts; in the First Book of Samuel (28:3–25), Saul, abandoned by God, asks the woman of Endor to call up the dead prophet Samuel, who rises to pronounce his doom. Necromancy is the oldest technology of the archive, the art of making the dead available to the living as informants and allies. The Spirit Ashes make the player a necromancer of the Lands Between, and the item descriptions make the player its archivist. In both capacities the player is the steward of the dead.

8.4

THE PALIMPSEST OF STRANGERS: MESSAGES, BLOODSTAINS, AND THE COMMUNITY OF THE DEAD

No player encounters the Lands Between alone. The asynchronous multiplayer system that FromSoftware developed from *Demon's Souls* (2009) onward fills each player's world with the traces of others. Messages, composed from a fixed vocabulary of templates and words, appear on the ground as glowing inscriptions: warnings of ambush, pointers to hidden paths, praise, deception, and jokes. Bloodstains mark the places where other players died, and touching one replays, as a spectral image, the last seconds of a stranger's life. Phantoms flicker past, players in other worlds glimpsed in passage. Miyazaki has recounted that the idea for this system came from an experience of being stranded in snow and helped by strangers whose names he never learned, a cooperation without community, anonymous and transient. The result is a world written over by thousands of hands.

The appropriate philological figure is the palimpsest, the manuscript whose original text was scraped away and overwritten, like the medieval prayer book beneath which modern imaging recovered treatises of Archimedes. Every instance of the Lands Between is a palimpsest, the authored world beneath and the players' inscriptions above, each layer partially effacing and partially revealing the other. A second figure is the glossed manuscript. The *Glossa Ordinaria* surrounded the text of the Bible with marginal and interlinear commentary, and the printed Talmud frames the Mishnah with the Gemara and the Gemara with the commentaries of Rashi and the Tosafists, so that the page itself becomes a conversation across centuries. The Lands Between are glossed in this way. Their primary text, the authored world and its item descriptions, is surrounded by a commentary of messages and bloodstains within the world, and beyond that by the vast exegetical literature of the community. Michael Camille's *Image on the Edge* (1992) showed how the margins of

Gothic manuscripts teemed with drolleries, apes, hybrids, knights jousting with snails, and obscene gestures, a counter-world of play and parody beside the sacred text. The players' messages are the drolleries of the Lands Between.

Mikhail Bakhtin described the medieval carnival as a second life of the people, organized on the basis of laughter: a world turned upside down, in which hierarchies were suspended, the sacred was parodied in a *parodia sacra*, and the high was brought low into the material body. The message system of FromSoftware's games produced, almost immediately, a carnival of this kind. Its fixed grammar, meant for warnings and hints, was turned by players into an instrument of parody, and its most famous product, the combination of templates that yields the sentence "try finger, but hole," has become an emblem of the community's irreverent wit: an obscene joke assembled from the oracular vocabulary of the world. The messages mimic the form of inscription and the imperative of the oracle, and they degrade it, so that the solemn ruin is constantly glossed by laughter. Bakhtin would have recognized the function. Carnival laughter, he argued, defeats fear; it is the people's victory over the terror of death and of power. In a world built of death, the community's laughter is a form of survival.

The bloodstains deserve a final word, because in them the ludic form and the patinal ontology coincide. A bloodstain is the record of a stranger's death at a particular place, inscribed into the surface of the world and replayable by anyone who touches it. Over the life of a game, the most dangerous places of the Lands Between accumulate them in profusion, a crust of deaths along the edges of cliffs, before the doors of bosses, in the traps of catacombs. This is patina in the precise sense defined in Chapter 1: the visible record of exposure, the sedimentation of contact and time upon a surface. The world of the Golden Order, which sought incorruptibility, is in every connected instance literally tarnished by the deaths of its players. The incorruptible world is impossible even as a game. The moment it is played, it acquires a patina of the dead.

8.5

MELETĒ THANATOU: DYING AS METHOD

In Plato's *Phaedo*, Socrates, on the day of his death, tells his friends that those who engage in philosophy rightly are practicing nothing other than dying and being dead (64a), and later that true philosophers make dying their study (67e). The phrase the tradition drew from these passages, *meletē thanatou*, the practice or rehearsal of death, became a definition of philosophy for the Stoics and for Montaigne. Seneca wrote to Lucilius that whoever bids you rehearse death bids you rehearse freedom (*meditare mortem; qui hoc dicit, meditari libertatem iubet*, *Epistulae* 26.10). Montaigne, in the essay titled "That to Philosophize Is to Learn to Die" (*Essais* 1.20), gave the thought its most memorable form: since it is uncertain where death awaits us, let us await it everywhere; to premeditate death

is to premeditate freedom; whoever has learned to die has unlearned how to serve. The last clause stands as this chapter's second epigraph, because it states the political content of the practice the game imposes upon its player.

No medium has made the rehearsal of death as literal as the games of FromSoftware, and *Elden Ring* perfects the practice. The player dies constantly: to ambushes, to falls, to the overwhelming bosses who guard every region, sometimes dozens or hundreds of times before a single encounter is mastered. Each death is announced by the same red words across a darkened screen; each returns the Tarnished to the last Site of Lost Grace; and each costs the runes the Tarnished was carrying, which lie at the place of death and can be recovered only by returning there without dying again. The procedure is a pedagogy. It teaches attention, patience, humility, and detachment from the accumulations that a single mistake can take away. Jesper Juul's paradox of failure (2013), that players seek out activities that reliably make them feel inadequate, finds here its most extreme case and its resolution: failure is the medium in which learning becomes perceptible. But the significance of the practice exceeds the psychology of skill. Its player, told at the outset that the Tarnished are dead who yet live, learns the world by dying in it, and the knowledge so acquired is the knowledge Montaigne promised, the unlearning of servitude. The player who has learned to die no longer fears the bosses who rule the Lands Between, and the Tarnished who has died a thousand times is the only being in the world who can stand before its gods without submission.

The late medieval *ars moriendi*, examined in Chapter 3 as the tradition Fia inverts, offers an unexpectedly precise map of the dispositions the death-loop cultivates. The deathbed temptations it enumerated were five: unbelief, despair, impatience, spiritual pride, and avarice. They correspond with almost comic exactness to the five failures that the experience of a FromSoftware game repeatedly provokes and corrects. Despair is the temptation to abandon the game after the twentieth death. Impatience is the haste that throws away a careful approach for a reckless one. Pride is the overconfidence that follows a victory and precedes the next death. Avarice is the refusal to spend accumulated runes before a dangerous passage, so that a single mistake forfeits the hoard. Unbelief is the conviction that an encounter is unfair and cannot be overcome. The game trains the corresponding virtues: perseverance, patience, humility, detachment, and a trust that the impossible encounter will yield to attention. Whatever its designers intended, the loop functions as a secular *ars moriendi*, a discipline of dying well rehearsed by millions.

Albert Camus's *The Myth of Sisyphus* (1942) gave the modern imagination its figure for the endless return to an impossible task. The gods condemned Sisyphus to roll a rock to the summit of a mountain, whence it would fall back of its own weight; Camus found in the hour of his descent, when he returns to the rock in full lucidity, the triumph of the absurd hero, and concluded that the struggle toward the heights is itself enough to fill a human heart, and that one must imagine Sisyphus happy. The player returning from the Site of Grace to the boss who has killed them thirty times is Camus's Sisyphus, and the community's enduring delight in such returns is the happiness Camus asked us to imagine.

Nietzsche's thought of eternal recurrence supplies the larger frame. In *The Gay Science* (§341) a demon asks whether one would live one's life again, innumerable times, exactly as it was, and the one who can answer that nothing more divine was ever heard has attained *amor fati*, the love of fate. *Elden Ring*, at the end of every ending, asks the player whether to begin again: the world is restored, the demigods live, and the journey resumes as a second journey, then a third. The willingness of players to accept the offer, again and again, is eternal recurrence affirmed as play, and Zarathustra's cry, *war das das Leben? Wohlan! Noch Ein Mal!*, was that life? well then, once more, might stand as the motto of New Game Plus. Tolkien's Northern courage, the will to fight on against certain defeat, and the daily meditation on death that the *Hagakure* (c. 1716) prescribed for the samurai belong to the same family of disciplines, though the political uses to which such disciplines have been put deserve suspicion. What unites them, and what the game makes available to anyone who plays it, is the transformation of mortality from a terror to be denied into a practice to be learned.

8.6

TLÖN AND THE EXEGETES: THE COMMUNITY AS ENCYCLOPEDISTS

Jorge Luis Borges's "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius" (1940) imagines a secret society of scholars who, over generations, compose an encyclopedia of an imaginary planet, Tlön, so complete in its languages, philosophies, and sciences that its objects begin to appear in the real world, and humanity, enchanted by the rigor of an order human in design, gradually abandons reality for Tlön. On Tlön, Borges reports, there exist objects called *hrönir*, duplicates of lost things produced by the expectation of finding them: a pencil lost by two people is found as two slightly different pencils. The community of *Elden Ring*'s interpreters is a society of Tlön's encyclopedists. From the game's fragments it has composed, in wikis, video essays, forum threads, and datamined archives, a total account of an imaginary world, more complete than anything the game itself provides and increasingly authoritative in shaping how the game is understood. Its theories are at times *hrönir*, objects found because they were expected, lore produced by the desire for lore. This is not a criticism. Borges's parable concerns the power of human order to remake the world in its image, and the community's encyclopedia is a genuine work of collective imagination, a second *Elden Ring* written by its readers.

Umberto Eco's *The Open Work* (1962) described a class of modern artworks designed to be completed by their interpreters, works whose indeterminacy is not a defect but a structure, inviting each reader to perform them anew. *Elden Ring* is an open work in Eco's sense, and its openness is social. Henry Jenkins's account of fan communities as "textual poachers" (1992), who appropriate and rework the texts of mass culture, and Pierre Lévy's notion of "collective intelligence" (1994), a knowledge distributed across a networked

community and greater than that of any member, describe the institutions through which the game's openness is realized. The game is completed not by any single player but by a community whose members divide the labor of exploration, translation, datamining, cross-referencing, and interpretation, and whose collective work functions as the game's living commentary. In the terms of §1.2, the community reconstructs the lost Ur-text of Martin's mythology as philologists reconstruct a lost source; in the terms of §2.6, it emends a corrupt text.

Jacques Derrida's *Archive Fever* (1995) warns of a danger internal to every archive. The archive, he argued, is driven by the desire to preserve and to return to origins, yet it is haunted by the death drive Freud described, a destructive force at work within the very impulse to conserve; archive fever is a compulsive, repetitive, nostalgic desire for an origin that the archive's own structure forever defers. The Golden Order was an archive in this sense. The Erdtree stored the dead in its roots, conserving them so completely that conservation became indistinguishable from death. The community's archive, too, is susceptible to fever: the desire for a complete and final lore, a canonical chronology, an origin recovered without remainder, would reproduce at the level of interpretation the chrysopoeic dream of a perfect order. The hermeneutics the game teaches is otherwise. It is a reading that honors the fragment as fragment, lets the lacuna stand as form, and holds its reconstructions as provisional repairs rather than restorations.

8.7

THE TARNISHED AS READER: TOWARD A HERMENEUTICS OF PLAY

8

Hans-Georg Gadamer made play the clue to the ontology of the artwork in *Truth and Method* (1960). Play, he argued, is not the activity of a subject who plays but a movement to and fro that has its own essence and absorbs the players into itself; all playing is a being-played, and the players are not so much the subjects of the game as the medium through which it comes to presentation. Understanding a work of art is likewise not the mastery of an object by a subject but participation in an event that transforms the participant. *Elden Ring* literalizes Gadamer's analysis. Its player does not master the world as a subject masters an object; the player is played by it, absorbed into its rhythms of approach, failure, return, and recovery, until the knowledge of its spaces and its enemies lives in the hands rather than in the mind. Understanding arrives through repetition, and the subject who understands is transformed by the repetition, as the Tarnished is transformed by every death.

The figure of the player that emerges from this chapter combines the roles it has examined. The player is the reader of ruins, in whose gaze the Lands Between become legible as allegory; the excavator of the treasure of vanished peoples; the collector of ensouled objects and the necromancer of their owners; a member of a community of the dead whose traces cover the world; a practitioner of dying; and an encyclopedist of Tlön. Each role

shares a single structure. Each finds meaning in what has been broken, lost, or ended, and each produces understanding not by restoring the broken to wholeness but by reading the fragment as fragment. The hermeneutics of play is a patinal hermeneutics. It reads tarnish rather than removing it, and it understands the world through the marks that time, contact, and death have left upon it. Ruskin, who found the real light and preciousness of architecture in the golden stain of time, would have recognized the method.

8.8

CONCLUSION: THESE FRAGMENTS

T. S. Eliot's *The Waste Land*, which supplied the third epigraph of this thesis's first chapter and the governing figure of this one, ends with a heap of fragments in several languages: a nursery rhyme, a line of Dante, a phrase of the *Pervigilium Veneris*, a verse of Nerval, a cry from Kyd, and the sentence that names what the poem has done, these fragments I have shored against my ruins. The poem does not restore the ruins. It shores fragments against them, and the shoring is its form. The player of *Elden Ring* does the same. Confronted with a world whose order has shattered, whose history survives only in inscriptions on the equipment of the dead, whose ruins are the work of giants and whose meaning accrues in decay, the player reads, collects, summons, dies, returns, and shares, and from these acts composes not a restored whole but an understanding held together by its fractures. The world is given to the player as an archive of the dead, and the player becomes its keeper by learning, as Montaigne taught, how to die.

That learning has a final consequence, which Chapter 9 must face. At the end of the journey, the reader of ruins is offered the power Benjamin's angel longed for and could not have: to make whole what has been smashed. The endings of *Elden Ring* are so many answers to the question of what such wholeness should be. The hermeneutics of this chapter suggests the criterion by which they must be judged. A mending that erases the fragments would betray the only way in which the world has ever been understood.

HEW THEE TWO TABLES OF STONE LIKE UNTO THE FIRST · HEW THEE TWO TABLES OF STONE LIKE UNTO THE FIRST ·

CHAPTER

9

THE MENDING PROBLEM

A Comparative Morphology of the Endings

Hew thee two tables of stone like unto the first: and I will write upon these tables the words that were in the first tables, which thou brakest.

— Exodus 34:1

Aus Wunschheim zieh' ich fort,
Wahnheim flieh' ich auf immer.

— Richard Wagner, unset ending for *Götterdämmerung* (1856)

9.1

THE MENDING PROBLEM STATED

Every ending of *Elden Ring* begins in the same place. The Tarnished has gathered the Great Runes, entered the capital, kindled the Erdtree at the Forge of the Giants, slain Maliketh and released Destined Death, crossed the Ashen Capital, felled Radagon and the Elden Beast, and stands at last before the shattered body of Marika with the broken Ring within reach. Chapter 1 argued that this common road constitutes the game's invariant, the re-mortalization of the cosmos, and that the endings decide not whether death returns but what is to be built with a death that has already returned. This chapter examines that decision. It treats the endings not as a menu of outcomes but as a morphology, in the sense Goethe gave the word in *The Metamorphosis of Plants* (1790) and Vladimir Propp extended to the folktale: a family of variations upon a single form, whose differences become intelligible only against what they share. The shared form is the act of mending. The variations are answers to what this thesis has called the Mending Problem: given a shattered absolute, what kind of repair is possible, and what kind is right?

Six answers are available. In the outcome the community calls the Age of Fracture, whose achievement the game titles simply "Elden Lord," the Tarnished mends the Ring without amendment and ascends the throne of a restored Golden Order. In the Age of Order, the Mending Rune of Perfect Order conceived by Goldmask re-founds the Order upon a law purged of divine caprice. In the Age of the Duskborn, Fia's Mending Rune of the Death-Prince makes the dead Godwyn the sovereign of an age in which life and death are no longer held apart. In the Blessing of Despair, the Dung Eater's Mending Rune of the Fell Curse extends the curse of the Omens to all who are born. In the Age of Stars, the Tarnished summons Ranni, who carries the order away into the cold distance of the stars. And in the ending of the Lord of Frenzied Flame, the Tarnished, long since embraced by the Three Fingers, burns the world and its Ring together into a single fire. To these the expansion adds a seventh possibility that the game forecloses: Miquella's age of compassion, the order of compelled love that the Tarnished defeats in the Land of Shadow.

The preceding chapters supply five criteria by which these answers may be compared. The first concerns death: what each ending does with the mortality that has been restored. The second concerns difference: whether it preserves the plurality of beings, purifies it, or abolishes it. The third concerns the fracture itself: whether the repair conceals the break, dissolves the vessel, or keeps faith with both the vessel and the break. The fourth concerns divine presence: whether the ending restores a god, removes one, or makes one. The fifth concerns freedom: whether the order that results can be refused. Table 9.1 summarizes the comparison, and the sections that follow develop it.

TABLE 9.1

A comparative morphology of the endings.

AGE OF FRACTURE

INSTRUMENT No Mending Rune
DEATH Restored within the Golden Order
DIFFERENCE Hierarchy restored
THE FRACTURE Repaired, the break kept in the name
MESSIANIC TYPE Restorative
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION A mortal Golden Order

AGE OF ORDER

INSTRUMENT Mending Rune of Perfect Order
DEATH Restored but subordinated to law
DIFFERENCE Subsumed under a single law
THE FRACTURE Concealed in a perfected whole
MESSIANIC TYPE Restorative and perfectionist
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION Chrysopoeic

AGE OF THE DUSKBORN

INSTRUMENT Mending Rune of the Death-Prince
DEATH Enthroned and mingled with life
DIFFERENCE The dead included
THE FRACTURE Threshold abolished
MESSIANIC TYPE Restorative and utopian
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION Patinal, at risk of stasis

BLESSING OF DESPAIR

INSTRUMENT Mending Rune of the Fell Curse
DEATH Overshadowed by a universal curse
DIFFERENCE Abolished by universal degradation
THE FRACTURE Stain made universal
MESSIANIC TYPE Antinomian
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION Inverted chrysopoeia

AGE OF STARS

INSTRUMENT Ranni's ascension
DEATH Returned to the earth
DIFFERENCE Preserved by distance
THE FRACTURE Vessel withdrawn from the world
MESSIANIC TYPE Utopian
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION Patinal below, incorruptible above

LORD OF FRENZIED FLAME

INSTRUMENT The Three Fingers
DEATH Abolished in total burning
DIFFERENCE Annihilated
THE FRACTURE Vessel dissolved
MESSIANIC TYPE Apocalyptic
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION Annihilationist

AGE OF COMPASSION (FORECLOSED)

INSTRUMENT Miquella's charm
DEATH Unaddressed
DIFFERENCE Abolished by compelled love
THE FRACTURE Concealed by love
MESSIANIC TYPE Utopian and tyrannical
ONTOLOGICAL POSITION Chrysopoeic

a ring of repairs none of which is final

§9.8

9.2

RESTORATION, UTOPIA, APOCALYPSE: SCHOLEM'S TYPOLOGY

Gershom Scholem's essay "Toward an Understanding of the Messianic Idea in Judaism" (1959) distinguished three forces at work in every messianism. Restorative forces aim at the return of an ideal past, the re-establishment of a kingdom that once was. Utopian forces aim at a future that has never been, a condition beyond anything history has known. Apocalyptic forces, which Scholem regarded as the most explosive, conceive redemption not as the fruit of historical development but as a catastrophic irruption that breaks history off; there is, Scholem insisted, no continuity between history and redemption. The three forces are never found in isolation. The restored past is always idealized, and so already utopian; the utopian future always promises the recovery of a lost wholeness, and so remains restorative; and both are shadowed by the catastrophe through which they must arrive. Scholem added a warning that bears directly on the Lands Between. The messianic idea, he wrote, exacts a price: it compels a life lived in deferment, in which nothing can be done definitively, because everything waits upon a redemption that has not yet come.

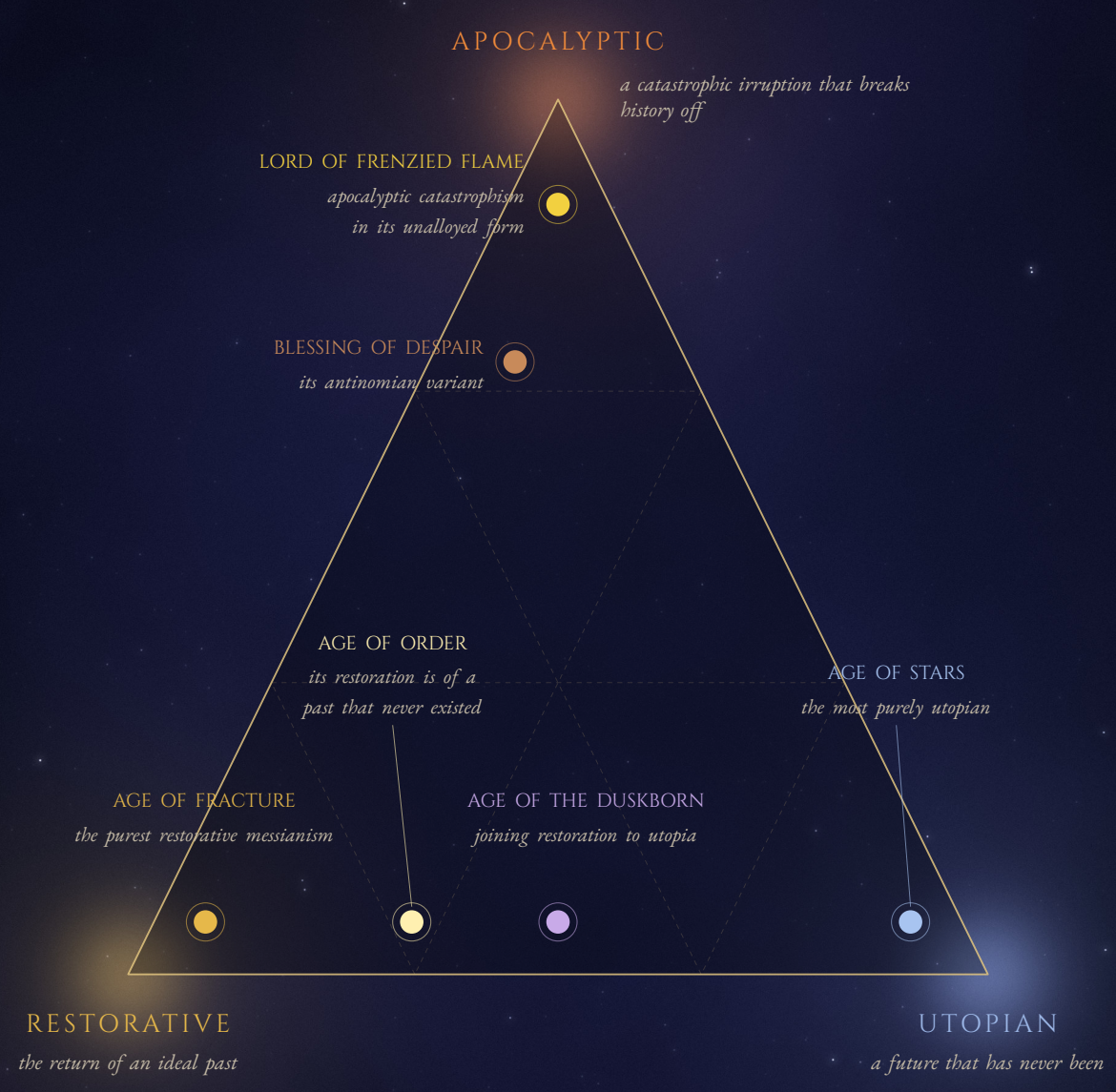
The endings of *Elden Ring* can be ranged along Scholem's spectrum with some precision. The Age of Fracture is the purest restorative messianism the game offers: the Golden Order re-established, its throne filled, its Ring made whole. The Age of Order is restorative too, but its restoration is of a past that never existed, the Golden Order as its theologians imagined it rather than as Marika ruled it, and it therefore crosses into utopia; it is restoration in Viollet-le-Duc's sense, the re-establishment of a completeness that may never have existed at any given moment. The Age of the Duskborn restores a dead prince and founds an age unlike any before it, joining restoration to utopia. The Age of Stars is the most purely utopian, an order without precedent in the world's history. The Lord of Frenzied Flame is apocalyptic catastrophism in its unalloyed form, and the Blessing of Despair its antinomian variant, the catastrophe that redeems by violating the law. Scholem's warning illuminates what all six share. The deathless world of the Golden Order was a life lived in perpetual deferment, an interminable present in which nothing could be done definitively because nothing could end. Every ending, whatever its type, ends the deferment. The restoration of death is the precondition of every messianic act, because only a world in which things end is a world in which anything can be done for good.

Walter Benjamin's second thesis on history introduces a qualification that suits the Tarnished better than any figure of the Messiah. Each generation, Benjamin wrote, has been endowed with a weak messianic power, a power to which the past has a claim; there is a secret agreement between past generations and the present one, and the dead await from the living a redemption that only the living can provide. The Tarnished is not a messiah. The Tarnished is the bearer of a weak messianic power, an exile who has walked through the archive of the dead, read its inscriptions, summoned its ashes, and inherited its claim. The

PLATE III

Scholem's three forces and the six endings

AFTER §9.2



The three forces are never found in isolation.

Every ending, whatever its type, ends the deferment.

endings are the forms in which that claim can be honored or betrayed, and the measure of each is what it does for the dead whose fragments the Tarnished has carried to the throne.

9.3

THE AGE OF ORDER: THE PERFECT LAW AND THE MACHINE WITHOUT ITS MAKER

Golden Order Fundamentalism, as Chapter 4 showed, discovered that its god was two, and concluded that the Order must be purged of the caprice her duality introduced. The Mending Rune of Perfect Order realizes that conclusion. Its age is an order grounded in law alone, in the Laws of Causality and Regression, freed from the passions and contradictions of any god. It is the most rational of the endings and, on its face, the most attractive to a modern sensibility: an order without arbitrary rulers, governed by principles that bind gods and mortals alike. It is also, on the argument of this thesis, the most refined of the chrysopoeic endings, because it seeks to make the law itself incorruptible.

Max Weber's diagnosis of modern rationalization supplies the first frame. The Protestant ethic, Weber argued, helped to build a rational economic order that, once established, no longer needed its religious spirit; the light cloak of worldly care that the saint was to wear became a shell as hard as steel, the iron cage, inhabited by specialists without spirit and sensualists without heart (Weber 1930 [1905]). The Age of Order is the iron cage of the Lands Between, a legal rationality that has outlived the charismatic will from which it arose and no longer needs a god. Hans Kelsen's *Pure Theory of Law* (1934) gave legal positivism its most rigorous form, a science of law purified of morality, politics, and nature, in which validity derives from a hierarchy of norms culminating in a presupposed basic norm. Carl Schmitt's rejoinder, in *Political Theology* (1922) and after, was that no legal order can eliminate the exception, and that sovereign is he who decides on it. The Age of Order is a Kelsenian dream with a Schmittian paradox at its origin. Its law would abolish the capricious decision of the god, yet it comes into being through a decision, the Tarnished's choice of a rune before the shattered Ring. An order without sovereign decision is founded by a sovereign decision, and the exception it would abolish is the act that creates it.

Franz Kafka's "In the Penal Colony" (1919) is the parable of such an order. On a tropical island, an officer demonstrates to a visiting traveler an execution apparatus designed by the colony's late Old Commandant, whose authority he reveres and whose drawings he guards. The machine inscribes upon the condemned man's body, with needles and over twelve hours, the commandment he has violated, and the officer insists that in the sixth hour the condemned, deciphering the script with his wounds, attains a transfiguring understanding. The new commandant disapproves; the traveler declines to intervene on the machine's behalf; and the officer, seeing that its day is over, frees the prisoner, lies down beneath the apparatus himself, and sets it to inscribe the words "Be just." The machine falls apart as it

runs, and instead of writing it simply kills him, and his face shows no sign of the promised redemption. Kafka's machine is law perfected in the absence of its maker, a mechanism that has outlived the will that designed it and promises a revelation it cannot deliver. Goldmask's perfect order is the Old Commandant's machine at cosmic scale: a law that would inscribe justice upon the world after its god has gone, and whose promise of a perfected order ends, if Kafka is right, in the destruction of those who submit to it. Hayao Miyazaki's Nausicaä, whose story Chapter 5 examined, confronts the same design in ecological form: offered a purified world engineered by the ancients, in which those now living could not survive, she destroys the machinery of purity rather than submit to it.

Plato himself, patron of the metaphysics on which Fundamentalism draws, regarded the rule of law as a second best. In the *Statesman* (294a–c) the Eleatic Stranger likens law to a stubborn and ignorant man who allows no one to act against his orders or to question them, even when something new and better has arisen; law speaks in universals and cannot attend to the endless variety of particular cases, which only a wise ruler could judge. Dostoevsky's underground man raised the same objection in the idiom of revolt. In *Notes from Underground* (1864) he imagines the Crystal Palace of rational utopia, in which every human action has been calculated and two times two will always make four, and he insists that a human being will smash it out of sheer caprice, to prove that he is a human being and not a piano key; what humans want is not advantage but independent volition, whatever it costs. The underground man defends precisely what Goldmask would purge: caprice, the unaccountable will that refuses reduction to law. The Fundamentalists diagnosed the Golden Order's catastrophe as an excess of divine caprice. The thesis of this study is that the catastrophe lay rather in the attempt to make anything, whether a god or a law, incorruptible, and that a perfect law is the Golden Order's error raised to its highest power.

9.4

THE DUSKBORN AND THE ACCURSED: ORDERS OF THE DEAD AND OF THE DAMNED

Fia's Age of the Duskborn is the only ending that takes the dead as its constituency. Its rune makes Godwyn, the first demigod to die and the half-dead source of the Deathroot, the prince of an age in which Those Who Live in Death are no longer hunted but welcomed, and in which the boundary between life and death, which the Golden Order guarded with such violence, is permitted to blur. Chapter 3 read the ending through the Egyptian enthronement of Osiris as lord of the dead and the Norse promise of Baldr's return, and through Bakhtin's image of a pregnant death in which dying and birth coincide. Its positive potential is considerable. It ends the Golden Order's persecution of the living dead, honors the dead whom the Order stored in its roots, and accepts death not as a defect to be sealed

but as a presence within life. Of all the endings it is, in one sense, the most patinal: an order in which the marks of death are worn openly.

The name of the age repays attention. Dusk is the hour between day and night, and in Japanese folklore it is the hour of uncertain identity, *tasogare*, whose old etymology was heard as *ta so kare*, "who is that?", the moment when faces can no longer be recognized; it was also called *ōmagatoki*, the hour of meeting demons, when the boundary between the human world and the world of spirits grows thin (Yanagita 1956). An age of the Duskborn is an age of permanent dusk, a world in which the hour of thin boundaries never passes. Japanese religious practice offers a contrast that clarifies the ending's risk. During the summer festival of Obon the dead return to their families, welcomed by fires lit at the gate, and at its close they are sent back with farewell fires and lanterns set upon the water. The dead are welcomed, but their visit is bounded, and the sending-off is as sacred as the welcome. The Age of the Duskborn welcomes the dead and never sends them back. Its acceptance of death therefore risks becoming a new form of the Golden Order's error, a world in which nothing finally ends because the dead never finally leave. Hegel wrote in the preface to the *Philosophy of Right* (1820) that the owl of Minerva spreads its wings only with the falling of dusk, that philosophy comes when a form of life has grown old. The Duskborn age may be the dusk in which the Lands Between at last understand themselves; or it may be a dusk that never becomes night.

The Blessing of Despair, examined in Chapter 7, includes the abject by universalizing it. Where the Duskborn age welcomes the dead as citizens, the Dung Eater's age makes everyone accursed. The two endings are the hospitable and the vengeful forms of the same inclusion, and the difference between them is the difference between Kristeva's abject embraced and the abject imposed. Giorgio Agamben, developing Benjamin's eighth thesis on history, that the state of emergency in which we live is not the exception but the rule, argued that the modern state of exception tends to become permanent and to reduce all citizens to bare life. The Blessing of Despair is the state of exception universalized: a world in which every being is the Omen, every life bare, every birth a sentence. It abolishes the injustice of the Golden Order's distinction between the blessed and the cursed by abolishing the blessed. Its equality is the equality of the camp.

9.5

DISTANCE AND FUSION: THE AGE OF STARS, THE FRENZIED FLAME, AND THE SCATTERING

The Age of Stars and the Lord of Frenzied Flame, examined in Chapters 6 and 7, form a symmetrical pair. Both abandon the Golden Order's presence in the world, and they do so in opposite directions. Ranni removes order to a distance and leaves the world to itself; the Frenzied Flame dissolves order and world together into a single fire. The one is

the only ending in which the world continues without a present god; the other is the only ending in which nothing continues at all. Ranni's ending is also, as Chapter 6 argued, the game's version of walking away from Le Guin's Omelas, a departure from a city whose order rests upon its basement. In Levinas's terms the Age of Stars is an order of separation and the Frenzied Flame a totality without remainder. In the terms of the Buddhist analysis of Chapter 7, the Frenzied Flame is the annihilationist extreme, while the Age of Stars, which restores the Aristotelian boundary between incorruptible heavens and a corruptible earth, returns the sublunary world to the middle way of arising and passing away.

Frank Herbert's *God Emperor of Dune* (1981) offers a parallel to the Age of Stars that also illuminates the Golden Order's whole history. Leto II, transformed into a hybrid of human and sandworm and ruling for three and a half millennia as an undying tyrant, imposes on humanity a stifling peace whose secret purpose he calls the Golden Path: to breed a humanity invisible to prescience and to provoke, after his death, a centrifugal explosion of the species across the universe, the Scattering, so that no single power could ever again hold humanity in its grasp. The Golden Path ends in the Scattering; the Golden Order ended in the Shattering. Herbert's tyrant intended his order's dissolution as its purpose. Marika's intention remains undisclosed, but the structure is comparable, and Ranni's age completes it: a dispersal under the stars beyond the reach of any single will, an order whose last act is to release the world from order. The Frenzied Flame is the Scattering's demonic counterpart, a dissolution that frees no one because no one remains.

The conclusion of Hideaki Anno's *Evangelion* stages the same choice at the scale of the human heart. The Human Instrumentality Project offers the merging of all souls into one; Shinji chooses instead a world of separate others, painful and uncertain. The Lord of Frenzied Flame accepts Instrumentality, and the Age of Stars, like Shinji's choice, insists on separation. But Ranni's separation is not only between persons. It is between the world and its gods, and it asks the inhabitants of the Lands Between to bear not only the pain of separate selves but the silence of a sky without a present god.

9.6

THE FINAL WORD: WAGNER'S TWO ENDINGS AND THE PLURALITY OF ENDINGS

Richard Wagner could not decide how his *Ring* should end. In 1852, under the influence of Ludwig Feuerbach, he gave Brünnhilde a closing speech proclaiming that neither wealth nor gold nor divine splendor, neither house nor court nor lordly pomp, neither the deceiving bond of gloomy treaties nor the harsh law of hypocritical custom, but love alone makes one blessed in joy and sorrow. In 1856, having read Schopenhauer, he replaced it with a speech of renunciation, from which this chapter takes its second epigraph: from the home of desire she departs, the home of delusion she flees forever; the open gates

of eternal becoming she closes behind her; and she goes to the holiest chosen land, free of desire and delusion, the goal of all wandering, redeemed from rebirth. He set neither text. In the finished score Brünnhilde's last words are briefer and less programmatic, and the meaning of the end is entrusted to the orchestra, whose final melody, often called the motif of redemption through love, rises over the ruins of Valhalla without the support of a doctrine. When he published the discarded endings, Wagner remarked that the music had made them superfluous (Wagner 1871–73).

The endings of *Elden Ring* reproduce Wagner's indecision as design. The Schopenhauerian ending, the closing of the gates of eternal becoming and release from rebirth, is the Frenzied Flame's, an end of becoming as such. The Feuerbachian ending, love alone as the ground of being, has its nearest counterpart in the Age of Stars, the only ending founded upon a marriage between two genuinely different beings, and its corruption in Miquella's age, where love is compelled. And the musical ending, the refusal to fix the meaning of the end in a doctrine, is the structure of the game itself, which offers six endings and declines to rank them. Where Wagner left the final word to the orchestra, FromSoftware leaves it to the player. The plurality of endings is not indecision but a formal claim: that the meaning of the restoration of death cannot be stated once and for all, and must be decided anew by each one who arrives before the broken Ring.

Other games have explored the ethical form of multiple endings, and two clarify what is distinctive in *Elden Ring*. Yoko Taro's *NieR: Automata* (2017) withholds its final ending until the player, assisted by the messages of other players, has fought through the closing credits themselves, and then asks whether the player will delete their own saved game in order to help a stranger reach the same end; the last word of the game is a gift of erasure to the community. Ice-Pick Lodge's *Pathologic* (2005; reimagined in 2019) forces its healers to choose between saving a town rooted in the body of an earth-god and saving the Polyhedron, an impossible tower sustained by children's dreams: tradition or utopia, the earth or the miracle. Both games make the ending a moral act rather than a reward. *Elden Ring* shares that conviction but organizes its endings around a different axis. Its question is not loyalty or sacrifice, tradition or utopia, but what is to be done with a death that has returned, and its endings are distinguished less by what they save than by how they mend.

9.7

THE AGE OF FRACTURE: THE SCAR THAT KEEPS ITS NAME

The ending that requires no rune is the most frequently reached and the most often dismissed. In the Age of Fracture the Tarnished mends the Ring without amendment and becomes Elden Lord of a restored Golden Order. Critics have treated it as the conservative default, the outcome of a player who has pursued no faction's design, a restoration of the regime that produced the catastrophe. The charge is partly just. The Age of Fracture

introduces no new principle; it restores the Golden Order's form, its tree, its throne, and its relation to the Greater Will. Two features nonetheless distinguish it from simple restoration, and both bear on the argument of this thesis.

The first is that the order it restores is not the order that fell. Destined Death has been released, Maliketh's seal broken, the Erdtree burned. The Golden Order of the Age of Fracture is a Golden Order with death in its law, which is to say, the Golden Order without its founding error. Its lord can be succeeded, because its lord can die; its dead can depart. It is, in Hobbes's term, a mortal god, the Leviathan as Hobbes conceived it rather than as Marika made it, and in Kantorowicz's terms it restores the distinction between the king's two bodies on which succession depends. The default ending is the re-mortalized Golden Order, and its conservatism is the conservatism of a regime that has accepted that it, too, will end.

The second feature is its name. The age is called not the Age of Gold or of Restoration but the Age of Fracture, and the name keeps the memory of the break within the order that repairs it. Rabbinic tradition, as Chapter 2 recalled, held that the fragments of the first tablets of the law, broken by Moses at the sight of the golden calf, were placed in the Ark beside the whole tablets of the second giving and carried with them (Babylonian Talmud, *Berakhot* 8b). The second tablets bore the same words as the first, as this chapter's first epigraph records; what distinguished them was not their content but the company they kept. The Age of Fracture is the second tablets of the Lands Between. Its law is the old law given again, but it travels with its fragments, and its name is the ark in which they are carried.

Shakespeare's *King Lear* closes with a comparable succession. The kingdom, divided by an old king's folly and devastated by the war of his heirs, passes at the end to Edgar, the legitimate son banished by his father's credulity, who survived by disguising himself as Poor Tom, a naked madman of the heath, the lowest of the low. Edgar returns from abjection to defeat the usurper in single combat, and in the Folio text it is he who speaks the play's last lines: that we must speak what we feel, not what we ought to say, that the oldest have borne most, and that we who are young shall never see so much, nor live so long. The Tarnished is Edgar, the exile who returned in the guise of the lowest, defeated the claimants, and inherited a broken kingdom with the memory of its suffering intact. Akira Kurosawa's *Ran* (1985), which transposed *Lear* to the civil wars of sixteenth-century Japan under a title meaning chaos, ends otherwise: the blind Tsurumaru stands alone at the edge of a ruined castle wall above a precipice, having let fall the scroll of the Buddha his sister gave him, as the sun goes down. *Ran* is the Shattering without a mending. The Age of Fracture is the answer *Lear* gives to *Ran*: not redemption, but succession, a kingdom continued by those who have seen the worst and do not pretend it did not happen.

9.8

CONCLUSION: SIX REPAIRS AND THE FORM OF THE WHOLE

No ending of*Elden Ring* fully realizes the fracture-faithful repair this thesis has proposed. The Age of Order conceals the break in a perfected law. The Lord of Frenzied Flame dissolves the vessel altogether. The Blessing of Despair makes the stain universal, the Age of the Duskborn abolishes the threshold between the living and the dead, and the Age of Stars withdraws the vessel from the world it was meant to hold. The Age of Fracture comes nearest, keeping the break in its name and death in its law, but it gives the old law again without transforming it, and its gold, though mortal now, is still gold. Miquella's foreclosed age would have concealed the break with love.

Yet the game does not offer a single ending. It offers all of them, and it offers them in sequence. A player who completes the journey is invited to begin again, and the second journey and the third can end differently; the six endings, together with the seventh the expansion forecloses, are accessible to a single player across the cycles of New Game Plus, and the community holds all of them at once in its collective memory. The work, considered as a whole, is none of its endings. It is the structure that holds them together, a ring of repairs none of which is final, each of which illuminates what the others conceal, and whose plurality keeps visible the fact that the Ring was broken and that no single mending can make it as though it had not been. Borges imagined in "The Garden of Forking Paths" a novel in which every alternative is chosen at once and every outcome coexists. *Elden Ring* is such a garden, and its form, rather than any one of its endings, is the fracture-faithful repair. The final chapter of this thesis takes that form as its object and attempts to state the patinal ontology it implies.

The work, considered as a whole, is none of its endings.

CHAPTER 9 · §9.8

THAT GOLDEN STAIN OF TIME · THAT GOLDEN STAIN OF TIME · THAT GOLDEN STAIN OF TIME · THAT GOLDEN STAIN OF TIME ·

CHAPTER

10

TOWARD A PATINAL ONTOLOGY

Kintsugi, Tikkun, and the Grace of the Tarnished

it is in that golden stain of time, that we are to look for the real light, and colour, and preciousness of architecture

— John Ruskin, *The Seven Lamps of Architecture* (1849)

Luḥot ve-shivrei luḥot munaḥin ba-aron.

— Babylonian Talmud, *Berakhot* 8b

10.1

THE ARGUMENT RECAPITULATED

This thesis began with a word. The protagonist of *Elden Ring* is named for the corrosion that noble metal resists, and the world into which it is summoned is governed by an order named for that metal. From this lexical antithesis the argument has unfolded a philosophy. Chapter 1 proposed that the Golden Order embodies a chrysopoeic metaphysics, the transhistorical will to transmute finite, mixed, and mortal being into an incorruptible substance, and that the Tarnished is the subject of a counter-ontology, here called patinal, in which being is constituted rather than degraded by the traces of time, contact, mixture, and death. It argued that beneath the game's divergent endings lies a single invariant: the restoration of death to the laws of the world.

Chapter 2 reconstructed a cosmology of arrivals and departures, in which order is imported into a world whose native condition is mixture, gods succeed one another by abandonment rather than overthrow, and gold is what remains when presence withdraws. Chapter 3 examined the sealing of death as an immortality project whose pathologies, the storage of the dead in the roots of the tree, the Tithonian senescence of the demigods, the foreclosure of succession, and the invention of social death in the figure of the exile, made the Shattering structurally inevitable. Chapter 4 read the identity of Radagon and Marika as a coincidence of opposites at the foundation of an order that proclaimed the One, and the Shattering as the self-fracture of a god. Chapter 5 traced the Golden Order's abjects, the Omens, the rot, the blood, the grafted, the accursed, and the compassionate tyranny of Miquella, as the return of the Order's own repressed substance. Chapter 6 found in Ranni's Age of Stars an ethics of distance, a god who withdraws so that the world may be its own. Chapter 7 analyzed the Frenzied Flame as the annihilationist extreme that answers the Golden Order's eternalism, and found in Melina's vow the claim that death is the guardian of difference. Chapter 8 argued that the game's form, its fragmentary narration, its archive of the dead, and its practice of dying, is itself patinal. Chapter 9 compared the endings as a morphology of repair and concluded that no single ending realizes the repair this thesis proposes, but that the plurality of endings, held together, approaches it.

This final chapter states the ontology that the argument implies, defines its ethic of repair, and draws out its consequences for theology, ecology, political thought, and the philosophy of games. It closes, as the thesis began, with the Tarnished.

10.2

PATINAL ONTOLOGY IN TEN THESES

Patinal ontology can be stated in ten theses. They are offered not as axioms from which the game is deduced but as generalizations from what the game has shown, each tested against its world and each answering one of the marks of chrysopoeic metaphysics defined in Chapter 1.

FIRST THESIS: BEING IS ALLOY. To be is to be mixed. The Golden Order treated mixture as contamination and purity as the measure of being, yet its purest lineage bore the horns of the Crucible, its god was two, and its gold was fed by the dead. Every being in the Lands Between is an alloy, and the Tarnished, whose body the player composes and recomposes from an open set of faculties, is the being that knows it. Emanuele Coccia's *The Life of Plants* (2016) has argued that the plant, which exists by immersion in air, light, and soil, discloses a metaphysics of mixture in which the world is not a set of separate substances but a medium in which everything is in everything else. The Crucible, the primordial matrix of mingled life that the Golden Order disowned, is such a medium, and its return in the blood of the golden line is the first lesson of the Shattering. I

SECOND THESIS: BEING IS ACCRETION. Identity is sedimented contact. A being is not an essence that time erodes but a history that time composes, and its surface is the record of its exposures. Riegl's age-value, Tanizaki's sheen of handled things, and the Japanese belief that objects acquire spirits through long use all express this thesis, and Henri Bergson gave it metaphysical form in *Creative Evolution* (1907), describing duration as the continuous progress of the past, which gnaws into the future and swells as it advances. The item descriptions of the Lands Between, the bloodstains of its players, and the inventory of the Tarnished are accretions in this sense. Nothing in the world is what it was made; everything is what it has become. II

THIRD THESIS: FINITUDE IS CONSTITUTIVE. Death is not a privation but a condition. It is the condition of succession, since a sovereign who cannot die cannot be succeeded; of history, since a world in which nothing ends is a world in which nothing happens; of meaning, since, as Heidegger argued and Borges imagined, an existence becomes whole and its acts precious only in relation to its end; and of grace, since grace, in Weil's physics, enters only where a void has been left. The Golden Order could not abolish the conditions of these goods without abolishing the goods themselves. Its world was not eternal life but deathless senescence. III

FOURTH THESIS: PLURALITY IS IRREDUCIBLE. The many do not return to the One. The Law of Regression and the Frenzied Flame, the Golden Order's highest theology and its most terrible heresy, share the henological desire that the many be gathered into unity, the one by reversion and the other by conflagration. Patinal ontology refuses that IV

desire. Alfred North Whitehead, describing the creative advance of the world in *Process and Reality* (1929), wrote that the many become one and are increased by one: every unification adds a new being to the plurality rather than abolishing it. Theodor Adorno, against the identity thinking that subsumes particulars under concepts, defended the non-identical and declared that the whole is the false (*Minima Moralia* §29; *Negative Dialectics*, 1966). The Buddhist middle way between eternalism and annihilationism, Levinas's separation, and Ranni's distance belong to the same refusal.

V **FIFTH THESIS: THE BREAK IS A DISCLOSURE.** A fracture is not an accident that befalls an order but the revelation of what the order was. The Shattering disclosed that the Golden Order's unity concealed a duality, that its incorruptibility was purchased by sealing, and that its purity rested upon the exclusion of its own substance. Every break, on this thesis, is a hermeneutic event that shows the seams that were always there. A repair that conceals the break is therefore not merely poorer but false, for it hides what the break revealed.

VI **SIXTH THESIS: REPAIR MUST KEEP FAITH WITH THE BREAK.** Mending is necessary, but not every mending is faithful. A faithful repair gathers what has been scattered, displays the break, transforms the repaired thing rather than returning it to a fictitious original, and carries its fragments with it. Section 10.3 develops this thesis.

VII **SEVENTH THESIS: GRACE IS GIVEN TO THE TARNISHED.** The power to renew an order comes from those the order excluded. The Golden Order's exiles, stripped of grace and named for their corrosion, are the only beings in the world who can receive grace again, because only they possess the void that grace requires. The theological form of this thesis is ancient, the stone the builders refused become the head of the corner (Psalm 118:22), and its political form is the homecoming of the outcast that, in the formula of Chapter 2, takes the place of the return of the god.

VIII **EIGHTH THESIS: ORDER MUST BE ABLE TO DEPART.** An order that arrives from outside a world, as every order in the Lands Between has arrived, must be capable of leaving it. The theogony of departures is not only a history of abandonments but a lesson: an order that cannot withdraw becomes a cage. Ranni's age, a withdrawal chosen rather than suffered, is the model of an order that honors the world by consenting to its own absence.

IX **NINTH THESIS: MEANING IS READ IN RUINS.** Understanding is patinal. The world is given in fragments, and its meaning accrues in decay; it is read allegorically, as Benjamin read the baroque, and it is learned, as the player learns the Lands Between, through failure and death. A hermeneutics that would restore the fragments to a final and complete lore reproduces at the level of interpretation the chrysopoeic dream. A patinal hermeneutics holds its reconstructions as repairs.

X **TENTH THESIS: DEATH IS THE GUARDIAN OF DIFFERENCE.** The last thesis gathers the others. Death individuates: it is the one thing no one can do for another, the

boundary that makes each life its own. An order that abolishes death abolishes the condition of the very distinctions it would preserve, and produces beneath its foundations the desire to abolish distinction altogether. Destined Death, which Melina vows to bring to the Lord of Frenzied Flame, defends a world of many beings against the fusion that would end their suffering by ending them. To restore death is to restore the world's plurality.

What patinal ontology is not should also be stated. It is not an aestheticism of decay, the *Ruinenlust* that savors ruin from a safe distance; its patina is lived rather than admired. It is not nihilism, for it affirms beings in their finitude rather than negating them. It is not relativism, for it judges repairs by criteria. It is a middle way in the precise sense the *Kaccānagotta Sutta* gave the phrase: between the eternalism of gold and the annihilationism of the flame, the path of beings that arise and pass away in relation to one another.

10.3

KINTSUGI AND TIKKUN: THE THEORY OF FRACTURE-FAITHFUL REPAIR

Two traditions, one Japanese and one Jewish, supply the elements of the ethic that patinal ontology implies. The first is *kintsugi*, "golden joinery." Tradition attaches its origin to a legend of the fifteenth century: the shogun Ashikaga Yoshimasa, having sent a cracked Chinese celadon bowl to China for repair, received it back held together with metal staples, and his dissatisfaction is said to have prompted Japanese craftsmen to seek a more beautiful method. Whatever the legend's truth, by the Edo period the rejoining of broken ceramics with *urushi* lacquer dusted or mixed with powdered gold had become an established art within the culture of tea, whose aesthetic prized the irregular, the worn, and the incomplete. In *kintsugi* the line of fracture becomes the most conspicuous and most valued feature of the vessel. Connoisseurs speak of the repaired bowl's new landscape, and a vessel may be esteemed more highly after its repair than before (Bartlett 2008). Yanagi Sōetsu, founder of the *mingei* movement, located the beauty of such objects in their irregularity and in the anonymous, humble labor of use that marks them (Yanagi 1972). *Kintsugi* does not restore. It transforms the vessel by inscribing its history upon it in gold.

The second tradition is *tikkun*, "repair," in the sense the Kabbalah of Isaac Luria gave it in sixteenth-century Safed. As Gershom Scholem reconstructed the doctrine (1941), creation began with *tsimtsum*, the withdrawal of the infinite into itself; the light that then streamed into the space of creation was received in vessels that could not contain it and shattered, scattering sparks of the divine into the lower worlds, where they were captured by the *kelipot*, the husks or shells of the demonic. The task of *tikkun* is to gather the sparks and raise them to their source, restoring the broken configuration of the divine, and Lurianic Kabbalah assigned that task largely to human beings, whose every act of devotion could liberate a spark. Later usage extended *tikkun olam*, the repair of the world, into an ethic of

social responsibility. *Tikkun* gathers. Its emphasis falls not on the visibility of the break but on the completeness of the gathering: no spark may be left in the husks.

Each tradition supplies what the other lacks. *Tikkun* without *kintsugi* risks becoming restoration, the return of the gathered sparks to an original configuration that erases the history of their dispersal, and in its Sabbatian inversion, examined in Chapter 7, it became a descent into defilement in the name of redemption. *Kintsugi* without *tikkun* risks becoming aestheticism, the beautification of a single broken object without concern for what was scattered beyond it. Fracture-faithful repair joins them, and it may be defined by four conditions. It gathers: nothing that was scattered is abandoned, and the fragments of the excluded are raised with the rest. It displays: the line of fracture is not concealed but made visible, and becomes part of the identity of the repaired thing. It transforms: the repaired thing is not returned to a fictitious original but becomes something new, bearing its history as its form. And it carries: the fragments accompany the repaired whole, as the broken tablets accompanied the whole ones in the Ark. Two errors define it negatively, concealment and dissolution, and the endings of *Elden Ring*, as Chapter 9 showed, exhibit both.

The world's mythologies preserve images of such repair. Plutarch relates that Isis, gathering the scattered body of Osiris, recovered every part but one, the phallus, which had been devoured by fish, and fashioned a likeness in its place (*Isis and Osiris* 18): the restored god is not identical to the god who was dismembered, and his body carries its loss. The Brāhmaṇas, as Chapter 4 observed, make the reassembly of the dismembered Prajāpati a ritual repeated in every fire altar, a repair that never becomes final. And the rabbinic tradition that the fragments of the first tablets traveled in the Ark beside the second, which this chapter takes as its second epigraph, makes the carrying of fragments an obligation; the Talmud draws from it the lesson that an elder who has forgotten his learning through no fault of his own must still be honored, for the broken tablets were kept with the whole (*Berakhot* 8b). A tradition that honors the forgetful elder for the sake of the broken tablets has understood that the dignity of a thing survives its breaking. These are the images in which fracture-faithful repair was thought before the Lands Between gave it a world.

10

10.4

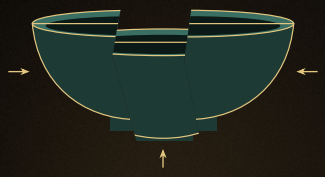
THEOLOGY AFTER THE SHATTERING

THE THEOLOGY IMPLIED by the Lands Between belongs to the long aftermath of what Nietzsche called the death of God, but it adopts neither the triumphant atheism nor the nostalgic restoration that this aftermath has produced. Its god did not die. She broke herself, and the higher will she served withdrew. Martin Buber's eclipse of God and Hans Jonas's God who renounced omnipotence so that the world might be its own, invoked in Chapter 2, describe its situation more precisely than Nietzsche's madman. Twentieth-century theology explored this territory under several names. Dietrich Bonhoeffer, writing from a Nazi prison

PLATE IV

The four conditions of fracture-faithful repair

AFTER §10.3



IT GATHERS

nothing that was scattered is abandoned, and the fragments of the excluded are raised with the rest.

IT DISPLAYS

the line of fracture is not concealed but made visible, and becomes part of the identity of the repaired thing.

IT TRANSFORMS

the repaired thing is not returned to a fictitious original but becomes something new, bearing its history as its form.

IT CARRIES

the fragments accompany the repaired whole, as the broken tablets accompanied the whole ones in the Ark.

TWO ERRORS DEFINE IT NEGATIVELY

CONCEALMENT

DISSOLUTION

in July 1944, imagined a world come of age that must live without the working hypothesis of God, and found in that world a God who lets himself be pushed out of the world onto the cross, weak and powerless, and who helps precisely in this way; only the suffering God, he wrote, can help. The death-of-God theologians of the 1960s, Thomas J. J. Altizer foremost among them in *The Gospel of Christian Atheism* (1966), read the incarnation as God's total self-emptying into the world. Gianni Vattimo's weak thought (1996) and John D. Caputo's *The Weakness of God* (2006) read the same kenosis, the self-emptying of Philippians 2:7 (*heauton ekenōsen*), as the secret of a faith after metaphysics.

Elden Ring contributes to this tradition an image none of its theologians supplied: a god whose self-emptying is a shattering, and whose shards are carried by an exile. Its theology is patinal in three senses. Its sacred is the worn rather than the pristine: grace returns to the tarnished, relics speak, and objects gain souls through use. Its god is a god who can depart, and the highest divine act it imagines, in the Age of Stars, is a withdrawal chosen for the world's sake, a *tsimtsum* performed in love. And its redemption is not the restoration of an incorruptible kingdom but the repair of a broken one by human hands, a *tikkun* that keeps the scars. Stated as plainly as possible, the theological claim of this thesis is that the Lands Between imagine a world in which the divine is present not as gold but as the golden seam: not in the unbroken surface but in the line where the broken has been joined.

10.5

ECOLOGY AFTER THE ERDTREE

The chrysopoeic dream has an ecological form, and the patinal alternative has ecological consequences. Environmental thought long organized itself around the ideal of an untouched nature, a wilderness pristine and pure, which human beings could only defile or, at best, restore. William Cronon's "The Trouble with Wilderness" (1995) argued that this ideal was itself a cultural construction, one that placed human beings outside nature and taught them to value only what they had not touched; Eric Katz's "The Big Lie" (1992) argued from the opposite direction that any restored nature is an artifact, a human imposition upon a world that cannot be returned to what it was. The two arguments converge upon the conclusion this thesis draws from the Lands Between: restoration to purity is impossible, and the attempt to achieve it reproduces the domination it would undo. The ecologists who now speak of novel ecosystems (Hobbs, Higgs, and Hall 2013), assemblages of native and introduced species in landscapes irreversibly altered by human action, have begun to think an ecology of the tarnished: one that accepts mixture, tends damaged places without pretending to return them to an origin, and values the life that persists in ruins.

The Scarlet Rot, Chapter 5 argued, is the form decomposition takes in a world that has abolished death: pathology rather than compost. Re-mortalization is the condition under

which rot could become compost again, the return of matter to the cycle of life that Donna Haraway's *Staying with the Trouble* and Anna Tsing's *The Mushroom at the End of the World* have placed at the center of contemporary ecological thought. Hayao Miyazaki's *Nausicaä*, whose heroine discovers that the poisonous forest is purifying the world and refuses a design to replace the contaminated present with a purified future, remains the ecological parable nearest to the Lands Between. The age of ruins that contemporary thought has named the Anthropocene is a Shattering of its own, and it tempts its inhabitants with the alternatives the endings of *Elden Ring* present: a perfected technological order that would master the damaged planet, a fatalism that would welcome collapse, an exodus to the stars. Patinal ecology proposes a further possibility: the tending of a mixed, damaged, and mortal world, gathered and repaired without the pretense of purity, its scars kept visible as the record of what was done.

10.6

SOVEREIGNTY AFTER THE SHATTERING

Chapter 3 argued, with Kantorowicz, that the abolition of death forecloses succession, and Chapter 2, with Hobbes, that the sovereign must be a mortal god. The political theory implied by the Lands Between begins from these claims: legitimate order is mortal, and its mortality is the condition of its renewal. Hannah Arendt's *The Human Condition* (1958) supplies the positive complement. Arendt argued that human beings, though they must die, are not born in order to die but in order to begin, and that natality, the fact that new beings are continually born into the world, is the miracle that saves the world from its natural ruin, because each birth brings the capacity for action, for beginning something new. Mortality and natality belong together; a world without death is a world in which beginning has lost its meaning. Arendt also identified the two faculties by which action is redeemed from its own predicaments: forgiveness, the remedy for the irreversibility of what has been done, and promise, the remedy for the unpredictability of what will be. Forgiveness accepts that the break cannot be undone; the promise binds the future without pretending to master it. Together they are the political form of fracture-faithful repair. And Arendt's insistence that men, not Man, inhabit the earth, that plurality is the condition of political life, is the political form of the thesis that the many do not return to the One.

Modern political life has produced institutions and monuments that approach this ideal. The Truth and Reconciliation Commission of South Africa (1996–98) sought to repair a shattered polity neither by amnesia nor by retribution alone but by the public recording of what had been done, so that the new order would carry the testimony of the old one's victims; its multivolume report is, among other things, an ark for broken tablets. Postwar European architecture produced monuments of the same type. At Coventry the ruins of the medieval cathedral destroyed in 1940 were preserved beside Basil Spence's new

cathedral, consecrated in 1962, so that worshippers pass from the shell of the old to the new; in Berlin the shattered tower of the Kaiser Wilhelm Memorial Church stands beside Egon Eiermann's new church; in Hiroshima the skeletal dome left standing by the atomic bomb is preserved as a memorial; and in Cologne Peter Zumthor's Kolumba museum (2007) rises from the ruins of a church destroyed in the war, its new walls built upon and around the old. These are works of *kintsugi* at the scale of cities. They do not conceal the break, they do not abandon the ruin, and they do not pretend that the new order is the old one restored. They carry their fragments.

The Elden Lord of a fracture-faithful order would rule in this spirit: a mortal sovereign in a world of births and deaths, exercising forgiveness and promise, keeping the record of the Shattering in the law, admitting the excluded, and holding power as something that will pass. No ending of *Elden Ring* crowns such a ruler. The game's morphology of endings, read as Chapter 9 read it, outlines the office by negation.

10.7

GAMES AS PHILOSOPHY, AND THE LIMITS OF THIS ONE

The final consequence concerns the medium. This thesis has read *Elden Ring* as a work of philosophical fiction in the lineage of Plato's myths, Lucian, More, Voltaire, Swift, and Borges, and it has argued that the game's philosophy is conducted not only in its narrative and cosmology but in its rules. Ian Bogost's procedural rhetoric holds that games argue through their mechanics; the argument of this thesis suggests a stronger formulation, a procedural ontology, in which the rules of a game do not merely persuade the player of a proposition but make the player inhabit a mode of being. The player of *Elden Ring* does not learn that death is the condition of meaning; the player becomes a being whose understanding is constituted by dying. The player does not learn that the world is an archive of the dead; the player becomes its archivist. Philosophical fiction has always sought to make its reader live a thought. The game makes its player embody one.

A doctoral thesis owes its object criticism as well as interpretation, and the limits of *Elden Ring*, measured by its own philosophy, should be named. The open-world form inherits a logic of acquisition and conquest that sits uneasily with patinal ontology: the map revealed and filled, the land traversed as a resource, the economy of runes harvested from the slain, the completionist drive to possess every item. The Tarnished's journey is, at one level, the journey of a conqueror who kills every sovereign and claims every treasure, and the game's celebration of mastery, its reward for the player who overcomes every obstacle, can reproduce the chrysopoeic fantasy it criticizes, the fantasy of a self made invulnerable by skill. Its aestheticization of ruin risks the *Ruinenlust* that savors catastrophe from a safe distance. Its multiplayer carnival, for all its wit, harbors cruelty as well as solidarity. These tensions are not so much failures of the work as conditions of its production as a

commercial artifact of an industry organized around consumption. But they mark the point at which the game's philosophy exceeds its form, and at which the player, like the community of interpreters, must complete the work.

They also mark the points at which the game, at its best, criticizes itself. The rune economy punishes avarice; the death-loop humbles mastery; the endings refuse a single triumph; and the most powerful figure in the world, the Tarnished, is defined by exile, corrosion, and repeated failure. The game offers its player the fantasy of becoming a lord, and then asks what kind of lord a tarnished being ought to be.

10.8

CODA: THE GRACE OF THE TARNISHED

At the opening of this thesis stood an Old English exile who waits for grace among the ruins of a hall whose lord is dead. Since then the argument has passed through a world of fallen gold: golden tables found again in the grass after the twilight of the gods; a thorn that pierces the hand of an immortal and announces, in a drop of blood, the return of death; a god who was two; a young woman who carries the rot within her and refuses to bloom; a witch who killed her body and carried her order to the stars; a maiden who chose one fire against another; fragments shored against ruins; and the tablets of a broken law carried beside the whole. Each of these images has figured the same truth, which this thesis has called patinal: that being is mixed, accreted, finite, and plural; that the break discloses; that repair must keep faith with what broke; and that grace comes to those who bear the marks of time.

The emblem of that truth is a tea bowl, cracked and rejoined with gold, its seams catching the dim light of a room such as Tanizaki loved, more precious after its breaking than before. The Golden Order wanted the world to be a bowl that could never break. The Shattering showed that it had always been cracked, along lines its gold concealed. The Tarnished, exiled for its tarnish and summoned back by a grace that could enter only where something had been lost, arrives before the broken Ring with the power to mend it. What *Elden Ring* asks, in the end, is whether the Tarnished will gild the world, laying over its cracks a surface of gold that time can never touch, or join it, filling its cracks with gold so that the history of the break shines in its seams. This thesis has argued that the second is the only mending worthy of a mortal world. Ruskin found the real light of architecture in the golden stain of time; the game finds it in the Tarnished. The incorruptible is uninhabitable, and grace is given only to the tarnished.

The Golden Order wanted the world to be a bowl that could never break.

CHAPTER 10 · §10.8

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KEYWORDS

Elden Ring; *Shadow of the Erdtree*; FromSoftware; Hidetaka Miyazaki; George R. R. Martin; chrysopoeia; chrysopoeic metaphysics; patina; patinal ontology; re-mortalization; fracture-faithful repair; alchemy; *nigredo*; ouroboros; *coniunctio*; *rebis*; Sol and Luna; *puer aeternus*; Golden Order; Golden Order Fundamentalism; Law of Causality; Law of Regression; Radagon and Marika; Destined Death; incorruptibility; immortality project; Tithonus; the Struldbrugs; the Makropulos case; Bernard Williams; Simone de Beauvoir; social death; Orlando Patterson; necropolitics; Achille Mbembe; Robert Pogue Harrison; Erdtree burial; Baldr; Osiris and Isis; *Epic of Gilgamesh*; Abishag; James George Frazer; *The Golden Bough*; the Fisher King; *Parsifal*; Númenor; the Gift of Men; *Sekiro: Shadows Die Twice*; Immortal Severance; Lurianic Kabbalah; *tsimtsum*; *shevirat ha-kelim*; *tikkun*; *kintsugi*; *wabi-sabi*; Tanizaki Jun'ichirō; Neoplatonism; Plotinus; Proclus; procession and reversion; *henosis*; Damascius; Nicholas of Cusa; *coincidentia oppositorum*; Ardhanārīśvara; the androgyne; Mitra-Varuṇa; the double; the shadow; Peter Schlemihl; *Die Frau ohne Schatten*; *Orlando*; *The Left Hand of Darkness*; Dark Sun Gwyndolin; the death of God; Puruṣa; Prajāpati; René Girard; mimetic violence; Messmer; the Hornsent; matter out of place; *Purity and Danger*; *kegare*; the Omens; Morgott; Mohg; the Formless Mother; *khōra*; the grotesque body; Mikhail Bakhtin; Bernard of Clairvaux; Malenia; the Scarlet Rot; *kusōzu*; compost; Donna Haraway; Anna Tsing; Godrick the Grafted; the albinaurics; the Dung Eater; Miquella; the Haligtree; the Grand Inquisitor; the critique of pity; the charismatic messiah; Frank Herbert; Griffith; Omelas; Quasimodo; Hayao Miyazaki; Ranni the Witch; the Age of Stars; metaphysical rebellion; Albert Camus; Radahn; gravity sorcery; astral fate; *heimarmenē*; Manilius; glintstone; the Primeval Current; Hermeticism; the *Poimandres*; Marsilio Ficino; Giordano Bruno; the Eternal Cities; Caria; Rennala; Tsukuyomi; Hecate; Blaidd; the Two Fingers; guardian angels; the panopticon; Immanuel Kant; enlightenment; Heinrich von Kleist; the marionette; the uncanny; Alexandre Koyré; the infinite universe; Blaise Pascal; Emmanuel Levinas; separation; Aristotle; the sublunary and the superlunary; the Three Fingers; Lord of Frenzied Flame; Shabriri; Hyetta; Vyke; Midra; the Dionysian; the primordial unity; the Nirvana principle; Human Instrumentality; *Hollow Knight*; *nirvāṇa*; eternalism and annihilationism; the Middle Way; dependent origination; *ekpyrōsis*; Heraclitus; Arthur Schopenhauer; Eduard von Hartmann; Peter Wessel Zapffe; Thomas Ligotti; pessimism; Melina; the kindling maiden; Brünnhilde; Iphigenia; the Fell God; the Godskin Apostles; the Black Flame; theocide; Xipe Totec; Marsyas; the Blessing of Despair; Søren Kierkegaard; demonic despair; *ressentiment*; Sabbatianism; redemption through sin; "The Colour Out of Space"; Michael Moorcock; Law and Chaos; *Shin Megami Tensei*; the Angel of History; the emblem; Andrea Alciato; *The Ruin*; *enta geweorc*; *Beowulf*; the Lay of the Last Survivor; Northern courage; Georg Simmel; *Ruinenlust*; Piranesi; Caspar David Friedrich; Zdzisław Beksiński; the epitaph; *tsukumogami*; the *Wunderkammer*; the collector; necromancy; the *nekyia*; asynchronous multiplayer; the palimpsest; marginalia; Michael Camille; carnival; *parodia sacra*; Michel de Montaigne; Seneca; Sisyphus; eternal recurrence; *amor fati*; New Game Plus; *Hagakure*; "Tlön, Uqbar, Orbis Tertius"; *brönir*; the open work; Umberto Eco; collective intelligence; *Archive Fever*;

Hans-Georg Gadamer; play; the Mending Problem; the Age of Fracture; the Age of Order; the Age of the Duskborn; restorative, utopian, and apocalyptic messianism; weak messianic power; the iron cage; Hans Kelsen; the pure theory of law; "In the Penal Colony"; the Crystal Palace; *Notes from Underground*; *tasogare*; *ōmagatoki*; Obon; the Golden Path; the Scattering; Wagner's unset endings; *NieR: Automata*; *Pathologic*; *King Lear*; *Ran*; Goethe's morphology; process philosophy; Alfred North Whitehead; Henri Bergson; duration; the non-identical; Theodor W. Adorno; Emanuele Coccia; the metaphysics of mixture; Yanagi Sōetsu; *mingei*; kenosis; Dietrich Bonhoeffer; death-of-God theology; Thomas J. J. Altizer; weak thought; Gianni Vattimo; John D. Caputo; restoration ecology; novel ecosystems; William Cronon; Hannah Arendt; natality; forgiveness and promise; plurality; truth and reconciliation; memorial architecture; Coventry Cathedral; Kolumba; procedural ontology; Gnosticism; alien demiurge; divine withdrawal; *deus absconditus*; eclipse of God; theogony of departures; Outer Gods; *nomos* and *miasma*; *Enuma Elish*; Tablet of Destinies; *Völuspá*; *Hávamál*; Yggdrasil; *axis mundi*; world tree; Ragnarök; Simone Weil; gravity and grace; decreation; Walter Benjamin; allegory; ruin; *Trauerspiel*; Ernst Kantorowicz; the king's two bodies; political theology; Thomas Hobbes; Leviathan; Carl Schmitt; constituent power; amendment and emendation; *hetoimasia*; Hans Blumenberg; theological absolutism; Lucien Goldmann; routinization of charisma; polytheism of values; the Golden Calf; sovereignty and succession; Ernest Becker; Martin Heidegger; being-toward-death; Philipp Mainländer; Georges Bataille; Julia Kristeva; abjection; Mary Douglas; Giorgio Agamben; *homo sacer*; Frenzied Flame; the Fire Sermon; death drive; Friedrich Nietzsche; Apollonian and Dionysian; Richard Wagner; *Der Ring des Nibelungen*; J. R. R. Tolkien; Ursula K. Le Guin; Jorge Luis Borges; Kentaro Miura; *Berserk*; *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind*; *Neon Genesis Evangelion*; *Planescape: Torment*; *Shadow of the Colossus*; John Ruskin; Alois Riegl; age-value; restoration theory; Paul Ricoeur; symbolism of defilement; ergodic literature; procedural rhetoric; ludic sublime; the art of failure; ludonarrative consonance; environmental storytelling; *meletē thanatou*; *ars moriendi*; liminality; Old English elegy; comparative mythology; philosophical fiction; dark fantasy; speculative fiction; game studies; translation and localization.